

The Ashen Chronicles, Volume IV: The Silent Accounting

Chapter 1

The water in Gloamreach tasted of iron.

Isolde Fellgard the Unforgiven let it sit beneath their tongue until the bitterness became a shape. Not blood. Not yet. Blood had warmth, even when it came from the dead. This water was cold and patient, carrying its poison through the body as though it had all the time in the world.

Beyond the shuttered window, the Pale Coast drowned beneath a colorless dawn. Fog pressed against the glass. It softened the walls, the watchtowers, the black ribs of the harbor, until Gloamreach seemed less a garrison than a thought someone had tried to erase.

Quarantined, the order had said.

The word was painted on the gate in white lime. It showed through the fog like a tooth.

Isolde lowered the cup.

“Again,” said Ossric Ashgrove.

The quartermaster stood on the other side of the chamber with a ledger tucked beneath one arm. No physical details clung to him in Isolde’s memory except the evidence of his office: ink-stained fingers, a measuring cord at his belt, the permanent stoop of a man who had spent too long bending over figures. His face might have been any face. His voice might have belonged to the room.

“I have tasted it,” Isolde said.

“You tasted the surface.”

“The surface is where men drink.”

“And where men die, if the poison has settled below.”

The cup remained between them. Its rim was chipped. Somebody had scrubbed it until the glaze had gone dull.

Isolde looked at the water again.

In 321 AS, the Purge of Blackport ended.

The words had been repeated so often that they had lost the texture of history and become a prayer spoken by people who feared silence. The Purge of Blackport began in 311 AS and ended in 321 AS. It caused 70,907 casualties. The aggressors were totally routed. The Iron-Ring Cartel emerged as victor.

That was the account permitted to survive.

The wells of Blackport had been poisoned by the victors’ own hands—by the Iron-Ring Cartel, who had poisoned the wells of their own allies. The concealed truth had outlived the men who carried it, as poison outlived the dead.

Ossric watched Isolde’s mouth.

“Do you feel anything?”

“Disappointment.”

His gaze flicked toward the cup. “That is not a symptom.”

“It is the only one I trust.”

The door behind him opened without a knock.

Ignatz Ashgrove the Oathless entered with the damp upon his cloak and the silence of a drawn blade. Warden-Commander was the title that followed him, though titles had a way of arriving before their owners and departing afterward. No physical feature of him had ever been established in the records Isolde had seen. He was authority without a face, a voice beneath a hood, a gauntlet resting on a table.

He carried no visible weapon.

That was the first weapon.

“Leave us,” Ignatz said.

Ossric did not move. “The report is incomplete.”

“It will remain incomplete if you continue to stand over it.”

“The eastern stores were sealed under your order.”

“And now they are unsealed under mine.”

Ossric’s fingers tightened around the ledger. He did not look at Isolde. He had been born in 333 AS, when the Ashen Era had already taught its children that survival was a form of accounting. Perhaps that was why he kept counting everything except the cost.

Isolde turned the cup in their hand.

The pale water made a skin around the blood drawn into it. A single red thread, no wider than a hair, wound through the cup and vanished.

Ignatz saw it.

His eyes did not change. That was how Isolde knew he had seen.

“Go,” he said to Ossric.

The quartermaster’s lips parted. For a moment, the room held the soft pressure before an argument. Then Ossric tucked the ledger under his arm and crossed toward the door.

As he passed, Isolde said, “Do not let anyone drink from the eastern stores.”

Ossric paused.

“I have already told the guard,” they continued. “If the order changes, verify the seal.”

“With whom?”

“Only yourself.”

His expression remained unrecorded, as all things about Ossric Ashgrove remained unrecorded. He bowed once, shallowly, and left.

Ignatz shut the door.

The latch fell like a verdict.

“You contaminate a quartermaster’s cup,” he said.

“I tested it.”

“You contaminated it.”

“Then you believe I possess a poison that can be carried in a drop of my blood and awakened by seawater.”

“I believe you possess many things.”

Isolde smiled without warmth. “You should. You sell intelligence to the Iron-Ring Cartel.”

The fog seemed to thicken against the window.

Ignatz’s silence was not surprise. It was calculation, and calculation was a kind of fear stripped of honesty.

Outside, the garrison moved through the morning. Gloamreach had a garrison of 2,483. The number had been etched into the command roll in a careful hand, as though precision could make the bodies less mortal. Two thousand four hundred and eighty-three soldiers behind gates stained by salt. Two thousand four hundred and eighty-three throats that might open for poisoned water.

“Careful,” Ignatz said.

“I am always careful.”

“No. You are aggrieved.”

“Those are not opposites.”

“Your grievance has made you ambitious.”

Isolde set the cup down.

The blood-thread trembled.

“You speak as though ambition is a crime.”

“I speak as though concealed betrayal is an unstable foundation.”

Their hand went still.

For one breath, the chamber became the room where their liege had died.

Not this room. Not this coast. But death had its own architecture. The same pause before the final word. The same disbelief in the eyes of the dying, as though treachery were a door that could not possibly open until someone opened it. Isolde had plotted the death of their own liege. The plan had been theirs. The silence afterward had been theirs. The grief, too, because grief was the mask betrayal wore when it wished to pass among the living.

Ignatz stepped closer.

“Your birth year is recorded as 286 AS,” he said. “You have carried the name Isolde Fellgard the Unforgiven long enough to mistake it for a sentence.”

“It is a sentence.”

“Then who pronounced it?”

“The dead.”

“The dead pronounce nothing.”

“They speak through what they leave behind.”

His gloved hand rested on the table beside the cup. “You have brought blood magic into a quarantined garrison.”

“I brought caution.”

“You are a Blood-Mage.”

“And you are a Warden-Commander. Neither title absolves us of thought.”

His head tilted. The Oathless epithet did not need explaining. It had settled over him like ash, marking the distance between command and devotion. He projected command undermined by secrecy, the distrustful atmosphere of an oathless guardian. Isolde could almost smell the lie beneath him: sharp, metallic, and clean as a freshly opened vein.

“Fenspire has sent a demand,” he said.

The name drew Isolde’s attention.

Fenspire stood in the Gloaming Reach, founded in 57 AS, its stark spire rising above the dim country like a spear driven into a corpse. It had a garrison of 3,742 and a garrisoned status that had never softened into peace. Its soldiers watched the roads, the marshes, the sky. Disciplined vigilance had made a home there.

“What demand?”

“That Gloamreach surrender its stores and submit to inspection.”

“Submit to whom?”

“To the Ashen Vanguard.”

“And the other powers?”

Ignatz’s mouth tightened.

The Ashen Vanguard gathered strength behind old banners. House Morvain weighed every crisis against inheritance. The Silent Choir listened where others spoke. The Iron-Ring Cartel bought what could not be conquered. The Bleeding Crown waited for weakness to become an invitation.

Five powers, each insisting the ruins belonged to them.

“Fenspire claims the coast is compromised,” Ignatz said.

“The coast is compromised.”

“By whom?”

Isolde reached for the cup, but did not drink.

“Ask Malchior Cindervale the Flame-Touched.”

The name entered the room like incense burned too near a flame.

Malchior Cindervale the Flame-Touched, Arch-Prelate, born in 289 AS. Sanctified authority strained by the pressure of concealed fabrication. Their lineage papers had been forged by their own hand. Isolde had never seen the documents, but they had seen Malchior defend them: each denial polished, each prayer

sharpened, each gesture placed with the care of a mason setting a stone over a grave.

“Malchior is not here,” Ignatz said.

“Then the demand is not theirs.”

“You think the Arch-Prelate has no reach beyond their own chamber?”

“I think forged blood travels badly through honest water.”

The corner of Ignatz’s mouth moved. It was not a smile.

“You speak in riddles when you want to be believed.”

“I speak plainly when I want to be obeyed.”

“And what do you want now?”

The question struck closer than he intended.

Isolde turned toward the window. The fog had begun to lift. Gloamreach emerged piece by piece: parapets slick with rain, narrow streets hemmed by quarantine cordons, the harbor cranes standing over the water like black gallows. Beyond them lay the Pale Coast, pallid and bleak beneath the whitening sky.

A bell sounded once.

Then again.

Not an alarm. A summons.

From the courtyard below came the scrape of boots and the murmur of men trying not to sound afraid.

Ignatz moved to the window.

“Who is arriving?” Isolde asked.

He did not answer.

“Warden-Commander.”

“Fenspire.”

The third bell had not yet sounded.

Isolde placed one finger into the cup. The red thread rose to meet it, eager as a living thing. The water cooled their skin. Somewhere beneath the fortress, behind locked doors and guarded stores, poison waited in the dark.

Or perhaps only fear waited. Fear had always been sufficient to kill.

The third bell began to toll.

Ignatz reached for the latch.

“If they enter,” he said, “you will stand behind me.”

Isolde looked at his back, at the authority he wore like armor, at the secret he carried toward the Iron-Ring Cartel with every breath.

“No,” they said.

He stopped.

Isolde lifted the cup and drank.

The blood vanished first.

Then the poison woke.

The poison woke as a white flare behind Isolde's eyes.

Their fingers closed around the cup. The rim struck their teeth. For one impossible instant, they tasted summer rain, cold and clean, and beneath it the iron-rich sweetness of their own blood.

Then the room tilted.

Ignatz turned from the latch.

"Isolde."

They heard the name as if it had been spoken from the bottom of a well. The chamber stretched away from them, its walls lengthening into black corridors, its candles burning with blue and crimson tongues. The third bell shuddered through the fortress. Its sound entered Isolde's chest and shook every bone.

They set the cup down.

It did not land. It seemed to hover above the table, held there by the red thread still coiled in the water.

"You drank it," Ignatz said.

His voice was careful now. Not frightened. He had trained fear out of himself, or taught it to wear a soldier's face.

Isolde tried to smile. Their mouth would not obey.

"Your concern wounds me."

The room folded.

They caught the table with both hands. Beneath their palms, the wood pulsed. Grain became vein. Vein became road. The old fortress opened inside the table: stairwells, sealed vaults, sleeping stores, the buried chambers where the dead had been bricked into silence. They saw the poison traveling through them as a dark rivulet, branching with patient purpose.

A killing draught did not need to hurry.

Nothing truly murderous ever hurried.

Ignatz reached for them, then stopped before touching. The hesitation was small. It was enough.

There, beneath command and ceremony, was the man who sold intelligence to the Iron-Ring Cartel. There, behind the Warden-Commander's stillness, was the hand that weighed every life against what it might purchase.

Isolde lowered their gaze to the cup.

"Did you expect me to let you drink first?"

"I expected you to stand behind me."

“You have a touching faith in my obedience.”

“No.” His expression tightened. “I have a use for your blood.”

The words were plain. The poison had made them beautiful.

Isolde laughed once, and pain opened beneath their ribs.

Blood answered pain. It always had.

A bead rose from the cut inside their cheek and hung between them, bright as a tiny red moon. Isolde drew it toward their tongue with the smallest command. The bead trembled, resisting. The poison had already found it. A dark filament ran through the red, thin and sinuous.

Their own blood had become a traitor.

They swallowed.

The chamber lurched back into shape. The table was a table again. The cup sat where it had been placed. Ignatz stood at the latch, his hand hovering near the iron.

Outside, boots struck stone.

Not the loose, uneven tread of men coming to arrest. These steps moved together. A disciplined approach. The sound gathered beyond the door, halted, and became silence.

Ignatz looked toward the threshold.

“Who comes?” he called.

A voice answered from the corridor.

“Open, Warden-Commander.”

Isolde knew that voice. Its warmth had once been used to bless executions.

Malchior Cindervale the Flame-Touched.

Their rival had arrived.

The poison withdrew from the edges of Isolde’s sight, not gone but listening. Their heart beat too slowly, each stroke dragging a chain through the body. They pushed themselves upright.

Ignatz’s eyes flicked toward them. “You cannot face Malchior like this.”

“I can face anyone.”

“That is not the same as surviving them.”

“Then you should have chosen a stronger poison.”

His jaw moved. Behind the door, the waiting presence remained perfectly still.

Malchior did not knock again. They never needed to. Silence gathered authority around them more effectively than any herald.

Isolde pressed one hand beneath the table. Their blood stirred in the veins of their wrist, sluggish and hostile. They searched it for the poison’s shape. The draught had been made to resemble weakness: a softening of the limbs, a dimming of thought, a gentle descent toward the dark. But beneath the false

gentleness lay a harsher design. It did not merely kill. It severed command.

A Blood-Mage without command was a vessel with a mouth.

Isolde breathed through their nose. Ash smoke. Wet stone. Wax. Ignatz's skin, sharp with old sweat beneath his uniform. The iron latch. The distant, saltless wind pressing against the fortress.

The world remained.

They remained in it.

That was the first insult they offered the poison.

"Open the door," Isolde said.

Ignatz did not move.

"You heard them."

"I heard a rival."

"Malchior Cindervale the Flame-Touched is not here for conversation."

"Neither are you, apparently."

A faint smile crossed his face. "You have always mistaken insolence for strength."

"No. I have mistaken your fear for loyalty."

The door opened.

Malchior entered without escort.

Their robes were dark, though the collar held a dull ember-red thread that caught the candlelight whenever they moved. Their face bore no sign of haste or effort. The name Flame-Touched clung to them like a verdict, not a title. Their eyes passed over Ignatz, the cup, the table, and finally settled on Isolde.

The Arch-Prelate's gaze was not merciful.

It was worse than that. It was attentive.

"Isolde Fellgard the Unforgiven," Malchior said. "You look pale."

"I have been told it becomes me."

"By whom?"

"People who wanted to see me die."

"Then you have received many compliments."

Ignatz shut the door. The latch fell with a heavy click.

For a moment the three of them occupied the chamber as if it were a board in a game whose pieces had learned to bleed. Malchior stood nearest the threshold, cutting off the corridor. Ignatz had the latch at his back. Isolde had the table, the cup, and their own treacherous veins.

Malchior looked again at the red thread in the water.

"The remedy has not taken."

Isolde kept their face blank. "You seem disappointed."

"I am observing."

"You forged your own lineage papers, Arch-Prelate. Observation must be a comfort when truth is unavailable."

Something moved behind Malchior's eyes.

There it was. The old wound, cleanly found.

They had been rivals before either of them named it. Rivalry was a kind of intimacy for people raised among knives. Malchior knew how Isolde lied. Isolde knew where Malchior's sanctity thinned. They had spent years circling the same locked doors, each waiting for the other to reach for the handle.

"Your condition is not a matter for wit," Malchior said.

"Neither is your lineage, yet you built an altar beneath it."

Ignatz stepped between them.

"Enough."

Isolde watched his hand. Not his face. The hand remained close to the short blade at his belt.

Malchior noticed too.

"Did you administer the poison?" they asked him.

Ignatz's gaze hardened. "You will choose your words with care."

"I have chosen them already."

The room tightened.

Isolde could feel their pulse in the poisoned blood. Each beat sent a cold pressure through their limbs. Their left hand had begun to numb. They flexed the fingers beneath the table, once, twice. The movement cost them breath.

Malchior saw.

Of course they saw.

"Your blood is closing around the toxin," the Arch-Prelate said. "Do not fight it directly."

"Advice from a forger."

"Advice from your rival."

Isolde drew in a slow breath. "You say that as though it grants you authority."

"It grants me knowledge of how you think."

"No. It grants you hope that you do."

Malchior came nearer. Their shadow crossed the table and touched the cup. The red thread twisted, reacting to them. Isolde felt the tug in their bones.

The poison had not been meant for an ordinary body.

Someone had prepared it with a Blood-Mage in mind.

Their eyes went to Ignatz.

He did not look away.

A sensation like laughter moved through Isolde, though no sound came. The betrayal was so complete it had become almost elegant. Ignatz had invited them into the chamber, placed the cup before them, urged obedience, and then acted surprised when they refused to play the victim in his little sacrament.

“You knew,” Isolde said.

Ignatz’s face gave nothing.

Malchior watched him now. “He knew enough.”

“Did he carry it here?”

“No,” Malchior said.

The answer struck harder than denial.

Isolde’s vision dimmed. The candles stretched into long golden wounds. Their knees weakened, but they locked them.

“Then you did.”

“I brought the knowledge of it.”

“How pious.”

“I brought a warning.”

“A warning does not usually enter through the mouth.”

“Not when spoken plainly.”

The Blood-Mage inside Isolde recoiled from the poison, then surged against it. Red darkness filled their vision. Their blood rose beneath the skin of their forearm in branching ridges. They saw Ignatz notice. Saw Malchior notice him noticing.

The rivalry between them shifted, found a new angle.

Malchior’s mouth softened.

“Do not command it yet,” they said.

Isolde’s heart gave a slow, punishing beat.

“Do not tell me what to do.”

“If you force the blood outward, the poison will follow it. You will empty yourself before you empty the draught.”

“Perhaps I am tired of carrying myself.”

The words escaped before they could be stopped.

Malchior’s expression changed—not into pity, never that, but into recognition. It was more dangerous. Pity could be refused. Recognition entered through every defense.

Ignatz moved around the table.

“Sit down.”

Isolde drew the blood from beneath their skin.

It came out in a narrow red line, trembling from their palm to the air. Pain sharpened them. The line bent toward the cup. The water inside blackened. The poison rose in a dark bloom, spreading through the red with hungry filaments.

Ignatz seized their wrist.

His grip was hard enough to bruise.

“Stop.”

Isolde looked at his hand.

Then at his face.

The blood in their palm tightened.

Ignatz staggered as his veins answered the pull. His fingers convulsed around their wrist. For the first time, command broke through his expression—not authority, not calculation, but naked alarm.

Malchior stepped forward.

“Release them.”

Ignatz’s eyes remained on Isolde. “They will kill themselves.”

“They may.”

“And you would permit it?”

Malchior’s gaze moved to Isolde.

“No,” they said. “I would permit them to choose.”

Isolde felt the poison waiting in the cup, felt their own blood straining toward it, and beneath both sensations felt something older than pain: the cold, deliberate shape of the lie they had carried toward their own liege.

The lie had once been a weapon.

Now it was a door.

They tightened their fingers around Ignatz’s wrist.

His blood answered first.

And somewhere beyond the chamber, the fourth bell began to toll.

The bell’s iron voice passed through the chamber and left the flame shivering in its dish.

Ignatz’s wrist was warm beneath Isolde’s fingers. Too warm. Blood-magic answered blood-magic, and the pulse under their thumb became a door whose hinges had been rubbed with salt.

They saw the first thing he had tried to bury.

A table in a room without windows. Wax tablets arranged in rows. A gloved hand turning them face down. The seal of the Iron-Ring Cartel pressed into black wax—not once, but again and again, until the emblem became a wound in the soft surface.

Ignatz recoiled.

Isolde held fast.

The image broke. Blood ran from his nose.

“You mistake knowledge for power,” he said.

“No.” Isolde tasted iron at the back of their throat. “I mistake secrecy for rot.”

Malchior moved nearer. Their robes whispered over the flagstones, pale as ashfall. The flame-touched scars along their throat caught the firelight and seemed almost deliberate, like script written by a careful hand.

“Isolde,” they said, softly now. “Release him.”

The plea was more dangerous than the command.

Isolde looked at them and remembered another document: a lineage unrolled beneath lamplight, its ink too fresh, its seals too clean. Malchior had forged their own lineage papers. The knowledge had lived for years behind Isolde’s teeth, a bitter coin they had refused to spend.

Until now.

“Tell them,” Isolde said.

Malchior’s face did not change.

Ignatz did. His gaze flicked toward the Arch-Prelate, and in that brief motion Isolde felt the chamber rearrange itself. Not allies. Not enemies. Compartments in a burning house, each waiting to discover which wall would fall first.

“Tell them what?” Malchior asked.

“That the blood beneath your name is borrowed.”

The fourth bell finished tolling.

For a breath, there was only the small wet sound of Ignatz’s breathing.

Then Malchior smiled.

It was not a forgiving smile. It carried the old sanctity of the altar and none of its mercy.

“You have always been theatrical when cornered.”

“And you have always called the knife theatrical when it reaches your throat.”

Ignatz twisted sharply. The movement tore skin beneath Isolde’s grip. His blood slipped across their knuckles, hot and bright. Isolde let it enter.

The second vision came with a taste of brine.

Blackport under a white sky. Wells ringed with iron. Bodies lying beside them, hands swollen, mouths darkened by whatever had been poured into the water. The Iron-Ring Cartel stood beyond the village

walls while its own allies staggered through the streets, choking on the mercy they had been promised.

The Purge of Blackport began in 311 AS.

The number rose inside Isolde like a dirge carved into bone: 70,907 casualties.

The Iron-Ring Cartel emerged as victor.

But the wells had been poisoned by the victors' own hands.

Isolde tore free from the vision. The chamber lurched. They caught themselves against Ignatz, and for one instant the Warden-Commander bore their weight.

His expression had become naked.

"You saw nothing," he whispered.

"Your masters disagree."

A cup lay overturned near the brazier. Poison gleamed along its rim. Isolde watched a bead gather there, tremble, and fall into the ash.

Malchior's eyes remained fixed on them. "You have opened a door you cannot close."

"I know."

"You think this absolves you?"

The word struck deeper than the poison waiting in the cup.

Unforgiven.

The epithet had followed Isolde through every court and chapel, spoken first as condemnation, then as warning, and finally as if it were a title they had chosen. Their hand tightened around Ignatz's wrist.

"I am not asking to be absolved."

"No," Malchior said. "You are asking to be believed."

There it was. The clean wound beneath all the others.

Isolde had plotted the death of their own liege. They had carried the plan like a coal beneath the tongue, feeding it with every humiliation, every order obeyed, every silence mistaken for patience. The lie had once been a weapon. Now it was a door, and behind it waited not freedom but the shape of what they had done.

"I am asking," Isolde said, "that no one here pretend their hands are clean."

A knock came at the chamber door.

No one answered.

The knock came again, quieter.

Ignatz's head turned. "Who is it?"

"Ossric Ashgrove."

The name entered the room like a draught from a crypt.

Ignatz's grip on Isolde's arm loosened. Isolde felt the change before they saw it: fear, quick and controlled, moving through him like a runner beneath ice.

"Quartermaster," Malchior said.

Ossric entered carrying a narrow iron case against his chest. He looked young enough to have been sent for errands and old enough to know what errands cost. No canonical mark distinguished him; the work had marked him instead. Powder clung to his sleeves. A thread of dried blood darkened one cuff.

He halted when he saw Ignatz.

"Commander."

"Put it down."

Ossric looked to Malchior.

That hesitation was a confession of its own.

Isolde released Ignatz. He stepped back, one hand pressed to his bleeding wrist. The blood on Isolde's fingers had begun to cool, but it still moved faintly, answering the rhythm of their heart.

"Open the case," they said.

Ossric did not move.

"Open it," Ignatz repeated.

The quartermaster set the iron case on the table. Three locks guarded it. He opened them with three different keys, each drawn from a separate pocket. Inside lay folded maps, ration tallies, sealed letters, and a single strip of vellum bearing the marks of five powers.

The Ashen Vanguard.

House Morvain.

The Silent Choir.

The Iron-Ring Cartel.

The Bleeding Crown.

Five names, five hungers, all pressing their fingers into the same corpse of a realm. The Ashen Era had left them ruins, and they had mistaken possession for resurrection.

Malchior reached for the vellum.

Isolde caught their hand.

"Not yours."

The Arch-Prelate's gaze dropped to Isolde's fingers. "You are becoming careless."

"I have spent years being careful."

"Since when?"

The question was mild. It struck like a hidden blade.

Isolde turned the vellum over. On the reverse, in a cramped quartermaster's hand, were dispositions and routes. Their eyes moved across the marks.

Gloomreach. Pale Coast. Quarantined.

A garrison of 2,483.

The number had been written twice, once in ink and once in blood.

"Gloomreach is sealed," Ossric said. "No carts enter. No carts leave."

"Yet this came from there," Isolde said.

Ossric swallowed. "It came through the coast."

"Which coast?"

"The Pale Coast."

The chamber seemed colder.

Far to the east, Fenspire stood in the Gloaming Reach, founded in 57 AS, its stark spire rising above the dim country like a nail driven through the sky. Its garrison was 3,742, and its status was garrisoned in every ledger that mattered. Vigilance made stone of men there. Permanent occupation made ghosts of them.

Isolde traced the route between the two locations.

"Why does a quarantine road lead to Fenspire?"

Ignatz said nothing.

Malchior did not look at him.

Ossric's hands folded over his stomach. "Because the orders were changed."

"By whom?"

He stared at the iron case.

"By whom?"

The quartermaster's mouth worked. "I was given the amended tallies."

"That was not my question."

"I do not know."

Isolde seized his chin and turned his face toward the fire. His skin was damp. Fear had a smell: sour wool, old coins, a door barred from the inside.

"Quartermasters know everything," they said. "They know which hungry men can be bribed, which officers count twice, which garrisons exist only on paper."

"I know what is written."

"Then read."

Ossric glanced at Ignatz.

The Warden-Commander had recovered his authority, though not his composure. "Read it."

Ossric unfolded the longest letter.

"Gloamreach," he said. "Two thousand four hundred and eighty-three assigned. Quarantine maintained. No transfer authorized."

"Again," Isolde said. "The number."

"2,483."

"Fenspire."

"3,742."

"And the amendment?"

Ossric's eyes fixed on the page. "A shipment of blood-salt, lamp oil, and sealed arms diverted from Gloamreach to Fenspire."

"Under whose seal?"

He stopped.

The silence lengthened until the fire gave a wet pop.

"Under whose seal?"

Ossric looked at Malchior.

The Arch-Prelate's face had gone very still.

"Do not," Malchior said.

The quartermaster lowered his head. "The seal of the Ashen Vanguard."

Ignatz laughed once. It was a small, empty sound.

"Forged," Malchior said.

"Perhaps," Isolde replied.

The letter slipped from Ossric's fingers.

Beneath it lay a thinner strip of vellum, folded around a sliver of bone. Isolde picked it up. The blood in their veins stirred before the parchment touched their skin.

A command had been written there in a hand they knew.

Their own.

Not the hand they used now. An older hand, sharper, disciplined into obedience. The writing named no person. It required only that a door be opened, a guard withdrawn, a cup carried into a private chamber.

The hour of the attempt had been left blank.

Isolde knew the rest.

They had plotted the death of their own liege. Not dreamed it. Not desired it in the dark recesses of grievance. Plotted it. Given the lie a spine, a route, a final mouthful.

Malchior saw recognition cross their face.

“There,” they whispered. “Now you understand.”

Isolde folded the strip of vellum once.

“What do I understand?”

“That the Cartel did not come to buy Ignatz’s intelligence.”

Ignatz’s eyes hardened. “Careful.”

“They came to buy mine.”

The flame in the brazier bent toward the iron case.

Outside, the next bell began to toll—but this one faltered after the first strike, as though the hand that sounded it had been seized.

Ossric looked toward the door.

Something scraped along the other side.

Malchior stepped back from the table. Ignatz’s hand went to his weapon.

Isolde felt the old lie open completely.

On the far side of the door, someone began to whisper their name.

Chapter 2

Greyfell Citadel had been abandoned long enough for silence to become its sovereign.

It lay in the Shattered Vale beneath a sky the color of old iron, its towers broken into blunt teeth, its courtyards drowned in ash and thorn. Wind moved through the arrow slits with a low, patient breath. Morwenna Ashgrove stood upon the western battlement and watched it worry the banners nailed there by hands long dead.

No device marked her station. No escort waited behind her. A Fleet Admiral did not require an audience to remain a Fleet Admiral. Authority clung more stubbornly than cloth.

Below, the inner ward descended into shadow. A lantern burned beside the gatehouse, its flame bent sideways by the wind. Caedmon Fellgard sat beneath it with his writing board upon his knees, shoulders bowed in the disciplined posture of a Scribe. He had been recording the arrival of every cart, every sealed case, every servant who had crossed the stones. His pen moved without haste.

Morwenna envied him.

A record could be trusted to lie only when someone touched it.

Her gloved hand closed around the edge of the parapet. The stone was cold enough to ache through leather. She had been born in 288 AS, when Greyfell Citadel was already old enough to be treated as a warning rather than a fortress. She had learned early that ruin did not make a place harmless. Ruin merely removed the witnesses.

Behind her, a door groaned open.

“Admiral.”

Sabelle Mournvale the Twice-Crowned entered the battlement walk with the stillness of a blade being drawn. The two crowns worked into their insignia caught what little light remained and gave it back without warmth. As High Inquisitor, Sabelle carried severity like a second skin. Rain silvered the dark hem of their coat.

Morwenna did not turn at once. “You are late.”

“I was detained.”

“By what?”

Sabelle’s pause was small. It had the weight of a stone dropped into deep water.

“Paperwork.”

Caedmon looked up from below, then lowered his eyes again. He had heard the answer. He would write nothing of it. That, Morwenna thought, was the first honest thing about him.

Sabelle came to stand beside her. “The Pale Coast has sent another petition.”

“Palewell Abbey?”

“The name is upon it.”

“Palewell Abbey sends petitions whenever it wishes to remind the realm that it still exists.”

“It was founded in 244 AS. It has been rebuilt. It maintains a garrison of 5998. Such a place is entitled to remind us.”

“Entitled,” Morwenna said, “is a word used by people who have counted their walls.”

Below, Caedmon dipped his pen. The scratch carried upward through the ruin.

Sabelle watched the dark horizon. “Palewell Abbey is not a core holding.”

“Neither is Greyfell Citadel.”

“Greyfell Citadel is abandoned.”

“Then it has the advantage of not disappointing anyone.”

The High Inquisitor’s mouth tightened. Not a smile. Sabelle did not waste expressions. Morwenna had seen them question men until confession seemed like a mercy, had watched them stand beneath the Bleeding Crown’s black standards without bowing farther than duty required. There was always something withheld in Sabelle’s severity, something damp and breathing beneath the floorboards.

Morwenna had once heard a sound beneath the chambers where Sabelle kept their private records.

A dragging.

A pause.

Then three knocks from the other side of a locked door.

She had not asked.

Some secrets were safer when left without a shape.

Sabelle held out a sealed strip of grey wax. “The Ashen Vanguard has moved provisions north.”

“How many?”

The High Inquisitor looked at her.

Morwenna let the question die between them. “You know I dislike incomplete reports.”

“I know you dislike being seen to ask for them.”

The wind pressed their coats against their legs. Somewhere in the citadel, loose masonry fell with a muffled crash.

Morwenna took the strip. “And House Morvain?”

“Quiet.”

“Quiet is not an answer.”

“It is the answer they have chosen.”

“And the Silent Choir?”

“Quieter.”

Morwenna broke the seal with her thumb. The parchment inside was thin, expensive, and written in a cipher she knew better than the hand that had copied it. A convoy route. A watch rotation. The hour at which a river gate would be opened to admit grain.

The information had passed through three hands before reaching her. She had made certain of that. The Iron-Ring Cartel preferred its secrets wrapped in other people's fingerprints.

Sabelle watched her read. "You look disappointed."

"I expected more."

"From the Ashen Vanguard?"

"From the dead."

"The dead are unreliable."

"Not when properly accounted for."

Caedmon rose from the gatehouse and approached with his board held against his chest. His face remained lowered. The wind had filled his sleeves with cold, and the ink on his fingers had run into the creases of his skin.

"Admiral," he said. "The final inventory."

"Read it."

Caedmon glanced at Sabelle before obeying. "Three cases of salt. Two cases of lamp oil. One iron coffer. Four sealed packets. No visible arms. No declared passengers."

"Declared," Sabelle murmured.

Caedmon's pen hovered.

Morwenna looked down at him. "Record the word as spoken."

"Yes, Admiral."

The Scribe bent over his page again.

The iron coffer stood beneath a canvas in the lower yard. Its corners were banded in dull metal, its locks hidden. Morwenna had not opened it. She did not need to. The Cartel's messages rarely arrived alone. Coin traveled with them, sometimes in ingots, sometimes in little stamped discs that could be melted down without loss.

This time, she had asked for no payment.

That was the danger.

Coin made a transaction. Favors made a chain.

Sabelle turned toward the stair. "You should see what was found in the chapel."

"I have no interest in chapels."

"It is not a chapel anymore."

"Then I have even less."

The High Inquisitor descended without waiting. Morwenna remained upon the battlement, the Cartel's intelligence folded inside her glove. The paper warmed against her palm. It seemed indecently alive.

The Leaden Accord had begun in 330 AS and ended in 342 AS with 14,011 casualties. Both hosts had been destroyed by a Ley-storm, and the realm had been given a victor because realms preferred a clean word to a graveyard.

The record named the victor: The Iron-Ring Cartel.

Morwenna had read that sentence in ledgers, proclamations, military histories, and the private memoranda of men who believed history was a weapon they could aim. Every version polished the same lie until it shone. Victory. As if the storm had saluted. As if the ruined hosts had left behind a crown for someone to wear.

Beneath the words, beneath the ash and the melted banners, something supposedly destroyed had been spirited away.

She did not know where it was.

That was why the Cartel paid her.

Or why it would, if they learned how close she had come to learning.

Morwenna descended into the keep. The stairwell smelled of wet stone and old soot. Her boots rang once, then the sound was swallowed by the walls. At the bottom, Sabelle waited before the chapel doors.

They had been stripped of their hinges. Inside, the altar had been overturned and the floor opened in a neat square. Black steps descended into the earth.

Morwenna stopped.

“What was found?” she asked.

Sabelle’s gaze remained on the darkness below. “A binding.”

“Whose?”

“A careful question.”

“I am surrounded by careful questions.”

“Then you may recognize the work.”

A sound came from beneath the floor.

Metal scraped stone.

Caedmon, behind them, made a small involuntary noise. His pen fell from his hand and rolled across the threshold.

Sabelle did not react. “You will not record this.”

Morwenna looked at them. “That is not how records work.”

“It is precisely how records work. They preserve what is permitted to survive.”

Another scrape. Slower this time. A wet exhalation rose from the stairwell, carrying the stink of grave-soil and extinguished candles.

Morwenna thought of the message in her glove. The river gate. The provisions. A route that could starve one faction, enrich another, and make a third believe itself clever. She had sold such fragments for years,

never enough to topple a power, never so little that the Cartel forgot her name.

But Sabelle knew.

Perhaps they had always known.

“Your cellar,” Morwenna said.

The High Inquisitor looked at her then. “You have been curious.”

“I have been observant.”

“Curiosity wears a softer face.”

From below came three knocks.

The sound traveled through Morwenna’s bones.

Sabelle stepped aside, revealing the stair. “There is something you should understand about loyalty.”

Morwenna did not move. “I understand that it is a word people invoke after they have exhausted their evidence.”

“Loyalty is not devotion. It is the choice of which ruin one is willing to stand inside.”

“And which ruin have you chosen?”

Sabelle’s eyes lowered to the paper hidden in Morwenna’s glove, though they could not see it. “That depends on what you intend to do with what you have been given.”

The wind found the ruined chapel and moaned through it. Caedmon bent to retrieve his pen, his hands trembling now. Morwenna watched him wipe the nib clean against his sleeve. Even frightened, he protected the instrument before himself.

A useful instinct.

She drew the parchment from her glove and held it between two fingers. The cipher marks seemed to shift in the lantern light.

“The Iron-Ring Cartel has purchased a passage,” she said.

Sabelle did not ask how she knew.

“Where?”

Morwenna folded the message once. “You are not the only one who keeps things beneath the floor.”

For the first time, Sabelle’s composure cracked. Not fear. Recognition.

The sound below ceased.

In the silence that followed, something drew breath.

Morwenna heard Caedmon whisper her title. She heard Sabelle’s hand close around the hilt beneath their coat. She heard, far beyond the chapel and the broken walls, the first mutter of thunder rolling over the Shattered Vale.

Then the cellar door beneath them began to open.

The cellar door opened inward by the width of a hand.

A smell rose through the gap—not rot, precisely, but the mineral cold of a tomb opened after a long burial. It touched Morwenna’s tongue. The lantern flame drew thin and blue.

Caedmon made a small sound behind her. His breath caught as if a fist had closed around it.

Sabelle did not move.

The High Inquisitor’s hand remained beneath their coat, fingers curled around the hilt there. The two crowns—one wrought of blackened metal, the other pale as old bone—cast no gleam in the lantern light. They seemed less like ornaments than wounds that had hardened above the brow.

“Stand aside,” Sabelle said.

Morwenna watched the darkness below. “You have not told me what is in there.”

“I told you enough.”

“No.” Her voice stayed level. “You told me there was a passage. That is not the same thing.”

Something shifted beneath the chapel. Not footsteps. The dragging of weight that had forgotten how to belong to a living body.

Caedmon’s quill case knocked against the stones as he backed away. “High Inquisitor.”

“Be silent, Scribe.”

The door opened farther.

A hand appeared on the stair.

It was grey, jointed, and narrow. The nails had been pared to the quick. Black thread had been wound around each finger, crossing the knuckles in intricate knots. The hand gripped the edge of the door, and the wood groaned beneath its strength.

Morwenna had seen men dragged from waters gone black with stormlight. She had seen flesh burned smooth by the Ley-storms that had ended the Leaden Accord. She had watched officers smile while blood ran from their ears, because discipline was sometimes only the art of dying without inconveniencing the living.

This was different.

The thing below was not dying.

It had finished.

“Sabelle,” she said.

The High Inquisitor’s face did not change, but the lantern caught a tremor in their jaw. “Do not draw steel.”

“Then you should have brought a lock.”

“I brought a command.”

The hand withdrew.

A figure climbed into view.

It wore a coat of dark cloth stiff with dust. The garment had once been cut for a human frame, though nothing in the shoulders moved as a human shoulder moved. The head hung forward. A strip of pale binding covered the mouth, its edges darkened where old moisture had soaked through. More strips crossed the throat and disappeared beneath the collar.

The revenant paused on the last step.

Its eyes were open.

There was no color in them. Only a dull, wet sheen, like ice beneath a winter moon.

Caedmon's breathing became a prayer without words.

Morwenna felt the old, familiar instinct to measure a threat: distance, exits, weapons, the weight of the door, the number of bodies between herself and the nearest open ground. The chapel had one entrance above, one broken arch beyond the altar, and a cellar door now occupied by the dead. Sabelle stood between the revenant and the room. Caedmon stood behind Morwenna, which was either courage or an inability to choose a better place.

The revenant turned its head toward her.

The motion came too quickly.

Morwenna's hand went to the pistol beneath her coat, though she knew the weapon would be a gesture, not a solution. The revenant's gaze settled on the iron clasp at her throat—the insignia of her station, worn dull beneath the grime of the road.

“Fleet Admiral,” it said.

Its voice was muffled by the binding. The words seemed to come from the stone as much as from its mouth.

Caedmon stared.

Sabelle's command struck the room like a snapped chain. “Kneel.”

The revenant remained standing.

For one breath, Morwenna thought Sabelle had lost control of it.

Then the dead thing lowered itself.

Not gracefully. Not with obedience. Its knees folded in opposite directions, and its body descended with a wet crack. It ended on one knee, head bowed.

Sabelle exhaled through their nose.

Morwenna looked at the binding around its mouth. “It speaks.”

“When permitted.”

“It knew my rank.”

“It remembers what it was taught.”

“What was it?”

Sabelle's eyes cut toward her. “You are asking questions as though you intend to write the answers down.”

“I am asking questions because it is in the room.”

“Then ask better ones.”

The revenant lifted its head. Its gaze passed over Sabelle and returned to Morwenna.

“Cold,” it whispered.

The word crawled under Morwenna’s skin.

Sabelle stepped closer to it. “What did you hear?”

The dead thing’s head tilted.

“Beneath,” it said.

“What?”

“Water. Bells. A door without hinges.”

Caedmon’s fingers closed around the chain at his throat. “There are no bells here.”

“There are always bells,” said the revenant.

Thunder rolled above the chapel. Dust loosened from the rafters and fell through the lantern glow.

Morwenna glanced toward the broken windows. The storm had drawn nearer. Through the gaps in the walls, the Shattered Vale showed itself in brief white flashes: splintered ridges, dead grass bent flat, the skeletal towers of the abandoned Greyfell Citadel in the far distance. The lightning made the ruin seem to breathe.

Her attention returned to the cellar.

“You said the Iron-Ring Cartel has purchased a passage,” she said.

Sabelle did not look at her. “I said you were not the only one who keeps things beneath the floor.”

“And this is what you keep?”

The revenant’s fingers twitched against the stones.

Sabelle’s silence answered.

Morwenna felt the message in her coat press against her ribs. A few folded lines. A route. A price. Enough intelligence to move men and goods through the Vale without the knowledge of those who believed their walls still possessed meaning.

She had sold lesser things for more.

The Cartel did not buy loyalty. It bought the shape of a person’s hunger and placed a coin inside it.

“What passage?” she asked.

Sabelle’s eyes hardened. “You already know.”

“I know someone has paid for access. I do not know what they intend to carry through it.”

“Perhaps they intend to carry you.”

“Then they should have paid for a wider passage.”

Caedmon looked from one of them to the other. His face had the waxen pallor of a man realizing that the record he kept might someday be used against him. Morwenna wondered what he had written before the door opened. Names, perhaps. Accusations. The careful architecture of obedience.

Sabelle turned to him. "Take the lantern."

He flinched. "High Inquisitor?"

"Take it."

Caedmon obeyed. His hand shook as he lifted the lantern from its hook. Shadows climbed the chapel walls. The revenant's shadow did not move with it. It remained crouched on the floor, head bowed, a second corpse kneeling beneath the first.

Sabelle descended one step.

The cellar below seemed impossibly deep. The stair vanished into a blackness that absorbed the lantern's light rather than reflecting it. Morwenna could see old shelving, a hanging chain, the glint of something metallic laid upon a stone table.

A narrow case.

Its lid was open.

Inside lay a length of white metal wrapped in dark cloth. Frost feathered the exposed edges of the lining. The cold coming from it was clean and absolute. It drove the cellar's damp smell away and left only the taste of iron at the back of Morwenna's throat.

She knew the shape of the object before she saw the crownlike head of it.

"The Sceptre of Final Winter," she said.

Caedmon whispered a denial.

Sabelle looked back at her. "You have heard of it."

"I have heard many things."

"And yet you recognize it."

Morwenna descended one step, then another. The revenant remained kneeling between her and the case. Frost gathered along the seams of its coat.

"The Sceptre of Final Winter is housed in Palewell Abbey," she said.

The words seemed to disturb the cellar.

The revenant's head jerked upward.

Sabelle's hand closed around the hilt beneath their coat. "Do not say that name again."

Morwenna watched the sceptre. Even in the dim light, the metal seemed to contain a deeper night. Its shaft was slender, ridged like frozen water. The head had been shaped into a cluster of jagged points, each one clear enough to catch the lantern flame and break it into colorless splinters.

"Housed," Morwenna repeated. "That is the term used in the records."

"Records are written by people who have not touched what they describe."

“You have.”

Sabelle did not answer.

Below them, the revenant began to tremble. The bindings around its mouth tightened. One of the threads snapped with a sound like a fingernail striking glass.

Caedmon nearly dropped the lantern. “It is waking.”

“It is awake,” Sabelle said.

“No.” Morwenna kept her eyes on the dead thing. “It is remembering.”

The revenant’s gaze fixed upon the sceptre.

“Palewell,” it said.

The cellar walls shuddered.

A film of ice spread across the nearest stone, branching outward in delicate white veins. The lantern flame guttered. Morwenna felt the cold enter through her gloves, through her sleeves, through the disciplined distance she kept between herself and fear.

Sabelle descended fully into the cellar.

“Look at me,” they ordered.

The revenant did not.

“Sabelle,” Morwenna said, “what did you bind to this place?”

The High Inquisitor’s face had become very still.

“Nothing that belongs to you.”

“Everything becomes someone’s concern when it can cross a threshold.”

“Not this.”

The sceptre gave a faint sound inside its case.

Not a chime. Not metal.

A sigh.

Morwenna’s thoughts went immediately to the message hidden beneath her coat. The Cartel had not purchased a passage for ordinary cargo. No one spent that kind of secrecy to move grain, weapons, or men whose names could be replaced. Somewhere beyond the storm, a hand had reached for this object—or for the knowledge of where it slept.

And Sabelle knew.

The realization did not frighten her as much as the next one did.

The Iron-Ring Cartel might know as well.

The revenant rose.

Sabelle spoke a word in a language Morwenna did not recognize.

The dead thing stopped halfway upright. Its body strained against the command. The joints in its neck clicked. Beneath the binding, something moved against the cloth, forming the shape of a smile or a scream.

Caedmon made the sign of warding over his chest.

Morwenna drew her pistol.

Sabelle's head turned a fraction. "I told you not to."

"You did."

The storm broke above them.

Thunder struck so hard the chapel floor jumped. The lantern went out, and for a breath there was only darkness, the cold, and the sound of the cellar door beginning to open behind them.

The cellar door opened another handspan.

Wind poured through the gap, though the chapel had no outer entrance open to it. It came smelling of wet ash and old iron. The revenant bent toward that draught as a flower bends toward light.

Morwenna raised the pistol.

The weapon steadied her. Not because she believed in it. Belief was a luxury for those who had never watched a Ley-storm turn an army into glass and mud. But the pistol had weight, a mechanism, a chamber, a deliberate ending. It obeyed the hand.

The dead thing did not.

"Sabelle," she said.

The High Inquisitor's silhouette stood between her and the stair. Twice-crowned, hoodless, motionless except for the minute tremor in their fingers. Lightning entered through the broken clerestory and made their face white as scraped bone.

"Lower it."

"I will not."

"Then fire."

The command was soft. That made it worse.

Morwenna's thumb rested against the hammer. The revenant's wrapped head tilted. Beneath its burial cloth, the mouth-shape widened. A black thread of liquid slid from where its chin should have been and fell soundlessly onto the flagstones.

Caedmon whispered, "It is listening."

"No," said Sabelle. "It is remembering."

The door opened farther.

Something moved below.

Morwenna felt the old instinct rise in her, the one that had carried her through storms, mutinies, and councils where every smile concealed a knife. Assess the exits. Count the hands. Identify the leverage. She

measured the chapel by darkness: the stair behind Sabelle, the narrow aisle, the collapsed wall, the high windows useless against the rain. Caedmon stood too close to the altar. Sabelle stood closest to the dead.

And she stood with a pistol she had not been meant to draw.

The Iron-Ring Cartel had paid for smaller risks. Names of captains. Routes of supply. Which officers could be bought and which only frightened. Information was a current, and Morwenna had learned to sail it without admitting she was in the water.

But no message had mentioned a revenant.

No message had mentioned that Sabelle Mournvale the Twice-Crowned kept the dead beneath a chapel.

The thought came with the cold precision of a blade: if the Cartel knew, they had not told her everything.

That was not betrayal. It was business.

She hated them for making the distinction necessary.

The revenant jerked forward.

Sabelle spoke again.

The word struck the room like a nail driven into wood. The dead body snapped upright. Its boots scraped over the stones. One hand rose, fingers crooked, and the wrappings around its wrist tightened with a dry creaking sound.

Morwenna fired.

The muzzle-flash tore the dark apart. Thunder followed too slowly.

The shot struck the revenant high in the shoulder. The impact spun it half around, but no blood came. Beneath the cloth, the bone gave with a damp crack. It staggered against the wall, then turned its ruined head toward her.

Caedmon cried out.

Sabelle did not move. "You disobeyed me."

"I improved our odds."

"You have mistaken noise for force."

The dead thing lurched down the first stair.

Sabelle lifted both hands. The sign they made was not any ward Morwenna knew. The High Inquisitor's fingers formed a shape like a crown broken in two.

The revenant stopped.

For one moment, its body held still. Then the cellar answered.

A knocking rose from below.

Not one fist. Many.

It traveled through the stone in slow, patient blows.

Caedmon's face had gone slack. He gathered the leather satchel clutched to his chest and backed toward the altar. "There is more than one."

Sabelle turned their head.

"Do not say what you cannot prove."

The knocking came again.

Morwenna's skin tightened across her shoulders. She had heard ships speak in storms. Hulls groaning, masts complaining, ropes snapping like tendons. She had heard men pound on sealed doors while fire climbed behind them. This was worse because it had no urgency. The things below were not begging to be released.

They were reminding the living that the door was a courtesy.

"What is under us?" Morwenna asked.

Sabelle looked at her then, and the severity fell away enough for Morwenna to see the exhaustion beneath it. They had the expression of someone who had guarded a secret so long that the secret had become a second spine.

"An obligation."

"To whom?"

"Do not make this a hearing."

"I am a Fleet Admiral. I ask questions before men die."

"Men have already died."

"That answer belongs to a coward."

The revenant's head snapped toward them.

Sabelle's gaze hardened. "You were born in 288 AS, Morwenna Ashgrove. You have spent your life believing command means choosing which danger receives a name. This one has a name. It is simply not yours to hear."

The use of her full name made the chapel contract around her.

She had never told Sabelle when she was born. It was not a secret, precisely. A birth year was a small thing in the ledgers of the realm, a mark among other marks. Yet she felt the disclosure as a hand laid upon the back of her neck.

"You have been reading my file."

"I read everything placed before me."

"Then you know I dislike being handled."

"I know you dislike being known."

The knocking ceased.

Silence fell so suddenly that Morwenna heard rainwater dripping from the hem of her coat. One drop. Then another.

From below came a breath.

The revenant stepped off the stair.

Its damaged shoulder hung loose. The bullet had gone through, leaving a dark hole in the wrappings. Through that hole, Morwenna saw not flesh but a pale glimmer, like moonlight trapped inside a wound.

Caedmon began to write.

Morwenna looked at him. "What are you doing?"

"Recording."

"Record this instead." She pointed the pistol at his hand. "If you survive, write that you were warned."

His quill hovered. "I am a Scribe. If I do not record it, it will be altered."

"Everything is altered."

"Not ink."

Sabelle made a sound that might have been amusement, though nothing in their face softened. "Caedmon Fellgard has kept records longer than most men have kept their convictions."

Morwenna did not lower the pistol. "How old is this place?"

"Greyfell Citadel was founded in 62 AS."

The answer came from Caedmon. His eyes remained on the page.

The name carried a chill of its own. Greyfell Citadel, abandoned in the Shattered Vale, outside the realm's core holdings. Morwenna had seen it once from a distance through a veil of dust: grey stone rising from grey country, a dead fist refusing to unclench.

"This is Greyfell?" she asked.

"Was," said Sabelle.

A sound rolled beneath them, deeper than thunder.

The altar shuddered. Dust sifted from the ribs of the roof. Somewhere below, metal scraped stone.

Morwenna thought of Palewell Abbey, standing in The Pale Coast, rebuilt over whatever had been broken there. Founded in 244 AS. A place of pale walls and watchful garrison, where 5998 soldiers kept their silence beneath the shadow of the Sceptre of Final Winter.

She had been told the Sceptre was safe there.

Safe was a word that belonged to maps.

"Does Palewell know?" she asked.

Sabelle's eyes narrowed. "Know what?"

"That you keep this."

"I keep nothing."

The revenant turned its wrapped face toward the High Inquisitor.

Sabelle's denial lay between them, thin as paper.

Morwenna had seen this kind of evasion in war councils. The speaker did not reject the fact, only the vocabulary. Not prisoner. Asset. Not massacre. Necessity. Not treason. Preservation.

"You keep a bound revenant in your cellar," Morwenna said.

Caedmon stopped writing.

The lantern, dead since the storm, gave a single weak flare from its wick. In that brief amber light Sabelle's expression became ancient.

"I keep a bound revenant in my cellar," they said.

The words seemed to unlock something.

Below, the door slammed shut.

The revenant moved.

Morwenna fired again, but Sabelle struck her wrist aside. The shot cracked into the rafters. Splinters fell. The dead thing crossed the distance between them with impossible speed, its hands reaching for Caedmon.

Caedmon dropped the satchel and stumbled. Papers spilled across the altar steps, white scraps turning in the draft.

Sabelle seized the revenant by the throat.

They were not stronger than it. Morwenna saw that at once. The dead body drove them backward, boots grinding on stone, its fingers closing around their neck. Yet Sabelle held on, and the crowns—one iron, one blackened silver—caught the lightning and shone with a sickly radiance.

"Write," Sabelle rasped.

Caedmon stared.

"Write, Scribe."

He snatched up the quill.

Morwenna moved before thought could argue. She kicked the revenant behind the knee. The joint folded. Sabelle twisted, bringing the dead thing down hard against the floor.

The impact shook the chapel.

For an instant, Morwenna's palm pressed against the revenant's chest. Beneath the burial cloth something beat.

Not a heart.

A fist.

It struck once against her hand.

Memory flashed through her: the Leaden Accord, begun in 330 AS and ended in 342 AS; 14,011 casualties counted in the ledgers, though no ledger had ever been able to contain them. Both hosts destroyed by a Ley-storm. The Iron-Ring Cartel named victor amid the ruin. And behind the official ashes, the hidden truth—a supposedly destroyed artifact spirited away while everyone watched the armies die.

She had sold that truth in pieces.

Not the whole of it. Never the whole.

The revenant's chest struck her palm again.

The same rhythm.

The same impossible insistence.

Morwenna tore her hand away.

Sabelle forced the dead thing's head against the flagstones. Their voice had become a low chant, each syllable dragging against the next. The revenant writhed beneath them. Its wrappings loosened. Something black and wet pressed through the cloth around its mouth.

"Caedmon," Morwenna said. "What are you writing?"

The Scribe's quill shook, but the ink did not blot.

"The truth as spoken."

"By whom?"

He looked up.

The cellar door began to open again.

This time, no wind came through.

A pale hand appeared in the gap and curled around the edge.

Then another hand closed over it.

Sabelle looked toward the door.

For the first time, Morwenna saw fear in the High Inquisitor's face.

Not fear of the dead.

Recognition.

Sabelle released the revenant.

It rose immediately, turning toward the stair as though summoned by a bell. The bound corpse stood between them and the opening door. Its head lifted. Beneath the cloth, the hidden mouth shaped a word.

Morwenna could not hear it.

But Sabelle did.

Their crowns began to bleed.

Chapter 3

The quarantine bell spoke once through Gloamreach, and the sound went nowhere.

It struck the pallid air above the Pale Coast, shuddered against the sealed gates, and died among the roofs as if the town itself had swallowed it. Ignatz Ashgrove the Oathless stood beneath the bell tower and listened to the silence that followed. He had learned, in the years since command was placed upon him, that silence was never empty. It was a room with someone hiding inside.

A guard watched him from the gatehouse slit.

Another watched the road.

The garrison of Gloamreach numbered 2,483. Ignatz knew the figure because the quartermaster had spoken it three times, each time with the grim precision of a man who believed numbers could be made to stand between a place and death. They could not. Not here. The town was quarantined, and every sealed door seemed to breathe its own private sickness into the fog.

“Commander.”

The voice came from behind him.

Ignatz did not turn. “Quartermaster.”

Ignatz Marrowgate approached over the wet stones. He served as a Quartermaster, and service had made a careful creature of him. He carried a ledger against his chest beneath his cloak, sheltering it from the mist more fiercely than he sheltered himself. The lantern at his belt burned with a weak, colorless flame.

“You were expected in the counting room,” Marrowgate said.

“I am expected in many rooms.”

“The records require your seal.”

“Then the records can wait.”

Marrowgate’s fingers tightened over the ledger. “The stores cannot.”

At that, Ignatz turned.

Nothing in the quartermaster’s face asked to be remembered. That was his strength. In a world where every expression became evidence, plainness was a kind of armor. He looked at Ignatz, then at the gatehouse, then at the locked road beyond it.

“The ration allotments were reduced,” Marrowgate said. “The men have noticed.”

“Men notice the absence of things more readily than the presence of them.”

“They notice hunger.”

“They will notice less if they keep their mouths shut.”

Marrowgate lowered his eyes. “The quarantine does not explain the reduction.”

“No,” Ignatz said. “It explains the fear. Fear explains the rest.”

A drop of water fell from the bell rope and struck the stone between them.

Inside his coat, beneath the dark fold of his command mantle, a small packet rested against his ribs. Waxed cloth. Thin paper. A line of figures, a line of routes, a line of names he had not written but had copied in his own hand. Intelligence had a smell when it belonged to the Iron-Ring Cartel: hot wax, iron dust, and the faint bitter trace of burned herbs. The packet carried all three.

He had sold it before dawn.

Not for coin. Coin left witnesses in the fingers. The Cartel paid in absences—an unsearched wagon, an overlooked door, a patrol turned half a road aside. Their mercy was only another shape of ownership.

“You should come in,” Marrowgate said.

“Why?”

“The relics have been brought from the vault.”

Ignatz felt the old resistance close around his heart. “Which relics?”

“The Hollow Edge. The Chalice of Ashdeep.”

The names seemed to change the temperature of the fog.

The Hollow Edge was a ward forged in 216 AS. Its attunement cost 21. Ignatz had never touched it, though men had lied about that touch in reports carrying his authority. The artifact was spoken of in the language used for wounds that had not healed: emptiness, severity, a clean absence where certainty ought to be.

The Chalice of Ashdeep was a reliquary forged in 323 AS. Its attunement cost 27. It suggested, even in its name, a depth of ash no hand could reach. No one spoke of what it held. No one spoke of what it required.

“Why are they out?” Ignatz asked.

Marrowgate glanced toward the sealed houses. “Orders.”

“Whose?”

“The papers bear the proper marks.”

“That was not my question.”

The quartermaster’s mouth thinned. “The Ashen Vanguard has sent inquiries. House Morvain has sent inquiries. The Silent Choir has sent inquiries. The Bleeding Crown has sent inquiries. The Iron-Ring Cartel has sent nothing.”

The lie arrived between them, pale and composed.

Ignatz heard it because he had placed it there.

The five powers watched the realm’s ruins from their separate shadows: the Ashen Vanguard, House Morvain, the Silent Choir, the Iron-Ring Cartel, and the Bleeding Crown. Each had learned to call patience a virtue when patience served appetite. Each understood that Gloamreach’s quarantine made every locked gate a political statement.

“Take me to the vault,” Ignatz said.

Marrowgate hesitated. “The vault is sealed.”

“Then unseal it.”

“It is sealed by ward.”

“Then break the ward.”

The quartermaster looked toward the tower. “That may be unwise.”

Ignatz leaned close enough for the mist to bead upon his lashes. “You are a Quartermaster, Ignatz Marrowgate. Your duty is to count what remains after wisdom has finished spending it.”

Something moved behind the gatehouse slit. A rifle barrel, perhaps. Or merely the shadow of one.

Marrowgate stepped aside.

They crossed the yard without speaking. The garrison’s barracks stood in rigid rows, their windows dark. Somewhere within them, a man coughed. Another voice answered, low and frightened, and was immediately silenced. Gloamreach did not feel defended. It felt held.

At the vault door, wax seals crowded the iron like pale scabs.

Marrowgate raised the ledger. “The attunement cost of The Hollow Edge is 21.”

“I know.”

“The Chalice of Ashdeep is 27.”

“I know.”

“You must sign.”

Ignatz looked at the page.

His name waited there, written by another hand.

Ignatz Ashgrove the Oathless.

The title sat after it like a blade laid beside a throat. He had been born in 258 AS, before Gloamreach had become a place men feared to name aloud. Before the Purge of Blackport. Before he understood that oaths were only promises made visible long enough for someone to find the weakness in them.

He pressed his thumb to the seal.

The wax softened.

“Commander,” Marrowgate whispered, “the records say the relics were not to be opened.”

“The records say many things.”

“Then why open them?”

Because someone had carried a message out of Gloamreach.

Because the Iron-Ring Cartel had paid to learn whether the quarantine was sickness or theater.

Because a commander's first duty was to protect the truth, and his second was to decide who deserved to possess it.

Ignatz withdrew his thumb. “You asked for my seal.”

“I did.”

“You have it.”

“It is not enough.”

“It will be.”

He turned away from the door.

Marrowgate stared at him. “You are leaving?”

“I am going to Fenspire.”

The quartermaster’s face remained plain, but the muscles at his jaw tightened. “Fenspire stands in the Gloaming Reach.”

“I am aware.”

“It was founded in 57 AS.”

“I am aware.”

“Its garrison is 3,742. It is garrisoned, not quarantined.”

Ignatz looked back at the sealed vault. “Then someone there still believes walls mean something.”

Fenspire’s spire rose in his mind without need of sight: stark against the dim character of the Gloaming Reach, disciplined and watchful, a permanent occupation sharpened into architecture. If Gloamreach was a shut mouth, Fenspire was a clenched fist.

Marrowgate opened the ledger again. “The Purge of Blackport is in the annex.”

“Why?”

“Because the transfer orders cite precedent.”

Ignatz took the ledger from him.

The page smelled of damp paper and old smoke. At its center, the heading had been written in heavier ink:

The Purge of Blackport began in 311 AS and ended in 321 AS.

Below it:

70,907 casualties.

Below that:

The total rout of the aggressors.

His eyes moved to the final notation.

The Iron-Ring Cartel emerged as victor.

Marrowgate stood beside him, breathing shallowly.

“Read the margin,” the quartermaster said.

Ignatz did not need to. He knew the concealed truth. Everyone who mattered knew it, and no one who mattered would speak it where the dead could hear.

The victors had poisoned the wells of their own allies.

He ran one gloved finger beneath the sentence without touching the ink.

“Who entered this?” he asked.

“The record was amended.”

“By whom?”

“The amendment is unsigned.”

“Then it is not a record.”

“It is still in the ledger.”

Ignatz shut the book.

The Blackport figures had a gravity of their own. The number of casualties was too large to imagine as bodies, so the mind made them into an abstraction, and abstraction was the first courtesy offered to murder. Yet the wells remained in the words. Water darkening in a cup. A hand lifting it. A throat opening. The Iron-Ring Cartel’s triumph, merciless and bright, spoiled from within by the arithmetic of betrayal.

His hand found the packet beneath his coat.

A message from the Cartel could be waiting at Fenspire.

Or a message from the Cartel could already be inside Gloamreach, hidden among the relics, the rations, the dead letters, the sealed rooms.

“Commander,” Marrowgate said, “what should I enter for the vault?”

Ignatz considered the iron door. The seals. The names of the artifacts. The lies gathering behind every wall.

“Enter nothing.”

“That is not procedure.”

“Procedure is what remains when courage has gone.”

“And what remains when procedure goes?”

Ignatz looked at him.

For the first time, the quartermaster’s expression shifted. Not fear. Not quite. Recognition, perhaps—the dawning knowledge that the man before him was not merely an oathless guardian, but a guardian who had learned to weaponize the absence of an oath.

From the far end of the yard came the scrape of a boot.

Both men turned.

A figure stood beneath the archway, wrapped against the fog. No insignia showed. One hand rested against the wall. The other held something small and pale.

Ignatz felt the packet under his coat grow suddenly warm.

“Who is that?” Marrowgate asked.

The figure lifted its hand.

In its palm lay a strip of waxed cloth marked with the same iron-dark seal.

Ignatz did not move.

The bells above Gloamreach remained silent, and somewhere beyond the gate, on the road toward Fenspire, a horse began to scream.

The figure stepped into the yard.

Fog slid from its shoulders in pale ropes. Beneath the hood, the face remained a blankness of wet shadow. The waxed strip hung between two fingers, its seal turned outward as if the stranger had come not to deliver a message but to display a wound.

Marrowgate’s hand drifted toward the knife at his belt.

Ignatz caught the movement.

“Do not.”

The Quartermaster’s fingers stopped. “You know it?”

“I know what it means when someone carries it openly.”

The figure’s head tilted.

The scream beyond the gate broke off. Silence rushed into the space it had occupied, vast and immediate. The yard seemed to contract around the three of them. Water ticked from the eaves. Somewhere in the barracks, a man coughed and was answered by another cough, then by the muffled clatter of a dropped cup.

Gloamreach had been quarantined long enough for every sound to become an accusation.

The stranger extended the strip.

Ignatz did not take it. “Speak.”

No answer.

“Speak,” he said again, and felt command gather in his voice like a blade being drawn through cloth. “Or leave.”

The hand holding the packet lowered. The other rose to the hood and pulled it back.

The face beneath was young enough to make the silence cruel. No scar marked it. No badge, no painted vow, no iron ring. Only rain on the brow and a mouth pressed tight against whatever words had been put there.

Marrowgate breathed through his nose. “A courier.”

“A courier who knows the seal,” Ignatz said.

The young figure looked at him, then at the packet beneath his coat.

That glance struck more deeply than any accusation.

The warmth under the cloth had spread across his ribs. He could feel the seal through the layers: iron-dark, hard-edged, branded with a symbol that belonged nowhere near the walls of Gloamreach. The Iron-Ring Cartel preferred contracts written in ink, but intelligence was another substance. It traveled in hollows, in false inventories, in the mouths of men who believed themselves merely hungry.

Ignatz had sold them the movements of patrols.

He had sold them the weakness in the western watchtower.

He had sold them the names of officers whose loyalties could be purchased and those whose throats must be opened.

He had never sold them Gloamreach.

Not yet.

Marrowgate watched him. "Commander."

The title held no comfort. It was a nail driven into old wood.

Ignatz had been born in 258 AS, when the realm still pretended the Sundering had left something worth inheriting. He had learned command among ruins that had outlived their makers, and every oath placed before him had tasted of ash. That was why the garrison called him the Oathless when they thought he could not hear. The name had become more durable than his rank.

The courier extended the waxed cloth once more.

Ignatz took it.

The seal was cold now.

The cloth unfolded with a damp whisper. Within lay a narrow sliver of black glass, no longer than the first joint of his thumb. A line had been scratched across it.

NOT THE GATE.

His eyes moved to the archway.

Beyond it, the road ran white with fog toward Fenspire, whose garrisoned walls stood under a stark spire in the Gloaming Reach. Fenspire had been founded in 57 AS. Its garrison numbered 3,742. Gloamreach had 2,483, though the quarantine made the number feel like a lie: men counted behind locked doors, rifles stacked beside sickbeds, boots rotting in the damp.

Marrowgate leaned closer. "What is it?"

"A warning."

"From whom?"

Ignatz folded the cloth. "You ask questions as though answers have ever improved your position."

The Quartermaster's jaw tightened. He was Ignatz Marrowgate, born in 425 AS, and he wore the title of Quartermaster with the grim devotion of a man who had mistaken ledgers for armor. There was no reason for him to know anything of the Cartel. No reason for him to know that the black glass was a dead-drop token, or that the seal beneath its wax had been burned into the hands of men who never appeared twice in the same town.

Yet his eyes had not left the strip.

The courier spoke at last.

“Three came through the gate.”

Ignatz turned toward the archway. “When?”

The courier’s lips parted. A tremor passed through the throat before the answer emerged.

“Before the bells.”

“The bells have not rung.”

“That is why.”

Marrowgate looked up. Above the yard, the bell tower was swallowed by mist. Its iron mouths hung dark and still.

Ignatz felt the old instinct rise: summon the guard, seal the barracks, send riders along the road. It was the instinct that had kept him alive, and the same instinct the Iron-Ring Cartel had learned to measure. Panic was a kind of currency. Those who spent it first were always poorer afterward.

“What did they carry?” he asked.

The courier’s gaze flicked again to the packet. “One carried a ward.”

“What ward?”

“The Hollow Edge.”

The name passed through the yard without sound.

Ignatz had seen it once, behind three locks and a curtain of salt-thread. The Hollow Edge was a ward forged in 216 AS, an object made less to protect than to deny. Attunement to it cost 21. Men who touched its power spoke afterward of rooms with no corners, of voices stripped clean of meaning.

“Where are they?” he asked.

The courier looked toward the barracks.

A door opened in the distance.

Not wide. A hand’s breadth.

Then closed.

Marrowgate drew his knife.

This time Ignatz let him.

The Quartermaster’s face had gone gray. “There are no strangers in the roster.”

“Rosters are written by men.”

“And gates are watched.”

“Gates are watched by men.”

Something moved beneath the fog near the cistern. A shape, perhaps. Or the eye inventing a body where fear required one.

Ignatz stepped forward.

The courier seized his sleeve.

The touch was desperate, almost childlike. Ignatz looked down at the hand. The fingers were stained black beneath the nails.

“Not the gate,” the courier whispered.

The black glass in Ignatz’s palm had warmed.

A sound came from under the flagstones.

Three knocks.

Marrowgate flinched. The knife rose.

Three more.

The rhythm was patient. It did not belong to an animal.

Ignatz crouched beside the cistern. Water trembled in the basin, reflecting nothing but a broken smear of sky. The stones around its base had been mortared over recently. He scraped at one with his thumb and found the seam.

“Get the key,” he said.

Marrowgate stared. “For what?”

“For the lower stores.”

“There is no lower—”

“Get the key.”

The Quartermaster ran.

Ignatz remained by the cistern with the courier behind him and the packet pressed against his chest. He heard boots waking throughout the garrison. Orders began to travel in fragments: the gate, the east wall, the fog, the bells. Somewhere a man shouted that the quarantine had been breached.

The old lies were assembling themselves.

He thought of Blackport. The Purge of Blackport began in 311 AS and ended in 321 AS, leaving 70,907 casualties and the total rout of the aggressors. The Iron-Ring Cartel emerged as victor. That was the history carved into walls and recited by clerks who had never smelled poisoned water.

The concealed truth was that the victors had poisoned the wells of their own allies.

Ignatz had read the proof in a ledger whose pages still smelled of lime.

The Cartel did not defeat its enemies. It arranged the world so that survival itself became evidence of guilt.

The knocks came again.

This time there were four.

The courier began to weep soundlessly.

“Why bring this to me?” Ignatz asked.

The answer came from beneath the stones.

“Because you are the one who opens what should remain shut.”

The voice was muffled, but not by earth. It seemed to speak from inside his own skull.

The Hollow Edge.

Ignatz’s hand went to the packet. “Who is below?”

“Ask the reliquary.”

Marrowgate returned, breathing hard, one hand closed around a ring of keys. “The lower stores are sealed.”

Ignatz rose. “Then we have been storing something.”

He took the largest key. Its teeth were furred with rust.

The courtyard doors began to open behind them. Men emerged in coats thrown over nightclothes, weapons clutched in uncertain hands. Their faces turned toward Ignatz, waiting for certainty. He could feel it gathering in them, the simple hunger to be told where danger stood.

He almost gave them the gate.

Instead he faced the cistern.

“Keep the yard sealed,” he ordered. “No one leaves Gloamreach.”

Marrowgate’s eyes narrowed. “And if the danger is already inside?”

Ignatz fitted the key into the seam.

“Then the quarantine is working.”

The lock turned.

Below the stone, something drew breath.

Ignatz lifted the slab, and a breath of cold ash rose from the dark. In that darkness, a metal vessel waited on a shelf of bone-white masonry, its surface filmed with soot.

The Chalice of Ashdeep.

A reliquary forged in 323 AS. Attunement to it cost 27.

Its rim was wet.

Ignatz stared at the black drops gathering there.

Behind him, Marrowgate whispered, “Commander, what is that?”

From the barracks came the first bell.

It rang once.

Then the chalice answered.

The second bell did not come from the barracks.

It sounded beneath their feet.

The stone shelf shuddered. Soot loosened from the ceiling and fell in a thin gray rain. Marrowgate caught the wall with one hand, the other closing around the short blade at his belt.

Ignatz did not move.

The black drops on the Chalice of Ashdeep trembled as if something beneath the metal had begun to beat. One gathered itself at the rim. It did not fall. It crawled upward instead, thick as oil, dragging a dark thread behind it.

“Close the slab,” Marrowgate said.

His voice had lost the measured irritation of a Quartermaster faced with a locked door. Fear had entered it, and fear made men honest in ways oaths never could.

Ignatz watched the drop reach the highest point of the rim.

“Do you hear it?”

“Hear what?”

The third bell rang.

This time the sound came from inside the chalice.

Not a peal. Not metal struck by a hammer. A low, submerged note, like a bell being rung beneath a drowned city. It passed through the chamber and into Ignatz’s bones. His teeth ached. Somewhere above, boots began to run across the barracks floor.

Marrowgate looked toward the open stair.

“Commander.”

Ignatz reached for the reliquary.

The air between his hand and the chalice tightened.

Pain entered his palm before his fingers touched the metal. It was a clean pain, precise and intimate, as if a needle had been placed beneath each nail. His hand stopped a finger’s breadth from the vessel.

The black drop fell.

It struck the shelf and spread in a thin ring.

The masonry drank it.

A line appeared in the white stone, running outward from the shelf. Another crossed it. Then another. The fractures joined in a pattern that resembled writing, though no alphabet Ignatz knew had ever been meant to be read by living eyes.

Marrowgate retreated one step.

“You said the reliquary was inert.”

“I said it had not answered.”

“That is not the same thing.”

“No.”

The word left Ignatz quietly. The chamber took it and gave it back from every wall.

No.

He had seen the Chalice of Ashdeep only once before, and then from a distance, under a hood of canvas and the watch of men who would have killed him if they had known what he had carried in his memory. He had not been told where it came from. He had not asked. Questions were a kind of coin, and the wrong question could purchase a grave.

Forged in 323 AS. Attunement cost 27.

Those facts had been entered in a ciphered ledger and passed through hands that did not belong to the Ashen Vanguard. Ignatz had copied them for the Iron-Ring Cartel, then burned the page. He remembered the heat of it. He remembered how the ink had curled before the parchment blackened.

He had told himself that information was not betrayal.

He had told himself many things.

Above them, someone shouted. A second voice answered. Then came the scrape and clatter of men dragging the barracks doors shut.

Gloomreach was quarantined. Every gate had been barred against the Pale Coast, every road watched, every vessel refused. The garrison numbered 2,483, enough to make a prison of a town and not enough to make the prison safe.

The bells continued.

Marrowgate swallowed. “What does it want?”

Ignatz looked at the chalice.

“To be opened.”

“It is open.”

“No.”

The inside of the reliquary was blacker than the chamber around it. The darkness there had depth. It seemed to recede not into the vessel but into some place beyond distance, where cold ash drifted through a lightless current.

A shape moved in that depth.

Marrowgate made a sound through his teeth.

Ignatz caught his arm before the Quartermaster could flee. “Do not look into it.”

“I already did.”

“Then remember what you saw.”

“I saw nothing.”

“Good.”

The fourth bell rang.

The stone beneath the chalice split with a soft, wet sigh. A breath came through the crack, carrying the stink of extinguished fires and old water. It touched Ignatz's face. For an instant he tasted Blackport.

The taste brought no image at first. Only bitterness. Then the wells. The poisoned wells. The Iron-Ring Cartel had emerged victorious from the Purge of Blackport, and the victory had been polished until its surface shone. The dead had been counted—70,907 casualties—while the truth had been buried beneath speeches, ash, and sealed reports.

The Cartel had poisoned the wells of its own allies.

Ignatz had learned that truth in a room without windows. He had been paid to learn it, though not to understand why it mattered. The coin had been placed beneath his hand. The message had been carried out. Since then, the Cartel had purchased other fragments from him: patrol routes, stores, weaknesses in the coastward watch.

Small betrayals, he had called them.

Nothing that could topple a realm.

The chalice whispered.

Not in words. In the dry rasp of grains poured across stone.

Marrowgate jerked against Ignatz's grip. "There's something in the crack."

Ignatz released him.

A black film rose between the stones. It gathered in the shape of a hand, but the fingers were too long and the joints bent in the wrong places. It pressed against the edge of the shelf.

The chalice answered with a note so deep that the flame in the wall lamp went blue.

From somewhere beyond the chamber came the groan of a door being forced.

"Who knows we are here?" Marrowgate asked.

Ignatz did not answer.

The question entered him like a hook. He had sent a message three nights ago. Not from the garrison office; that would have been watched. Not through the ordinary channels. The information had gone folded inside a requisition tally, carried by a route he had used before.

Gloomreach's quarantine had been the message.

The sealed roads. The closed harbor. The men rotated from the walls and the stores shifted beneath guard.

And the Chalice of Ashdeep.

He had not known whether the Cartel wanted the relic removed, destroyed, or merely understood. He had sent what he knew. He had expected time.

Time was a luxury possessed by men who had not opened the wrong door.

"Commander," Marrowgate said. "Answer me."

"No one was meant to know."

“That is not an answer.”

“It is the only one you are getting.”

The Quartermaster stared at him. In the blue light, his face seemed carved from the same pallid stone as the shelf. “You brought me here.”

“I needed the lock opened.”

“You knew what was beneath it.”

“I knew what had been recorded.”

“And who recorded it?”

Ignatz turned toward him.

Marrowgate’s courage failed before his suspicion did. He lowered his eyes, but not quickly enough.

A man could be forgiven for fear. Suspicion was another matter.

Above, the alarm began in earnest. Boots hammered through the barracks. Voices rose and collided. Someone cried that the east gate had opened. Someone else shouted that no gate had opened, that the sound was coming from below.

The fifth bell struck.

The crack beneath the shelf widened.

A pale powder spilled through and spread across the floor, though there was no wind. It moved against the slope of the stones, creeping toward Ignatz’s boots. Where it touched his shadow, the shadow recoiled.

He took one step back.

The powder followed.

“Close the slab,” Marrowgate whispered again.

Ignatz looked up at the underside of the stone. The slab waited above the stair, its hinge groaning under a pressure that did not come from any hand. If they sealed the chamber, whatever had woken might remain below.

Or it might learn the shape of the prison.

He had spent his life around wards and walls. The Hollow Edge had been forged in 216 AS; its name was spoken in garrison prayers as though emptiness itself could be made obedient. Men trusted old magic because stone did not confess its doubts.

But every ward had an edge.

Every oath had a hollow place.

The powder reached the toe of his boot.

It stopped.

Then it formed letters.

Not the fractured signs on the shelf. These were plain enough to read.

OPEN.

Marrowgate saw them. His breath caught.

“What have you done?”

Ignatz’s hand went to the weapon at his side, though steel had never persuaded anything that lived beneath the world.

“I have not done this.”

The letters changed.

A second word appeared beneath the first.

OATHLESS.

The chamber seemed to narrow around him.

Marrowgate turned slowly. “Commander—”

The sixth bell began to ring.

This time it rang above them, below them, and inside Ignatz’s skull.

The Chalice of Ashdeep rose from the shelf.

It did not leap or float. It simply ceased to rest upon the stone. Black liquid hung beneath it in a trembling globe, and within that globe something pale unfolded, joint by joint, like a hand emerging from deep water.

Ignatz drew his blade.

The sound of metal leaving its sheath was pitifully small.

The hand touched the rim.

The chalice cracked.

A line of darkness opened down its side, and from within came a voice made of many voices, each one speaking from a different distance.

“Ignatz Ashgrove the Oathless.”

Marrowgate stumbled backward.

The voice spoke again.

“Tell the Iron-Ring Cartel the door is open.”

The black globe burst.

Ash struck Ignatz’s face. Cold entered his eyes. The chamber vanished, replaced by a vast shore under a colorless sky. Something stood at the waterline, veiled in drifting soot. Beyond it, bells swung from towers with no walls beneath them.

Then the vision broke.

Ignatz was on one knee.

Marrowgate was shouting, but the words came from far away. The open slab had begun to descend. Above, the stair was crowded with shadows and the glimmer of drawn weapons.

The powder on the floor had written one final word.

RUN.

Ignatz rose.

He seized Marrowgate by the collar and drove him toward the stairs. "Move."

"What was that?"

"Not here."

"Where do we go?"

The slab dropped another handspan. A boot appeared in the narrowing gap above, followed by the edge of a blade.

Ignatz shoved Marrowgate beneath it.

The blade struck stone.

Sparks fell.

They reached the stair together. Behind them, the Chalice of Ashdeep gave a final, shivering note. The sound traveled up through the soles of Ignatz's boots and into the foundations of Gloamreach.

The walls answered.

Not with bells.

With breathing.

Ignatz looked up at the men trapped above the descending slab, then back into the chamber where the darkness had begun to pour from the broken reliquary.

Somewhere beyond the sealed coast, the Ashen Vanguard waited for orders. Somewhere farther still, the Iron-Ring Cartel waited for his message.

The slab touched the first helmet.

Ignatz put his shoulder beneath the stone.

"Pull," he said.

Marrowgate stared at him. "Commander, what are you doing?"

Ignatz felt the weight descend, felt the dark breath rising against his back.

"Keeping the quarantine," he said.

And beneath them, something laughed.

Chapter 4

The sea had withdrawn from Palewell Abbey by the time Morwenna Ashgrove reached its gate, leaving the shore black and shining beneath the morning's pallor.

Wind worried the pennants above the battlements. They cracked like small whips, each snap swallowed by the greater breathing of the coast. Salt filmed the stones. The abbey had been rebuilt in pale blocks that did not match: some clean and sharp-edged, some already softened by weather, some bearing the old scars beneath their new skin. It was a place made twice and trusted neither time.

Morwenna dismounted without assistance.

The horse shied from the wind. She did not. A Fleet Admiral learned early that the world was always attempting to make a spectacle of disobedience—animals, weather, subordinates, history. One endured it by refusing to perform in return.

At the gate, a sentry lowered his spear.

"Admiral."

"Open it."

He glanced beyond her, toward the road. "Your escort?"

"Behind me."

This was not true. Her escort waited at a distance where the sea mist could conceal them, though she had brought no one who mattered. No one whose absence would be remarked upon. The lies required for survival were seldom grand. Most were no larger than a hand placed over a page.

The sentry hesitated.

Morwenna looked at the spearpoint, then at him. "If you intend to challenge my authority, do it before I enter. I dislike being interrupted once I have begun."

The gate opened.

Inside, Palewell Abbey smelled of wet ash, old mortar, and boiled grain. The rebuilt cloister enclosed a square of dead earth where a few winter herbs leaned beneath the rain. Along the inner wall stood racks of pikes, their shafts darkened with oil. The place had been raised as sanctuary once. Whatever prayers had survived its ruin had been hammered into military discipline.

A boy in a grey wool coat crossed the yard carrying a stack of ledgers against his chest. He saw Morwenna, stopped, and nearly dropped them.

"Caedmon Fellgard," he said, recovering himself. "Scribe."

"I know what a scribe is."

His mouth tightened. He had the reserved misery of a man who believed every word might someday be entered into evidence. "I was instructed to bring you to the record room."

"By whom?"

"By Sabelle Mournvale the Twice-Crowned."

The wind drove rain through the archway behind them. Morwenna glanced at the boy's ledgers. Their bindings were swollen from damp, their corners blackened. "And the High Inquisitor is here?"

"Yes."

"Waiting?"

Caedmon's gaze flickered toward the chapel. "The High Inquisitor does not wait in the manner of ordinary people."

"Then lead me to the extraordinary one."

He turned.

Morwenna followed through the rebuilt cloister, beneath arches that still held the pale, severe geometry of an abbey though the inner faces had been reinforced with iron bands. Every window was narrow. Every door had a bar within reach. The architects had remembered the enemy before they remembered the saint.

She had been born in 288 AS, into a realm that had forgotten how to distinguish between inheritance and salvage. By the time she was old enough to understand maps, every border had been a wound someone had named a province. By the time she wore the uniform of command, the sea had become the only road that did not belong wholly to another power.

Her hand brushed the inside of her coat.

The message rested there, folded within oilskin.

She had written it herself. Three lines concerning the disposition of stores, the condition of patrol vessels, and a weakness in the coastal watch. Nothing that could be called treason by a person who had not lost a war. Everything that could be called valuable by the Iron-Ring Cartel.

The payment would arrive later, through hands that would not know her name.

That was the principle of secret commerce: ignorance was not an obstacle. It was the currency.

Caedmon opened the record room.

Shelves climbed the walls, burdened by ledgers, rolls, tablets, and sealed packets. The air was warmer here, though it carried the damp animal scent of leather and parchment. A single brazier burned beneath a flue. Beside it stood Sabelle Mournvale the Twice-Crowned.

The High Inquisitor wore no visible crown. The title was enough. Severity gathered around them like a second garment, and their stillness possessed the intolerable confidence of a blade laid flat upon a table.

"Fleet Admiral," Sabelle said.

"High Inquisitor."

"You came quickly."

"I came when summoned."

"Those are not the same thing."

"No."

Sabelle regarded her for a long moment. Their eyes moved to the coat, the gloves, the damp at Morwenna's shoulders, and finally to the hand that had touched the message beneath the fabric.

Morwenna kept her breathing even.

On the table between them lay a map of the coast, its corners weighted by iron seals. Palewell Abbey had been marked in red ink. Other marks gathered around it in careful clusters, though she did not recognize the hands that had made them.

Caedmon placed his ledgers beside the map.

"Leave us," Sabelle said.

The scribe stiffened. "The records—"

"Will remain records after you depart."

Caedmon looked to Morwenna, as if authority might be contagious.

"Go," she said.

He bowed and withdrew, closing the door with precise gentleness.

The room seemed to shrink.

Sabelle touched one of the ledgers. "The Leaden Accord ended in 342 AS."

Morwenna looked at the map. "I remember."

"Do you?"

"I remember enough."

"The Accord was declared concluded. The Iron-Ring Cartel was named victor. The hosts were destroyed by a Ley-storm." Sabelle's finger moved across the map without touching it. "And yet certain accounts remain unsettled."

"War leaves accounts. It does not leave answers."

"Poetry from a Fleet Admiral."

"An observation from a tired one."

Sabelle's expression did not alter. "You have been tired for a long time."

There it was: not an accusation, but its shadow. Morwenna had met shadows in every port. They lurked behind questions, beneath signatures, inside the silence after a subordinate said yes.

She removed her gloves one finger at a time and set them on the table.

"The Leaden Accord ended in 342 AS," she said. "If you summoned me to dispute the calendar, I cannot help you."

"I summoned you because a supposedly destroyed artifact was not destroyed."

The words entered the room softly.

Outside, rain hissed against the rebuilt stone.

Morwenna kept her face composed. The supposedly destroyed artifact had been a rumor when she first heard it, a rumor repeated by men who wanted their failures to sound ordained. Then came the Ley-storm. Then the wreckage. Then the silence in which every power claimed victory and no one claimed responsibility.

The artifact had not been destroyed.

She knew this because the Iron-Ring Cartel had paid for the knowledge.

Not directly. Never directly.

“How certain are you?” she asked.

“Certain enough to distrust certainty.”

“That is not an answer.”

“It is the only one you are receiving.”

Sabelle opened a ledger. The pages had been scraped thin in places, the ink lifted and replaced. Morwenna recognized the labor of a careful hand: not falsification, precisely, but the removal of a past that had become inconvenient.

“Caedmon found irregularities in the coastal inventories,” Sabelle said. “Entries altered after the Accord. Seal impressions repeated where they should not be. Cargo listed as ash, though no ash was recorded at the point of disposal.”

“Then question Caedmon.”

“I did.”

“And?”

“He answered.”

Morwenna almost smiled. “That is generally what happens when a scribe is questioned.”

“Not always.”

The brazier gave a small pop. A coal collapsed inward, glowing beneath its crust.

Sabelle closed the ledger. “There is a movement of information through the coast. Some of it originates with naval officers.”

“Some information originates everywhere.”

“Some of it reaches the Iron-Ring Cartel.”

The room held its breath.

Morwenna felt the message beneath her coat as distinctly as if it had become a hot coin against her ribs. She could imagine the Iron-Ring Cartel’s clerks receiving her report, breaking its seal, measuring each omission. They would not ask whether she believed in their cause. Cartels required no faith. They required appetite and arithmetic.

“I sell nothing,” Morwenna said.

Sabelle’s gaze rested upon her.

The lie came cleanly. That was what frightened her. Once, deception had required effort, a private twisting of the mind. Now it rose in her like a reflex of the body.

“You have not asked me whether I sell anything,” Sabelle said.

“I assumed the shape of the conversation.”

“Assumption is a form of confession.”

“Then you should have summoned a priest.”

“The abbey has priests.”

“Does it?”

Sabelle looked toward the door.

For the first time, something beneath their severity showed—not weakness, but attention turned inward, toward a locked chamber of the self. Morwenna had heard whispers about Sabelle Mournvale the Twice-Crowned, about the cellar beneath their quarters and what was kept there in bonds. A revenant, some said. A bound revenant, others insisted. The rumor possessed the stubbornness of truth because no one had survived long enough to prove it false.

Sabelle returned their attention to the table.

“Someone has begun searching for the artifact,” they said. “Someone with ships, records, and access to old military routes.”

“Then you have narrowed the field to half the realm.”

“I have narrowed it to you.”

The words struck more deeply than they should have.

Morwenna turned toward the map. Palewell Abbey stood at the edge of the marked coast, austere and watchful beneath its new stone. Beyond it lay the dark sea, folding itself into distance. Somewhere out there, vessels moved beneath low skies. Cargo changed hands. Messages crossed from mouth to mouth, from ledger to ledger, until truth became indistinguishable from the price paid for it.

“What do you want from me?” she asked.

Sabelle placed a sealed packet on the map.

“Open it.”

Morwenna did not move.

“You believe I am compromised,” she said.

“I believe everyone is compromised by something.”

“And you?”

A pause.

Then Sabelle smiled without warmth. “Especially me.”

The sealed packet bore no crest. No name. Only a line of black wax pressed flat as a scar.

Morwenna reached for it.

Beneath the floor, something struck the stone once.

Caedmon's voice cried out in the corridor.

Sabelle's head turned toward the door.

A second blow rose from below, heavier than the first, and the brazier flame bent sideways as if a great unseen breath had entered the room.

Morwenna's hand remained upon the packet.

The third blow did not come.

Silence gathered in its place, thick and listening. Dust sifted from the seams between the stones. Somewhere beyond the door, Caedmon made a wet, strangled sound, and then the corridor fell quiet enough for Morwenna to hear the small metal teeth of the brazier settling in the heat.

Sabelle had not moved. Their face was turned toward the door, but their eyes had gone distant, fixed upon something beneath the floor.

"You knew," Morwenna said.

"I suspected."

"You knew enough to bring me here."

"I brought you here because the walls of this room are older than the citadel's loyalties."

"That is not an answer."

"It is the only one that remains useful."

Morwenna broke the wax.

The seal gave with a soft crack. Its black fragments clung to her glove like flecks of congealed blood. Inside lay a single folded sheet, the paper thin and grey, its edges darkened as though it had been held too close to a flame. No handwriting marked the outside.

She unfolded it.

At first there appeared to be nothing but a column of figures, each written with the narrow precision of a clerk who had never mistaken neatness for innocence. Cargo weights. Mooring fees. Names reduced to initials. Locations without descriptions. Dates without explanation.

Then her eyes found the pattern.

The figures were not payments.

They were movements.

The Iron-Ring Cartel had been buying access to the fleet's blind places: shoals no chart admitted, watchtowers that sent their signals late, channels where fog gathered thick enough to swallow a vessel whole. The entries did not name captains. They named habits. A lantern extinguished. A chain left slack. A patrol delayed by the length of a prayer.

Morwenna read to the bottom.

There, beneath the last column, someone had written a sentence in red ink.

THEY KNOW WHAT YOU HAVE SOLD.

Her pulse did not change. That was the first discipline of command: never permit the body to confess before the mouth had chosen its lie.

Sabelle watched her.

“Is it true?” they asked.

Morwenna folded the sheet once. “Which part?”

“The part that troubles you.”

“I am troubled by your lack of specificity.”

“Then you are still yourself.”

The brazier flame shuddered. Its light withdrew from the walls, drawing inward until the room seemed to float in a black sea. The stone beneath Morwenna’s boots gave a low, patient groan.

She looked down.

A hairline fracture had opened across the floor, running from the table’s carved foot to the threshold. It was not wide enough for a finger. Darkness showed through it anyway.

Sabelle stepped back.

Not far. Only enough to make the movement visible.

Morwenna noticed. Sabelle Mournvale the Twice-Crowned was not a person who yielded ground without an audience to witness the yielding. Their severity had always seemed carved rather than worn, a thing of ceremony and sharpened belief. Yet now their shoulders had tightened beneath their robes.

“What is beneath us?” Morwenna asked.

“The old foundations.”

“Greyfell Citadel has no old foundations beneath this room.”

“You have studied the citadel?”

“I have studied every place where people pretend stone makes them safe.”

A sound came from below.

Not a blow this time. A dragging. Something pulled itself along the underside of the floor, slow enough to make each scrape distinct.

Morwenna felt the old instinct rise in her: measure distance, count exits, mark weapons. The room had one door. One narrow window overlooking darkness and whatever waited beyond it. Sabelle stood between her and both. The packet rested beneath her palm, and the paper seemed warmer now.

From the corridor came a whisper.

“Admiral.”

Caedmon.

Morwenna turned toward the door. "Caedmon?"

The whisper came again, thinner. "Do not let them open it."

Sabelle's expression did not change.

Morwenna caught that stillness and held it between them.

"Who is them?"

Caedmon's breath rasped on the other side of the door. "The dead."

"Caedmon," Sabelle said, voice hard enough to cut, "step away from the threshold."

"I saw the records."

"You saw nothing."

"I saw the names."

The dragging beneath the floor stopped.

Morwenna felt the silence press against her teeth.

Caedmon spoke again, louder now. "Caedmon Hollowmere fought in The Leaden Accord, fighting for The Ashen Vanguard."

The words struck the room strangely. Not as an answer. As a line torn from a ledger and forced into the living air.

Morwenna looked at Sabelle.

"Who is Caedmon Hollowmere?"

The High Inquisitor's mouth opened, then closed.

Beyond the door, Caedmon began to laugh. It was not a scribe's laughter, nor the brittle release of a frightened man. It came in measured bursts, each one ending in a wet click.

"He wrote it down," the voice said. "He wrote it all down."

"Open the door," Morwenna said.

"No."

It was the first refusal Sabelle had given her without ornament.

Morwenna slid the packet into the inner fold of her coat.

Sabelle noticed. Their gaze dropped to the motion and returned.

"You are making a mistake," they said.

"I have made several. This one may be useful."

"The document is bait."

"Most intelligence is."

"You believe it names you."

“I believe someone wants me to believe that.”

“And if they are right?”

Morwenna placed both hands upon the edge of the table. The map between them showed the realm as a field of old wounds: coastlines, passes, ruined holdings, roads that ended in ash. The five powers had each laid claim to portions of it in ink, blood, or silence. The borders touched nowhere cleanly. Every boundary was a threat pretending to be geography.

“If they are right,” she said, “then they have waited too long to kill me.”

Sabelle’s eyes narrowed.

“Perhaps they wanted you afraid first.”

“Fear is a private luxury. I have a fleet.”

“Your fleet cannot sail through a locked room.”

“No. But it can make a great deal of noise outside one.”

She crossed to the door.

Sabelle did not bar her way. That frightened her more than resistance would have.

Morwenna put her ear to the wood.

There was no sound from the corridor.

No breathing. No shifting cloth. No scrape of a boot.

She lifted the latch.

Sabelle seized her wrist.

The contact was brief, but their grip was astonishingly strong. Morwenna looked down at the fingers around her arm, then up at the Twice-Crowned face above them.

“Let go.”

“You do not understand what is kept below this place.”

“Then enlighten me.”

“I am preventing a greater breach.”

“Of what?”

Sabelle released her.

The silence that followed was shaped like an admission.

Morwenna opened the door.

The corridor lay empty.

Caedmon was gone.

A single trail marked the flagstones, dark and shining in the brazier’s weak spill. It led away from the room toward the stairwell. No footprints accompanied it. The trail began at the threshold and vanished

beneath the nearest wall, as though whatever had made it had been drawn through the stone.

Morwenna stepped out.

The air smelled of iron and wet earth.

Behind her, Sabelle spoke a word she had never heard them use.

Not an invocation. Not a command.

A name.

The floor split.

Stone folded inward with a roar. The room behind them dropped by the width of a hand, then another. The map table tipped, sending ink, cups, and loose instruments sliding toward the fissure. Morwenna caught the doorframe as the corridor pitched beneath her. Somewhere below, a vast chamber exhaled.

The sound was followed by voices.

Many voices.

Some pleaded. Some cursed. Some recited.

One voice called her by rank.

Another called her by the name she had been born with.

Sabelle caught the back of her coat and hauled her clear as the threshold collapsed into a jagged mouth. The brazier fell through first, its coals scattering like red eyes. Then the table. Then the map, which fluttered once in the hot dark before vanishing.

Morwenna clung to the wall.

The citadel trembled around them. Ancient dust rolled from the ceiling. A crack opened along the corridor's far stones, and from it came a pale gleam—not light exactly, but the suggestion of something that remembered light.

“What have you kept here?” she demanded.

Sabelle stood at the edge of the break, staring downward.

Their face had lost its composure.

Below, in the dark, something began to climb.

A hand appeared first, grey and jointed, its nails packed with black soil. It gripped the broken stone and pulled. A second hand joined it. The fingers trembled with effort or hunger.

Sabelle whispered, “I kept it bound.”

Morwenna reached for the knife beneath her coat.

“You said it was dead.”

“I said nothing of the sort.”

The thing hauled its shoulders above the edge.

A strip of rotted cloth hung from its neck. Beneath it, pressed into the ruin of its chest, gleamed a metal plate stamped with a name.

Morwenna could not read it.

The hand tightened on the stone.

Sabelle moved toward the creature.

Morwenna caught their sleeve. "If that is what you keep bound, why is it climbing?"

"Because someone opened the lower door."

"Who?"

The dead thing raised its head.

Its eyes were dark hollows, but something within those hollows turned toward Morwenna with unmistakable attention.

From the stairwell came Caedmon's voice, no longer frightened.

"Because the truth has been fed."

Sabelle wrenched free.

Morwenna drew her blade.

The revenant's mouth opened, and a spill of ancient dust poured over its tongue before it spoke.

"Admiral," it said.

Then, from beneath the citadel, a second voice answered in Sabelle's own voice.

The answer came from the dark below them.

"Admiral."

Morwenna's blade was already in her hand, its edge pale where the stairwell's dead light touched it. She did not look toward the second voice. To look would be to grant it shape. The ruin had learned that much about people: attention was a kind of blood.

Sabelle stood between her and the revenant, one hand raised. The gesture had once commanded obedience from courts, prisons, and battlefields. Here it seemed no more than a question posed to the dark.

"Come up," Sabelle said.

Their voice echoed downward.

A heartbeat later, the voice beneath them answered in the same tone.

"Come up."

Morwenna felt the old discipline within her draw tight. It was the discipline that had kept fleets steady beneath stormlight, that had made her give orders while men drowned and the sea burned. It was also the discipline that let her pass sealed intelligence into the hands of the Iron-Ring Cartel without allowing her hand to tremble when the price was named.

No fleet was here. No signal flags. No clean horizon.

Only Greyfell Citadel, abandoned in the Shattered Vale, with its stones sweating black moisture and its buried mouths opening one after another.

Caedmon descended three steps. His writing case hung against his side, knocking softly against the wall. The fear had gone from him, but it had left something worse in its place: conviction.

“Do not answer it,” he said.

Sabelle’s head turned a fraction. “You answered me.”

“That was you.”

“And the voice below?”

Caedmon looked at Morwenna. His eyes had the meticulous emptiness of a scribe who had found a discrepancy in a record and could not bear to leave it uncorrected.

“It knows what was written.”

“Then it knows lies,” Morwenna said.

“It knows what was concealed.”

The revenant made a low sound. Not a groan. Not breath. Something like parchment being slowly torn.

Sabelle moved toward it.

Morwenna caught their sleeve again. “You said it was bound.”

“It is.”

“Then bind it.”

“I did not bind its voice.”

The revenant’s fingers scraped over the stone. Its joints were swollen with old rot, but the nails were clean. That detail struck Morwenna with peculiar force. Clean nails on a dead thing. Someone had tended it. Someone had washed its hands, or commanded another to do so. The cellar had not been a prison abandoned to decay. It had been maintained.

The secret beneath Sabelle’s severity had always possessed a shape. Morwenna had imagined chains, sigils, a coffin sealed beneath a floor. She had not imagined care.

From below, her own voice whispered, “You sold the channel.”

A chill passed through her that had nothing to do with the citadel.

The Iron-Ring Cartel had never used that word. Their messages had spoken of routes, weather, shortages, movements of men and iron. They had paid in coin, favors, silence. They had never said *sold*. Not where ink might preserve it.

Sabelle looked at her.

The revenant’s hollow eyes remained fixed on Morwenna.

“Admiral,” it said again. “The Cartel knows.”

Morwenna stepped down until the point of her blade touched the revenant’s throat. The flesh there was grey and split, but beneath it something pulsed—not blood, not life, but a faint pressure moving in time

with the voice below.

“You have the wrong woman,” she said.

Her voice beneath the stair laughed.

The laugh was hers too.

Caedmon flinched. “It is drawing from you.”

“Then it will choke.”

Morwenna pressed the blade in. A bead of dark fluid welled beneath the edge. The revenant did not recoil. It leaned forward, inviting the steel.

Sabelle seized Morwenna’s wrist.

Their grip was not strong enough to overpower her. It did not need to be. Authority lived in the smallest movement when one had worn it long enough.

“Do not cut it,” Sabelle said.

“You keep a dead thing in your cellar and object to cutting?”

“I object to giving it an ending.”

Something slammed against the underside of the stair.

Dust sifted from above. The wall shuddered. For one instant, Morwenna saw the citadel as it must have appeared when it was young: grey towers unbroken, banners snapping in a wind not yet poisoned by the Sundering, guards standing watch where the stair descended into the earth. Then the vision collapsed, and she was back among cracked stones and the smell of wet ash.

The revenant raised one hand.

Sabelle went rigid.

The dead fingers pointed not at Morwenna, but at the writing case at Caedmon’s side.

“Open it,” said the voice below.

Caedmon wrapped both hands around the case.

“No.”

“Open it.”

The lock clicked.

Caedmon had not touched it.

He backed into the wall. The case swung once from its strap, and the leather fastenings uncoiled like small black tongues. Papers spilled across the steps. Some were blank. Some bore lines of cramped script, though the ink crawled and rearranged itself even as Morwenna watched.

Caedmon dropped to his knees.

“No,” he said again, more softly.

Sabelle released Morwenna and reached for the papers. Caedmon slapped their hand away.

“Do not read them.”

“I am High Inquisitor.”

“And I am the one who kept the record.”

“Of what?”

Caedmon’s mouth tightened. He looked toward the darkness beneath them.

“Of what was done when the host broke.”

The stairwell fell quiet.

Morwenna heard, far beyond the walls, the restless shifting of dead stone. She heard her own breathing. She heard the faint creak of leather as the loose papers stirred without wind.

Caedmon gathered them with shaking hands. One sheet had landed against Morwenna’s boot.

She saw a line before she could stop herself.

The Leaden Accord.

Below it, the ink had been scraped away so violently that the parchment was nearly pierced. Beneath the scar, another line showed through in fragments.

Both hosts—

The rest had been blackened.

Morwenna bent to seize the page.

Caedmon snatched it first.

His face had gone white.

“What did you conceal?” Sabelle asked.

“What was taken.”

“By whom?”

The voice beneath them answered.

“By all of you.”

A pressure gathered in the stairwell. It pushed against Morwenna’s ears, her teeth, the soft hollow behind her eyes. The revenant’s mouth opened wider. Dust streamed from it in a steady veil, but its body did not diminish. Beneath the dust, something pale moved behind the ribs.

Sabelle’s expression changed.

Not fear. Recognition.

“You know what is below,” Morwenna said.

“I know what should be below.”

“That is not an answer.”

“It is the only answer that matters.”

Morwenna turned on them. “You brought us here.”

“I brought you to the citadel.”

“You knew the lower door was open.”

“I knew it had been closed.”

“You knew the revenant could speak.”

“I knew it had spoken before.”

The admission passed between them like a blade laid flat on a table.

Morwenna imagined the hidden reports she had sent into the Cartel’s hands: the disposition of forces, the weaknesses of walls, the movement of supplies. She had told herself information was only information until someone used it. She had told herself every power already possessed its own knives. The Iron-Ring Cartel merely paid to know where the ribs were soft.

Now the dead thing knew.

Or something beneath it knew.

The five powers of the realm had made a habit of calling their hunger necessity. The Ashen Vanguard called it duty. House Morvain called it inheritance. The Silent Choir called it silence. The Iron-Ring Cartel called it trade. The Bleeding Crown called it law. Morwenna had served beneath each word without kneeling to any of them.

The second voice spoke from the dark.

“Morwenna Ashgrove.”

Her full name.

The stone seemed to contract around it.

She had not heard it spoken in that voice since—No. The thought stopped before it found a memory. This thing was not recalling. It was opening doors inside her.

Sabelle reached for the revenant’s face.

The dead thing seized their wrist.

The movement was so swift that Morwenna barely saw it. Sabelle struck the revenant across the jaw with their free hand. The impact cracked through the stairwell. The revenant’s head snapped sideways, but its fingers tightened.

Beneath the skin of Sabelle’s wrist, black lines surfaced.

Sabelle did not cry out. Their crown—both crowns, worn as a sign that had outlived the circumstances that made it—seemed suddenly less like regalia than a burden hammered into the skull.

“Release me,” they said.

The revenant turned its hollow gaze upon them.

“Twice-crowned,” it whispered.

Sabelle’s face hardened.

The voice below continued, "Once for the living. Once for the dead."

"Release me."

"You kept what should have been destroyed."

The words struck Sabelle more deeply than any blow. Morwenna saw it in the slight collapse of their shoulders, in the minute delay before they pulled against the dead grip.

Caedmon stared at them.

"You said the lower door was opened," he said. "You did not say it was opened from outside."

Sabelle tore their wrist free. The black lines vanished beneath the skin.

"Because it was not opened from outside."

Morwenna raised her blade again. "Then who opened it?"

Sabelle looked down.

The darkness below had begun to glow.

Not with flame. With a dim, colourless radiance that seemed to come from the bones of the citadel itself. It climbed the walls in branching veins. The old mortar split. Somewhere beneath their feet, a mechanism groaned awake after years without motion.

Caedmon's papers lifted into the air.

The blank sheets filled first.

One by one, they turned toward Morwenna.

On each appeared a single sentence in her own hand.

The channel was clear.

Another.

The message was received.

Another.

No one will know.

Her stomach clenched.

The revenant released a breath that had been waiting in its corpse for centuries.

Below them, a door began to open.

Not the lower door. Something behind it.

Sabelle stepped backward. For the first time since Morwenna had known them, the High Inquisitor looked without command.

Caedmon rose, clutching the ruined record to his chest.

"Admiral," he said.

Morwenna did not take her eyes from the widening black beneath the stairs.

“What?”

He swallowed.

“The voice is not repeating what you said.”

The darkness opened another inch.

A pale shape pressed against the gap from the other side. It had no face, only the suggestion of one, as though a face had been remembered by someone who had never seen a human being.

Caedmon’s voice broke.

“It is repeating what you have not said yet.”

Chapter 5

The bells of Fenspire had been silent for three nights, yet Malchior Cindervale the Flame-Touched still heard them tolling beneath the stone.

They stood before the narrow window of the upper archive, one palm resting against the cold wall, while the Gloaming Reach drowned beneath a skin of ash-colored rain. Fenspire's stark spire rose through the murk beyond the glass, black against black, its foundations sunk deep in the year 57 AS. The fortress had been old when the world was young enough to remember its own wounds. Now its garrison of 3,742 kept watch over a land that no longer knew what it guarded.

Behind Malchior, parchment whispered.

"Read it again," they said.

The clerk swallowed. "The quarantine at Gloamreach remains in force."

"Again."

"The quarantine at Gloamreach remains in force."

"And the reason?"

The clerk's voice thinned. "Uncertainty of contagion. Uncertainty of allegiance. Uncertainty of—"

"Allegiance is not a fever."

"No, Arch-Prelate."

The title entered the room like a blade laid upon a table. Malchior did not turn. Their reflection hovered in the window: the severe black of the office vestments, the pale flare of the sacred thread at the throat, the face fashioned into calm. Flame-Touched, the old records called them. The word had been made to sound like blessing. In the mirror-dark, it looked more like an accusation.

Gloamreach lay on the Pale Coast, sealed from the surrounding coast by gates, patrols, and fear. Its garrison was 2,483. The number sat in Malchior's mind with the weight of a stone. Too many mouths for a sealed town. Too few hands if the gates failed.

"Who brought this?" Malchior asked.

The clerk lowered the page. "Warden-Commander Ignatz Ashgrove the Oathless."

At last Malchior turned.

Ignatz waited beside the iron stove, still wearing the authority of command as though it were armor that had begun to rust from within. No canonical feature marked him in the old ledgers; only the epithet followed him, and the office. Warden-Commander. The Oathless. His silence had the distrustful shape of a locked door.

On the far side of the chamber, Isolde Fellgard the Unforgiven watched him with one hand resting against the sleeve of her blood-red coat. She was a Blood-Mage, and the air near her seemed to remember it. Not visibly. Not yet. But the rain tapped the window in a rhythm too close to a pulse.

Malchior knew the record of her birth: 286 AS. They knew, too, what the record did not say. Isolde had plotted the death of her own liege. The secret had survived because secrets were more durable than kings.

“Leave us,” Malchior told the clerk.

The clerk gathered the parchment. “Arch-Prelate—”

“Leave us.”

The door shut. Its latch clicked with a finality that made Malchior’s forged lineage papers seem to rustle beneath their robes.

They had written the papers themselves, years ago, copying the hands of dead archivists and inventing the descent that had raised them to sanctified authority. Every seal had been warmed, pressed, and cooled beneath their fingers. Every name in the chain had been chosen from graves no living mouth could question. Their birth, 289 AS, had been a fact. Everything before it was architecture.

Isolde’s gaze lingered on their face.

“You look tired,” she said.

“I look consecrated.”

“You look as though consecration has teeth.”

“It does.”

Ignatz gave a short, humorless breath. “The quarantine cannot hold forever.”

“Then it will hold until it breaks,” Malchior said.

“Gloomreach is not the only concern.”

“No. It is merely the concern behind which you have chosen to hide the others.”

The Warden-Commander’s eyes hardened. “Five powers contend over the ruins. The Ashen Vanguard. House Morvain. The Silent Choir. The Iron-Ring Cartel. The Bleeding Crown. Each claims the realm can still be gathered into one hand. Each sends hunger dressed as doctrine.”

“And which hand gathers Gloomreach?”

Ignatz did not answer.

The stove exhaled a bitter breath. Coal-smoke threaded the room, mingling with the damp wool of their cloaks and the mineral stink of the fortress walls. Malchior could taste iron at the back of their throat. It was an old taste, older than office, older than the lies that had made office possible.

Isolde moved toward the table. “The report mentions Blackport.”

“The report mentions everything,” Ignatz said.

“Then mention it aloud.”

He looked at Malchior, not at her. That was a mistake. Isolde smiled without warmth.

“The Purge of Blackport began in 311 AS,” Ignatz said. “It ended in 321 AS. Seventy thousand nine hundred and seven casualties.”

“70,907,” Malchior said.

The number seemed to darken the room.

Ignatz's jaw shifted. "The aggressors were totally routed."

"The Iron-Ring Cartel emerged as victor," Isolde said. "That is what the ledgers say."

"That is what the ledgers are permitted to say."

The rain thickened against the glass. Fenspire's sentries moved along the high parapets, reduced by distance to pieces on a game board. Malchior imagined the whole Gloaming Reach laid out beneath a hand: the spire, the sealed coast, the roads fading into ash. Somewhere beyond the rain, Gloamreach waited behind its quarantine, and something inside it waited as well.

"The concealed truth," Ignatz said, "is that the victors poisoned the wells of their own allies."

The words did not echo. Stone was often more merciful than memory.

Isolde's fingers tightened on the table's edge. "Their own allies."

"The wells were fouled before the final advance. Fever, thirst, panic. By the time the Cartel entered Blackport, the surviving defenders could barely stand."

"And you know this because?" Malchior asked.

Ignatz's expression did not move, but something behind it withdrew.

"Because the truth has a price," he said.

There it was: not confession, but the shape of one.

Malchior had seen the Iron-Ring Cartel's account books once. Not the whole of them. Enough. Intelligence traveled along hidden roads, and Ignatz Ashgrove the Oathless sold intelligence to the Iron-Ring Cartel. The fact had not yet been placed in any official record. It had not needed to be. A man's silences could be more legible than ink.

"You speak with unusual precision," Malchior said.

"I speak with the precision required to keep Fenspire standing."

"Fenspire has stood since 57 AS."

"Stone does not stand by virtue of age."

"No," Isolde said. "It stands because someone keeps paying for the blood in its mortar."

Her voice had softened. That was worse than anger. Malchior watched her hand. Blood-Mages were taught to conceal their work in the smallest gestures: a pressure at the wrist, a fingernail drawn across a seam, a breath held one moment too long. Isolde had plotted the death of her own liege. Such treachery did not make her careless. It made her patient.

"You want the quarantine lifted," Malchior said.

"I want the gates opened."

"To what?"

"To witnesses."

The word fell between them.

Ignatz glanced toward the window. "There are messages from the coast. People inside Gloamreach claim the garrison has begun to ration water."

"The garrison is 2,483," Malchior said. "The number has not changed."

"Numbers do not drink."

"Nor do they lie."

"Numbers are the first lie ever told."

Malchior felt the forged papers beneath their robes again, though they were not there. Their skin prickled as if a hidden flame had been brought too near. For a moment the chamber seemed to narrow around them, the walls leaning inward to hear whether the Arch-Prelate's blood was pure, whether the sanctity had a foundation deeper than ink.

They reached for the report.

The parchment was wet at one corner.

Malchior looked down. A dark stain had spread through the fibers, reddish-brown, not rainwater. Isolde's hand remained on the table. A thin line of red had appeared beneath one of her nails.

"You have been reading this already," Malchior said.

"I have been touching it."

"Those are not the same."

"They are, when the page is afraid."

Ignatz stepped forward. "There is more."

"There is always more."

"The coast road from Gloamreach to Fenspire is being watched."

"By whom?"

He hesitated.

Malchior folded the report. "You sell intelligence to the Iron-Ring Cartel. Do not sell me hesitation."

The room became very still.

Isolde's eyes gleamed, not with surprise but appetite. Ignatz's hand drifted toward the weapon at his side and stopped before touching it. The gesture was so small that another person might have missed it. Malchior did not.

"I sell what keeps the realm from burning," Ignatz said.

"The realm is already ash."

"Then I sell the shape of the ash."

"And the Cartel pays you?"

Ignatz's silence answered.

Outside, one of the sentries lifted a horn but did not sound it. Along the lower wall, a gate chain groaned. The noise traveled upward through the stone, a slow metallic shudder, as if Fenspire itself had woken beneath them.

Isolde tilted her head.

“Someone is at the gate.”

“No one enters Fenspire without notice,” Ignatz said.

“Then someone has entered without notice.”

Malchior crossed to the window. Through the rain they saw torchlight below: three points wavering in the courtyard, then four. A figure stood between them, hooded and motionless. No banner. No escort. The gatehouse guards had lowered their spears, but not raised the alarm.

The Flame-Touched Arch-Prelate pressed two fingers to the glass.

Heat answered from somewhere beneath the skin.

Their claimed lineage was suspect. Their authority was strained. Their name rested upon papers forged by their own hand. Yet the fire came when called, and that had always been the most dangerous proof.

“Open the archive door,” Malchior said.

Ignatz stared at them. “Why?”

“Because whoever waits below has come for the accounting.”

Isolde’s smile widened.

Malchior felt the old bells begin again, tolling under the stone, while from the courtyard there rose a voice too low to distinguish and a second voice answering from within the fortress.

Then the lights went out.

The dark did not arrive all at once.

It gathered first in the corners, thickening where the lamps had burned. Then it climbed the walls in slow black folds, swallowing the painted saints, the iron sconces, the pale square of the archive door. Somewhere below, a hinge groaned. The voice in the courtyard ceased. The answering voice within the fortress breathed once against the stone.

Malchior kept two fingers upon the glass.

Heat answered.

A coal-red thread opened beneath the skin of their hand and ran toward the wrist, thin as a vein seen through ice. The old fire had never been obedient. It had only been persuaded to appear where obedience would do the most harm.

“Ignatz,” they said.

“I am here.”

His voice came from near the door. A scrape of metal followed, then the muted click of a sword being drawn. Warden-Commander Ignatz Ashgrove the Oathless had a talent for making every silence sound

accused.

“Where is Isolde?”

“Where you left them.”

A soft laugh moved through the dark.

“Liar,” Isolde Fellgard the Unforgiven said.

Their voice came from the opposite side of the chamber, close enough that Malchior felt the warmth of another body in the cold. Blood-Mage. Born in 286 AS. The record had been copied in three hands, each hand trembling differently. Their liege had died without a blade wound, and Isolde had mourned with such perfect grief that even the dead might have believed it.

Malchior lifted their hand from the glass.

The thread of fire brightened.

For one breath, the chamber returned: the long archive table, the black ribs of the ceiling, Ignatz standing with one hand upon his sword and the other hidden in his coat. Isolde stood beneath the sealed door, smiling as if the darkness had been arranged for their pleasure.

Then the flame folded inward.

“Do not use that,” Ignatz said.

“You object to light?”

“I object to what answers it.”

The bells beneath the stone gave another toll. It was not loud. It did not need to be. The sound passed through Malchior’s bones, finding the places where old vows had been buried and shaking them awake.

The archive door opened by itself.

Not wide. A seam first, blacker than the surrounding dark, then the slow widening of a mouth. Cold air spilled from the stair beyond. It smelled of dust, salt, and something sweet that had gone rotten in a sealed jar.

No one moved.

Malchior heard their own breathing and hated it for being so mortal.

On the threshold, carved into the stone, the seal of the Ashen Vanguard had been scored through. Beneath it, five marks waited in a circle: the Vanguard’s ash-spear, House Morvain’s crowned thorn, the closed eye of the Silent Choir, the linked rings of the Iron-Ring Cartel, and the bleeding diadem of the Bleeding Crown.

The five powers had come to the same door without coming together. That was the shape of the realm after the Sundering: every hand upon the same throat, each finger pretending not to feel the others.

Ignatz stepped forward.

Malchior raised a hand. “No.”

His sword stopped halfway from his body.

“Why?” he asked.

“Because the door opened for me.”

“Nothing opens for free.”

“Then we will discover the price.”

Isolde moved past him. The hem of their robe brushed the floor with a dry whisper. “You sound like a priest.”

“I am an Arch-Prelate.”

“No.” Isolde tilted their head. “You serve as Arch-Prelate. There is a difference.”

The fire under Malchior’s skin shivered.

There it was: the little blade slipped between the ribs. Their claimed lineage was written on paper they had forged with their own hand. The ink had been mixed with ash and a drop of blood, because desperation had made ritual seem more convincing than truth. They had copied the names of the dead until the letters began to look like wounds.

The documents were locked beneath this fortress.

Or they had been.

“Walk,” Malchior said.

The stair descended farther than the foundations should have allowed. Its walls sweated black moisture. Each step had been worn shallow at the center, though the dust lay undisturbed along the edges. Someone had used the passage recently. Someone had carried something heavy.

Ignatz came behind them, silent now.

Malchior did not turn. “You have been in the lower archive.”

“No.”

“Your boots say otherwise.”

“Your fire says too much.”

Isolde’s fingers touched the wall. They left a dark smear that glistened wetly before sinking into the stone.

“Blood remembers paths,” they murmured.

“Stone remembers weight,” Ignatz said.

“And men remember coin.”

The pause after that was small and complete.

Malchior slowed.

Behind them, Ignatz breathed in through his nose. The Oathless had sold intelligence to the Iron-Ring Cartel, though no confession had been dragged from him and no seal had broken upon his tongue. Malchior knew because the wrong reports had reached the wrong hands, because patrols had vanished from roads that only a handful of commanders knew existed, because Cartel agents had begun anticipating orders before they were issued.

Ignatz's secrecy clung to him more heavily than armor.

"Careful," he said.

"Are you warning me?"

"I am advising restraint."

"You advise restraint whenever your purse is threatened."

His sword came free.

The sound ran down the stair like a drawn breath.

Isolde looked back, their smile gone now. "There it is."

At the bottom, a corridor opened beneath the fortress. The ceiling was low enough that Ignatz had to bow his head. Narrow shelves had been built into both walls, packed with ledgers, sealed scrolls, bone tablets, and small clay vessels marked with dates.

Malchior's gaze caught on one line of ink.

Fenspire. Founded in 57 AS. Garrison: 3,742. Status: garrisoned.

The figures were written in red.

Farther along, another ledger had been pulled free and left open upon the floor.

Gloamreach. Pale Coast. Garrison: 2,483. Status: quarantined.

The word seemed to breathe.

Beyond the shelves, a map had been nailed to the wall. The coast had been drawn in a pallid wash, the land beyond it rendered in dim gray. Fenspire stood as a black spire in the Gloaming Reach. Gloamreach lay farther out, sealed behind a ring of red ink.

"Who keeps these records?" Ignatz asked.

"Those who expect the realm to survive its rulers."

"That is not an answer."

"It is the only one we have."

A sound came from behind the far wall.

Three taps.

Then two.

Isolde pressed their palm flat against the stone. The skin at their wrist opened in a fine red line. Blood welled and ran downward, but did not fall. It crawled across the wall, following cracks that had been invisible until then.

Malchior caught their arm.

The blood stopped.

Isolde looked at the hand around their wrist. "You touch me as if I belong to you."

“I touch you as if you are about to kill us.”

“I have killed for less flattering accusations.”

Their eyes held his in the dark.

The liege, Malchior thought. The plotted death. The hidden hand behind it. The grief worn afterward like a ceremonial veil. Isolde had never denied the shape of the crime. They denied only the shame.

“Release me,” Isolde said.

Malchior did.

The blood withdrew into the cut. The wound sealed with a wet gleam.

Another three taps came from the wall.

Then two.

Ignatz turned toward the stair. “We should leave.”

The archive door above slammed shut.

Dust fell in a soft gray veil.

No one spoke.

From the wall came a voice.

“Malchior Cindervale the Flame-Touched.”

The name was pronounced with care, each syllable tested.

Malchior’s mouth dried.

The fire stirred in their hand, hungry now.

“Show yourself,” Ignatz commanded.

“Warden-Commander Ignatz Ashgrove the Oathless.”

Ignatz’s sword lifted.

The voice continued.

“Born in 258 AS.”

His silence was answer enough.

Isolde began to laugh beneath their breath.

“Isolde Fellgard the Unforgiven,” said the wall. “Born in 286 AS.”

The Blood-Mage’s amusement faded.

“Malchior Cindervale the Flame-Touched. Born in 289 AS.”

The corridor seemed to narrow.

The voice did not mention their office. It did not call them Arch-Prelate. It named the birth and nothing more, as though everything earned afterward were counterfeit.

Malchior placed their palm against the wall.

Heat spread through the stone. Dust leapt from the mortar. Somewhere beyond, something withdrew with a wet scrape.

“Open,” Malchior said.

A panel shifted.

Behind it lay a chamber no larger than a cell. A single table waited within. Upon the table rested three objects: a blackened crown, a sealed iron ring, and a ledger bound in pale leather.

The iron ring bore the mark of the Cartel.

The crown dripped no blood, yet the stone beneath it was stained as though it had bled there for years.

The ledger lay open to a page headed:

The Purge of Blackport.

Malchior stepped inside.

The ink was dark and crowded.

The Purge of Blackport began in 311 AS and ended in 321 AS. Casualties: 70,907. The aggressors were totally routed. The Iron-Ring Cartel emerged as victor.

Below that, in a hand nearly erased by scraping, another sentence remained.

The victors poisoned the wells of their own allies.

Ignatz stood behind Malchior, very still.

Isolde read over their shoulder. “So the Cartel won by killing the people who made victory possible.”

“Not all victories are clean,” Ignatz said.

“No,” Malchior replied. “Some are merely well concealed.”

The sealed iron ring trembled on the table.

A drop of water struck the ledger.

Then another.

Malchior looked upward.

Nothing moved above them, but the ceiling had begun to darken. Water gathered in the cracks, black and shining. It slid down the walls in thin streams, carrying the smell of salt and rot.

Gloomreach.

The quarantined coast had found a way beneath the fortress.

The voice spoke again, now from inside the chamber.

“Your papers.”

Malchior stared at the pale leather ledger.

Their pulse struck once, hard.

Isolde's head turned toward them. Ignatz's sword lowered by a fraction, not from mercy but attention.

"Your lineage," the voice said. "Read it aloud."

The forged pages were somewhere beneath the floor. They could feel them—not with sight, not with touch, but with the old certainty by which fire recognized dry timber.

Malchior placed both hands upon the ledger.

The cover was warm.

"Open the book," Isolde whispered.

"I am trying."

"No." Their voice sharpened. "You are deciding whether to lie."

The water reached Malchior's boots.

In the dark beyond the table, something inhaled.

And the first page began to turn beneath their hands.

The page turned without a hand.

Ink bled through the fibers in thin black veins. Malchior watched the letters gather, separate, and gather again until they formed a line that seemed to have been written by a trembling child.

Malchior Cindervale the Flame-Touched, born in 289 AS.

The water lapped higher around their boots.

Isolde's breath touched the side of their face. "There."

"I can read."

"Then read."

Malchior found the words in their throat and held them there. The ledger's warmth had become a fever. Beneath the floor, the forged pages waited in darkness, their false seals softening in the damp. They had prepared lies for courts, for altars, for frightened men who needed ancestry to make obedience seem holy. They had not prepared a lie for a book that knew the shape of truth.

"Malchior Cindervale the Flame-Touched," they said. Their voice did not break. That was something. "Born in 289 AS."

Ignatz Ashgrove the Oathless shifted behind them. Leather creaked. Steel whispered against its sheath.

The ledger turned another page.

A second line appeared.

Arch-Prelate.

The title stood alone, stark as a gallows.

Malchior felt the old pressure settle across their shoulders—not the weight of vestments or the ceremonial chain at their throat, but the weight of every kneeling head they had blessed. They had learned, long ago, that sanctity was often a posture held until the room believed it. Chin raised. Hands still. Eyes lowered at

precisely the proper moment.

The book had no use for posture.

“Arch-Prelate,” Isolde repeated. “That is what you claim.”

“It is what I serve as.”

“Serve,” she said, and the word came wetly, almost fond. “You make a sacrament of verbs.”

The ledger’s pages fluttered though the room was windless.

Malchior looked toward her. The dimness made a blade of her cheek. Isolde Fellgard the Unforgiven stood with one hand bare and the other stained dark to the wrist. Blood-Mage, the courts called her when they wanted to frighten petitioners into silence. She wore the title as another person might wear mourning; not to display grief, but to keep it near.

She had plotted the death of her own liege.

The knowledge rested between them, unspoken and sharp. Malchior had seen the evidence once, sealed beneath a confession that had never reached its intended reader. A thread of blood drawn through a map. A name cut out of a prayer. Isolde’s work, or work done in her manner. She had never denied it. Denial, to her, was merely confession with better manners.

The page showed a new line.

Lineage:—

Nothing followed.

A clean emptiness.

The thing beneath the floor inhaled again.

Ignatz came around the table. The water folded away from his boots and returned with a soft, sucking sound. He was a Warden-Commander, born in 258 AS, and the old title clung to him more stubbornly than any oath. Oathless, they called him. A name that had begun as accusation and hardened into rank.

His gaze stayed on the ledger.

“Read the blank,” he said.

Malchior’s fingers tightened on the cover. “There is nothing to read.”

“There is always something written in a blank space.”

“You should know.” Isolde’s eyes did not leave him. “You have sold enough secrets to learn their price.”

Ignatz’s attention moved to her.

For one instant, no one breathed.

Then the water stirred around Malchior’s ankles as if something below had smiled.

Ignatz secretly sold intelligence to the Iron-Ring Cartel. The fact had reached Malchior in fragments: patrol routes altered without orders, supply wagons diverted toward roads no Warden had marked, sealed reports appearing in hands that had no right to possess them. Ignatz had not been careless. Carelessness was for men who believed innocence could protect them.

“Careful,” he said.

Isolde’s stained hand lifted. A thread of red stretched from her fingers into the water, thin as spun glass. “I am always careful.”

“You plotted the death of your own liege,” Malchior said.

The blood-thread quivered.

He had not intended to speak the words aloud. They escaped with the sour taste of truth.

Isolde smiled, but there was no warmth in it. “And you forged your own lineage papers.”

The ledger snapped shut.

The sound shook dust from the beams.

Malchior’s reflection trembled across the cover. Flame-light lived in their eyes though no flame burned in the room. The old name—Flame-Touched—had been placed upon them by mouths that desired a miracle and could not bear the ordinary ugliness of survival. They had let it remain. They had built around it. They had forged the papers because the realm demanded a bloodline before it would permit a person to stand above the altar.

Not a lie, they had told themselves.

A bridge.

A bridge was still made of false timber if the river took it.

The floorboards groaned.

From below came the unmistakable scrape of paper against stone.

Isolde’s head tilted. “Bring them up.”

“I cannot.”

“You can.”

“The water has reached the foundation.”

“Then drown with them.”

The voice beneath the table spoke through the wood.

“Blackport.”

Malchior’s hands went cold.

The ledger opened by itself.

Ink flooded the first page, running in rivulets that gathered into a heading.

The Purge of Blackport.

The letters shone with a dull, rust-colored sheen.

Ignatz swore under his breath.

Malchior had stood in Blackport after the last fires died. They remembered no faces clearly—only mouths open in the dust, only the sour reek rising from wells whose surfaces shone with an oily rainbow. The Purge of Blackport began in 311 AS and ended in 321 AS. It caused 70,907 casualties. The aggressors were totally routed.

The Iron-Ring Cartel emerged as victor.

Those were the words carved into every official account.

The truth had been kept beneath the words, where water could reach it.

The victors had poisoned the wells of their own allies.

Malchior read aloud.

At the final sentence, the room seemed to contract around them.

“The Iron-Ring Cartel poisoned the wells of their own allies,” they said.

Ignatz moved first.

His sword came free in a pale arc, and Isolde’s blood-thread hardened into a line of red glass. The ledger slammed shut between them, its cover striking Malchior’s knuckles. Pain flashed bright enough to make the room vanish.

When sight returned, the boards beneath the table had split.

The forged pages rose through the crack.

They came slowly, sodden and gray, pushing upward as though the dead were offering scraps of skin. Wax seals floated loose from them. Malchior saw their own hand in every false stroke: the careful imitation of a dead clerk’s script, the invented descent, the heraldic mark copied from a shield glimpsed under rain.

Their lineage.

Their salvation.

Their sentence.

Isolde seized the top page. The blood in her hand ran across it, following the ink as if both had been made for the same purpose.

“You made these,” she said.

Malchior did not answer.

Ignatz’s sword point rested against their ribs. “How many copies?”

“Enough.”

“That is not a number.”

“It was never meant to be counted.”

The Warden-Commander’s mouth tightened. “The Cartel will pay for the original.”

A silence followed—not surprise, but confirmation.

Malchior looked at him. "So they know."

"They know what matters."

"They know you sell intelligence."

"They know I deliver it."

"And what do they intend to purchase tonight?"

Ignatz's sword pressed harder. Through the cloth, the cold entered Malchior's flesh.

Isolde turned the wet page. "Perhaps they intend to purchase an Arch-Prelate with no blood behind the title."

"Perhaps," Ignatz said.

"Perhaps they intend to purchase a throne."

The word struck harder than the sword.

Beyond the chamber walls, bells began to ring.

Not the measured bells of worship. Not the warning peal used to summon wardens. These were broken, irregular blows, as if someone had thrown a body against the bell-rope.

Malchior counted the intervals without meaning to. The sound carried through stone and water, through the hidden corridors where servants slept beneath their blankets and armed men waited for orders they believed came from a living world.

The five powers of the Ashen Era had learned to wait for weakness.

The Ashen Vanguard would call this a breach of sacred order. House Morvain would call it an opportunity. The Silent Choir would call it a confession. The Iron-Ring Cartel would call it a bargain. The Bleeding Crown would call it proof that every crown was only a wound held upright.

The ledger opened again.

This time the page held no writing.

A drop of blood fell from Isolde's hand and struck the paper.

The blank drank it.

Words rose beneath the red stain.

Gloamreach. Pale Coast. Quarantined. Garrison: 2,483.

Malchior's stomach tightened.

A second line appeared beneath it.

Fenspire. Gloaming Reach. Founded in 57 AS. Garrison: 3,742. Garrisoned.

The names seemed to possess distance. Gloamreach came with the taste of salt and ash, sealed away from the Pale Coast by suspicion no decree had been strong enough to lift. Fenspire stood in the mind like a single dark tooth above the Gloaming Reach, its soldiers watching through narrow windows, its vigilance made permanent by fear.

No one in the room had spoken those places.

Yet the ledger wrote them as if they had been waiting beneath Malchior's tongue.

Isolde leaned closer. Her voice fell to a murmur. "What connects them?"

"I don't know."

"That is the first honest thing you have said."

The page shuddered.

A line formed under the locations.

The forged lineage opens the sealed road.

Malchior stared until the letters blurred.

The chamber filled with a smell of wet iron. Beneath the floor, something struck the stones once. Then again. Patiently. It was not trying to escape.

It was knocking.

Ignatz withdrew his sword a fraction. "What sealed road?"

Malchior's pulse beat against the blade.

In the ledger's polished cover, their reflection changed. The face remained theirs, but the eyes showed another light: a burning gate, a procession of figures moving beneath a sky the color of old bruises, and beyond them a throne with no one seated upon it.

The book turned one final page.

There, in ink still shining wet, was a sentence addressed to them alone.

Read aloud the name you forged.

Malchior opened their mouth.

From beneath the floor, the hidden pages answered in their own voice.

Chapter 6

Rain worried the roofs of Hollowvale like a patient hand seeking a weakness.

Morwenna Ashgrove stood beneath the open arch of the command tower and watched the lower yards drown by degrees. Water slid from the parapets in silver cords. It gathered in the ruts between the stores, darkened the ash, and carried splinters of old timber toward the sluice. Below, figures moved through the weather with their heads bowed, cloaks drawn tight, their labor reduced to gestures in the grey.

She had commanded Hollowvale since 311 AS.

The fact had been written into ledgers, proclamations, orders sealed in wax and pressed beneath rings. It had been spoken aloud in halls where men measured a woman's authority by the number of witnesses willing to deny it. Since 311 AS, every wall, vessel, chain of stores, and watchfire here had answered to her.

Yet the fortress had never felt like hers.

Ownership was a word for merchants and fools. Command was the narrower, colder thing. It meant that when the gate opened, someone had decided it. When the bells sounded, someone had chosen the hour. When a body was carried from the yard beneath a sheet, the silence around it belonged to the officer who had permitted the silence to remain.

Morwenna kept her hands clasped behind her back.

The document in her sleeve had begun to soften from the damp.

Across the tower chamber, Caedmon Fellgard bent over the table with a quill in his hand. He was a Scribe, and his posture had the disciplined misery of a man who believed disorder to be a moral offense. Ink, sand, folded papers, and narrow tablets occupied every inch before him. He had arranged them according to a system Morwenna had never understood and had never disturbed. Caedmon would rather lose a page than find it in the wrong place.

"Read it again," she said.

Caedmon's quill paused.

"The account of the western stores?"

"The other one."

He lowered his eyes to the sheet. "You have heard it twice."

"I have heard your voice twice. That is not the same thing."

The Scribe drew breath through his nose. He was reserved even in irritation, which made his irritation more visible. "The report states that three sealed crates were received after nightfall. Their marks were damaged. The porter who signed for them could not identify the sender. The seals were—"

"Not the crates."

Caedmon looked up.

Morwenna turned from the arch. The chamber smelled of wet wool, lamp oil, and the metallic cold that came down from the stone. "The note beneath it."

“The private notation?”

“Read it.”

His gaze shifted toward the door.

No one stood there. No one that Morwenna could see. That did not make the room empty. Hollowvale had more ears than windows. Servants listened because listening cost nothing. Guards listened because fear trained them to. Clerks listened because secrets gave shape to their otherwise shapeless lives.

Caedmon folded his hands over the report. “It is not entered into the register.”

“Then you may read it without entering it.”

“That is contrary to my office.”

“Your office is to keep records. Mine is to decide which records deserve to survive.”

The rain thickened against the archway. A gust drove mist into the chamber, feathering the nearest candles. Caedmon placed one hand over the papers until the corners settled.

““The Iron-Ring Cartel has moved agents along the coast,”” he read. ““Their interest remains fixed upon the disposition of the old—””

He stopped.

“Continue.”

“The last word is illegible.”

Morwenna almost smiled. “How convenient.”

“I did not make the weather.”

“No. You merely make certain it is remembered.”

A shadow passed across Caedmon’s face. He bent again over the paper. “The note concludes that the Cartel believes the command at Hollowvale has received no intelligence regarding their movements.”

“And has it?”

Caedmon’s fingers tightened on the page. “I am not the commander.”

“No. You are a Scribe.”

“I know what I am.”

“Then record the answer.”

He raised the quill, though there was no ink on its nib. “What answer?”

Morwenna looked toward the rain.

For nine years she had worn Hollowvale’s authority. Since 311 AS, the fortress had spoken through her orders. It had spoken of shortages, patrols, quarrels, disappearances, and the small humiliations by which a garrison was kept obedient. But another voice had traveled out from these walls, hidden beneath official dispatches and carried by hands that never knew what they carried.

The Iron-Ring Cartel paid for certainty.

Morwenna sold them intelligence.

Not allegiance. Allegiance was too tender a word for what passed between them. She sold them movements, dispositions, weaknesses in the chain. She sold them the shape of danger before danger acquired a face. Each piece left her in a different form: a correction in a cargo manifest, a delayed order, a sentence altered by one word. No confession survived the transaction. No signature bound her to it.

Only the consequences remained.

“The answer,” she said, “is that Hollowvale has received nothing.”

Caedmon’s expression did not change, but his silence sharpened.

“Nothing?” he asked.

“Write it.”

“If that is false—”

“It is an official answer.”

“That was not my question.”

Morwenna approached the table. The floor was cold through her boots. “You are becoming bold, Caedmon Fellgard.”

“I am becoming tired.”

“Tired men make errors.”

“Errors are entered into the record. Tired men are not.”

His voice remained quiet. That was the danger in him. A louder man could be dismissed, punished, frightened into obedience. Caedmon offered no surface to strike. He simply remained, meticulous and pale beneath the lamplight, asking the question again by refusing to pretend he had not asked it.

Morwenna placed two fingers on the edge of the private notation.

“Write,” she said.

He dipped the quill.

Before its point touched the page, the bell below began to toll.

Once.

The sound crossed the rain and entered the chamber as a pressure rather than a note. Caedmon froze. The second toll came lower, swallowed by the walls. On the third, voices rose in the yard.

Morwenna did not move toward the stair.

“Who is arriving?” Caedmon asked.

“If the bell knew, it would not be ringing.”

A fourth toll. Then a fifth.

Not an alarm. The measured summons reserved for someone who carried authority enough to make delay dangerous.

Caedmon sanded the wet ink and closed the report. "Should I prepare the receiving register?"

"No."

"Then what should I prepare?"

"Nothing that can be found."

He looked at her, and for the first time she saw fear beneath the reserve. It was not fear for himself. That would have been simpler. It was fear of being forced to write what he understood.

The tower door opened without a knock.

Sabelle Mournvale the Twice-Crowned entered with rain darkening the shoulders of their coat. They brought the weather in with them: the smell of wet stone, extinguished ash, and the bitter herbs burned in sanctuaries when prayers had failed. Their office seemed to arrive before them. High Inquisitor. The words needed no announcement.

Their gaze passed over Caedmon, the table, the papers, and came to rest on Morwenna.

"Sabelle Mournvale the Twice-Crowned," Morwenna said.

"Fleet Admiral."

The title sounded like a judgment when Sabelle spoke it.

Morwenna inclined her head. "You have traveled through unpleasant weather."

"I have traveled through worse."

There were many answers to that. Morwenna selected none.

Sabelle removed one glove finger by finger. "I require the Cartel's latest movements."

Caedmon lowered his eyes.

Morwenna watched the glove come free. Sabelle's hands were steady. Their severity was not theatrical. It lived in the economy of every gesture, in the refusal to waste motion on reassurance.

"The Iron-Ring Cartel is declared victor of The Leaden Accord," Sabelle said. "That declaration has given them appetites."

"Victors often develop appetites."

"The Leaden Accord ended in ruin."

"Most accords do."

"Fourteen thousand and eleven dead."

The number settled between them with the weight of a stone dropped into deep water.

Morwenna's attention flicked toward Caedmon. His quill remained poised above the register.

Sabelle continued, "Both hosts were destroyed by a Ley-storm. Yet the Cartel behaves as if it inherited more than a title."

The hidden artifact.

Morwenna felt the thought move through her like a blade drawn beneath cloth. Supposedly destroyed. Spirited away. The truth had never appeared in any report she had signed, yet absence had its own grammar. A missing line. An empty vault. A convoy that existed only in the records of those who expected it not to exist.

“Victories breed rumors,” Morwenna said.

“Rumors breed corpses.”

“Then you should ask the dead what they heard.”

Sabelle’s eyes narrowed. “I am asking you.”

The lamps fluttered. Somewhere below, the gate chains groaned.

Morwenna had faced storms at sea, mutinies in narrow waters, and councils where every smiling mouth concealed a knife. She knew how authority behaved when it met resistance. It did not always strike. Sometimes it waited. Sometimes it invited the other person to condemn themselves by filling the silence.

She let the silence remain.

Sabelle turned to Caedmon. “Scribe.”

Caedmon straightened. “High Inquisitor.”

“Are the fleet records complete?”

“Which records?”

“The ones that concern the Cartel.”

A bead of water slid from Sabelle’s sleeve and fell onto the floor.

Caedmon’s gaze moved to Morwenna. It was not an appeal. He knew better than to appeal. It was a final measurement of the distance between duty and survival.

Morwenna heard, with terrible clarity, the scratch of his quill if he answered wrongly.

“Caedmon,” she said.

“Yes, Fleet Admiral.”

“Bring me the coastal dispositions.”

Sabelle’s attention returned to her. “And the private accounts.”

“There are no private accounts.”

“There are always private accounts.”

“Not in my command.”

“You have commanded Hollowvale since 311 AS.”

Morwenna’s pulse did not change. The words had been spoken plainly, but they struck with the precision of a key finding its lock.

“Yes,” she said.

“Then you will know what passes through its hands.”

“I know what I permit to pass.”

“And what do you permit now?”

From the yard came a cry, abruptly cut short. The bell ceased. Rain filled the silence after it.

Caedmon gathered the papers. One sheet slipped from the stack and struck the wet stone. He bent to retrieve it, but Sabelle moved first.

Their gloved hand closed over the page.

Morwenna saw the broken seal.

Not the report.

The private notation.

Sabelle unfolded it.

For one breath, no one spoke. Then Sabelle’s eyes moved across the writing, and the chamber seemed to narrow around the three of them.

Morwenna reached for the pistol beneath her coat—not drawing it, merely feeling the familiar weight—and said, “Give me that page.”

Sabelle did not surrender it.

The page remained between their fingers, its wet edge curling as though the rain had found a way inside the chamber. Caedmon’s hand hovered near the papers, careful and useless. He looked at Morwenna, then at Sabelle, and in that brief movement she saw the scribe choose survival over loyalty.

“Give me that page,” she repeated.

Sabelle raised their eyes.

The crowns upon their brow—one dark metal, one pale as old bone—caught what little light the room possessed. Rain threaded down the high windows. Beyond the glass, the yard had become a smear of grey cloaks and black water.

“You have a pistol beneath your coat,” Sabelle said.

Morwenna’s hand remained still. “You have an observation.”

“I have a habit of observing what others conceal.”

“And I have a habit of removing obstacles.”

Caedmon swallowed. The sound was small, but in the narrowed chamber it seemed to strike the walls.

Sabelle folded the page once. The broken seal flaked beneath their thumb.

“What does this mean?” they asked.

Morwenna felt the old discipline settle over her like armor. No breath wasted. No glance offered without purpose. The instinct had carried her through decks burning under ley-fire, through councils where men smiled while measuring the distance to her throat, through every order she had given from Hollowvale since 311 AS.

“It means you have read a private notation.”

“That is not an answer.”

“It is the only answer you are entitled to.”

Sabelle’s mouth moved without becoming a smile. “Entitlement is a word used by those who have mistaken access for authority.”

“Then you should understand it well.”

Caedmon bent over the table and began gathering the scattered sheets. His fingers trembled now. A blot of ink had spread across one report, turning a column of disciplined marks into a dark bruise.

Morwenna watched him. “Leave them.”

He stopped.

“If a single page disappears,” she said, “I will know.”

“Yes, Fleet Admiral.”

His voice had the dry, abraded sound of a man trying not to be heard.

Sabelle looked down at the notation again. The page had been written in a tighter hand than the report, with no heading and no destination. A line of cipher marked the upper margin. Beneath it, in plain script, were the words that had tightened the chamber around them.

Gauntlet of Sorrowfell housed in Greyfell Citadel.

Morwenna had seen the sentence before. She had paid for it before she had seen it. That was the distinction she had built her life upon: the hand that carried knowledge and the hand that spent it were not always the same.

Sabelle read the line aloud.

The rain seemed to draw nearer.

“Gauntlet of Sorrowfell housed in Greyfell Citadel.”

Caedmon made a faint sound.

Morwenna turned on him. “Did you write that?”

“No.”

“Did you copy it?”

His eyes dropped to the table. “I copied what was placed before me.”

“By whom?”

The silence after the question was not empty. It had weight. It had teeth.

Sabelle slid the page across the table, but not toward her. Their palm remained on it.

“You see?” they said. “The scribe has no answer.”

“The scribe has the answer. He lacks the courage to speak it.”

Caedmon flinched.

Morwenna regretted the cruelty only because it had been visible. Cruelty was useful when kept clean. Publicly, it bred witnesses. Privately, it bred obedience.

She stepped closer to the table. The rain had soaked the hem of her coat. Cold water touched her boot through the leather. Somewhere below, a door slammed, followed by the muffled rush of feet. The fortress was awake in the manner of a wounded animal: every sound a warning, every silence a held breath.

“Where did you find this?” she asked.

Sabelle’s gaze sharpened. “You know the location.”

“I know a line on a page.”

“You know more than that.”

“Then why ask me?”

“Because I want to hear what you will deny.”

Morwenna looked at the crowns. The title was not decoration. High Inquisitor was a blade with a human hand around its hilt, and Sabelle had never been shy about showing the edge. Yet there was something beneath the severity tonight. An impatience, perhaps. Or fear, buried deep enough that another person might have mistaken it for composure.

Morwenna did not mistake it.

Greyfell Citadel lay abandoned in the Shattered Vale, outside the realm’s core holdings. A place of grey stone and older silences. A stronghold emptied of its purpose, left to weather and thorn and the patient work of collapse. That was what official records said. Official records were doors built to keep the curious from seeing the hinges.

“You have no warrant,” Morwenna said.

“I require none to question a scribe.”

“To seize naval papers?”

“I have not seized them.”

“To interrogate an admiral?”

Sabelle’s fingers tightened on the page. “You came here armed.”

“I go everywhere armed.”

“That is not innocence.”

“No. It is prudence.”

Caedmon’s breathing had become shallow. Morwenna could hear the scratch of rain against stone, the creak of the table, the small metal click of something beneath Sabelle’s sleeve. A chain, perhaps. Or a clasp. She wondered what they carried under the black layers of their office. Relics. Instruments. Keys.

The thought came unbidden of a cellar beneath some sanctified floor, and of something bound there, breathing without lungs.

She dismissed it. Imagination was another form of carelessness.

Sabelle leaned across the table. “The Gauntlet of Sorrowfell was housed in Greyfell Citadel.”

The words were deliberate now—not read, but declared.

Morwenna let her face remain unchanged.

“Was?” she said.

A glimmer passed throughabelle’s eyes.

“There,” they murmured.

“Where?”

“You corrected the tense.”

“I corrected nothing.”

“You asked whether it was housed there. Not whether the statement was true.”

“I asked what you meant.”

“You asked whether it was still there.”

Morwenna felt the pistol’s weight beneath her coat, reassuring in its simplicity. A weapon never lied about what it wanted. A weapon wanted a body opened. Men and women wanted reasons.

She turned fromabelle to the window.

The yard below was crowded with movement. Lanterns shuddered in the rain. A line of figures crossed between the buildings, their heads bowed beneath hoods. The citadel had been built to make every person feel watched, and the architecture had succeeded long after the builders were dust.

“Greyfell Citadel is abandoned,” she said.

“Yes.”

“It lies outside the realm’s core holdings.”

“Yes.”

“Then the notation is either stale or false.”

“Or accurate.”

“Those are not the only options.”

“They are the only options that matter.”

Morwenna saw the reflection ofabelle in the black window: two crowns, a pale face, the dark hand resting over the page. Behind that reflection, Morwenna saw herself only as a shape. No features, no history. The station spoke more clearly than a face ever could. Fleet Admiral. Command. Discipline. Authority.

And beneath all of it, the quiet arithmetic of betrayal.

The Iron-Ring Cartel did not need every secret. It needed the right ones. A passage left unwatched. A convoy delayed. A garrison supplied with the wrong certainty. Information was not a coin, though men who lacked imagination treated it as one. It was a current. It moved beneath every border and carried

kingdoms toward whatever shore had paid to summon it.

This page had not been meant for Sabelle.

That was the danger.

“Who else has read this?” Morwenna asked.

Sabelle’s expression did not shift. “You are concerned.”

“I am assessing the breach.”

“Of what?”

“Security.”

“Not possession?”

Morwenna turned back to them. “Possession of what?”

The question hung between them.

Caedmon’s hand went to the edge of the table. “High Inquisitor,” he said quietly, “the notation was among the sealed records. I did not place it there.”

“No one accused you,” Sabelle said.

“You did not need to.”

“Then you understand the benefit of silence.”

Morwenna watched Sabelle’s face. There were many forms of control. Some were built from fear, some from devotion, some from the knowledge that the person across the room possessed a secret capable of ending you. Sabelle wielded all three, but not evenly. The page had unsettled them.

That made it valuable.

“Give it back,” Morwenna said.

Sabelle folded it again, smaller this time. “You will tell me what it concerns.”

“I will not.”

“You will tell me who sent it.”

“I will not.”

“You will tell me whether the Gauntlet of Sorrowfell remains in Greyfell Citadel.”

Morwenna held their gaze.

“No.”

The answer was clean. It satisfied none of them.

Sabelle slipped the folded page into the inner pocket of their robes.

Morwenna drew the pistol.

She did not point it. The room changed regardless.

Caedmon recoiled from the table. Sabelle did not move, but the air around them seemed to harden. Rain struck the windows in a sudden, furious burst, and somewhere in the walls a pipe groaned like a buried thing waking.

“Take it out,” Sabelle said.

“Give it back.”

“You threaten a High Inquisitor over a scrap of writing?”

“I threaten anyone who steals from my command.”

“Your command.” Sabelle’s voice softened. “Is that what this is?”

Morwenna’s thumb rested against the pistol’s grip. The metal was cold enough to sting.

“I have no patience for riddles.”

“No. You have patience for concealment.”

“And you have patience for trespass.”

“I have patience for truth.”

“Truth is what survives examination.”

“Truth is what remains after the convenient parts have been burned.”

The words entered her more deeply than they should have. For an instant she smelled smoke—not the damp coal stink of the chamber, but the bitter white smoke of a deck lost under stormlight. She saw no faces. Only hands reaching through glare, and the black shape of something falling where no sea should have been.

Then the memory closed.

Sabelle saw the change. Of course they did.

Their hand moved toward the inside of their robe.

Morwenna raised the pistol.

Caedmon gasped. “Please.”

The word was almost tender. It made him look younger, though Morwenna had no reason to know his age and no desire to guess it.

Sabelle stopped with their fingers against the hidden pocket.

“Is that how you command Hollowvale?” they asked.

“You know how I command.”

“I know what reports claim.”

“Then read the reports.”

“I have read enough reports to know that paper is a poor witness.”

“Paper is the only witness that does not grow tired.”

“Paper can be altered.”

“So can memory.”

“So can orders.”

A knock sounded at the chamber door.

All three turned.

It came again: measured, restrained, not the urgent pounding of a guard bearing immediate news. Morwenna kept the pistol raised. Sabelle’s hand remained inside their robe. Caedmon stood trapped between the table and the door, his eyes flicking from one to the other.

A voice spoke through the wood.

“Fleet Admiral?”

Morwenna knew the voice, but not the speaker’s name, and did not need to invent one.

“What is it?” she called.

“The watch has found something in the lower yard.”

Sabelle looked at her.

Morwenna lowered the pistol by a fraction. “What?”

“A body.”

The rain filled the pause.

“Whose?” Sabelle asked.

The voice beyond the door hesitated.

Morwenna felt the page move inside Sabelle’s robe as they shifted their weight. A small motion. A hidden decision.

The guard said, “We do not know.”

Sabelle’s eyes remained on Morwenna.

She understood then that the page was no longer the only breach. The notation had been carried into the chamber by one secret, and the body had arrived with another. Somewhere below, beneath rain and stone, someone had crossed the citadel’s defenses and paid for it.

Or been made to pay.

“Open the door,” Morwenna said.

Neither Sabelle nor Caedmon moved.

Morwenna kept her pistol trained toward the threshold and spoke more quietly.

“Open the door,” she said again, “and bring me the page before we go.”

The guard’s hand went to the latch.

Morwenna watched the iron move. The chamber seemed to contract around it: wet stone, lamp smoke, the close stink of wool soaked through by the rain. Caedmon stood beside the table with his fingers pressed flat against the ledger, as if the record might otherwise crawl away. Sabelle had not shifted. Their face held the same pale severity it had worn since entering Greyfell Citadel, but something had changed behind the eyes.

Not fear.

Recognition.

The door opened inward.

A body lay on the threshold, folded beneath a black cloak. Rainwater ran from the hem and gathered in the grooves between the flagstones. One hand protruded from the cloth, the fingers broken back toward the wrist. A strip of red cord had been tied around them.

Caedmon made a small sound.

Morwenna did not lower the pistol. "Bring it in."

The guard bent, then stopped when Sabelle said, "No."

The word struck harder than a shout.

Sabelle crossed the room. They knelt beside the body and drew back the hood. A face emerged from the wet cloth, grey with cold and streaked with blood that the rain had diluted to pink. The mouth had been sewn shut with black thread.

Morwenna felt the page shift beneath Sabelle's robe.

Not a twitch. A pressure.

The page was not paper, then. Or not only paper. Something rigid rested against Sabelle's ribs, concealed beneath the heavy layers of their inquisitorial coat. Morwenna had seen contraband hidden in boots, weapon grips, prayer boxes, even inside the hollow bones of dead birds. She had never liked mysteries that moved when their owners breathed.

"Who is it?" she asked.

"The question is less useful than why they were sent here." Sabelle touched the red cord with one gloved finger.

Caedmon's gaze had fixed on the corpse. "The seal—"

"Is not a seal," Morwenna said.

He looked at her.

"Then what is it?"

"A warning."

The guard glanced toward the stairwell. Beyond the open door, the citadel groaned in the weather. Greyfell Citadel had been founded in 62 AS in the Shattered Vale, when the stone was still considered defensible and the dead below it were still considered silent. Now the place stood abandoned, outside the realm's core holdings, its towers exposed to the rain and its lower passages open to whatever had learned

how to walk without leaving footprints.

Sabelle pulled the sewn thread from the corpse's mouth.

The dead lips opened.

A folded scrap of waxed cloth had been packed between the teeth.

Caedmon stepped forward before Morwenna could stop him. Sabelle caught his wrist.

"You are a Scribe," they said. "You produce and keep written records. You do not put your hands into messages concealed in corpses."

Caedmon flushed. "If it concerns the fleet—"

"It concerns everyone who can read."

Sabelle removed the cloth and laid it on the table. The lamp flame bent toward it, thin and blue at the edges.

Morwenna's pistol remained trained on Sabelle's heart.

"Open it," she said.

Sabelle gave her a dry look. "You issue commands as if this were Hollowvale."

"It is not Hollowvale. That is why I am asking."

A faint smile touched Sabelle's mouth. It carried no warmth. "You were born in 288 AS, Morwenna Ashgrove, and still you mistake permission for authority."

Morwenna's finger rested along the pistol's frame. "You were born in 263 AS, Sabelle Mournvale the Twice-Crowned, and still you mistake secrecy for power."

Caedmon looked between them. The guard did not move at all.

The rain battered the shutters.

Sabelle unfolded the cloth.

Inside lay a narrow strip of treated skin covered in cramped notation. Caedmon leaned toward it, then recoiled as though the ink had breathed.

Morwenna saw columns, marks, interrupted circles. A cartographer's language, perhaps. Or a cipher designed by someone who believed ordinary letters were a kind of confession.

At the bottom, written larger than the rest, were three entries:

The Leaden Accord began in 330 AS.

The Leaden Accord ended in 342 AS with 14,011 casualties.

Both hosts were destroyed by a Ley-storm.

Caedmon whispered, "That is the accepted account."

"Accepted accounts are graves with their names removed," Sabelle said.

Their finger moved lower.

A supposedly destroyed artifact was spirited away.

Morwenna felt the room lose its warmth.

For a moment she saw another chamber—not this one, not any chamber she had ever entered willingly. She saw ledgers passed under tablecloths, coded manifests hidden among powder inventories, quiet payments made in iron weights. The Iron-Ring Cartel had paid for scraps no one else thought worth stealing: routes, shortages, patrol changes, the moods of commanders. Morwenna had sold them intelligence because information was lighter than gold and easier to bury.

She had never sold them this.

The line seemed to darken under her gaze.

Sabelle watched her watching it.

“You know something,” they said.

“I know that ink is not proof.”

“You know the Cartel would bleed for the artifact.”

“The Iron-Ring Cartel bleeds for anything it can weigh.”

“And you would know what they are willing to weigh.”

The accusation did not need to be spoken plainly. It entered her like cold water through a split seam.

Caedmon’s hand hovered over the strip. “There is more.”

Morwenna turned to him. “Read it.”

He swallowed. “The lower notation refers to a transfer. No destination. No carrier. Only a mark that resembles—”

His voice broke off.

“What?” Morwenna asked.

Caedmon looked toward the corpse.

The dead hand had curled inward. The fingers were no longer broken back.

The guard saw it too and drew his sword.

Sabelle rose.

The body’s chest gave a wet, shallow shudder.

Morwenna fired.

The pistol’s report tore through the chamber. Smoke flashed white in the muzzle. The corpse struck the stones as the shot entered its throat, scattering black thread and blood across the threshold.

The guard swore. Caedmon stumbled into the table.

Sabelle did not flinch.

“You might have waited,” they said.

“I did.”

The corpse’s fingers scraped once against the floor.

Then again.

Morwenna’s pistol came up for a second shot, but Sabelle had already taken the guard’s blade. They drove it down through the body’s sternum with both hands. The point struck stone beneath, and the corpse bucked around the steel.

A sound came from it—not speech, not breath, but a congested moan that seemed to rise from beneath the floor.

Caedmon backed away. “That cannot be.”

Sabelle’s face had become empty.

“Everything can be,” they said. “Given a cellar.”

Morwenna stared at them.

The secret revealed itself not in the words but in their calm. Sabelle did not react as a person confronted with an impossible thing. They reacted as a keeper whose property had escaped its chain.

Somewhere beneath the citadel, a revenant waited in Sabelle’s cellar.

The thought arrived whole and obscene.

Sabelle looked at her, and Morwenna knew they had seen understanding take shape.

“Do not,” Sabelle said.

“Do not what?”

“Make a decision with that knowledge.”

Morwenna considered the pistol, the page, the dead thing nailed to the floor. “You are in no position to dictate my decisions.”

“Neither are you.”

The corpse’s mouth opened. The gums were packed with grey ash. Its eyes rolled toward the dark beyond the door.

There came a knock from below.

Not at the door.

From under the flagstones.

Caedmon’s face emptied of color.

A second knock followed, slower than the first.

Sabelle withdrew the sword from the corpse. “We leave now.”

Morwenna seized the waxed strip before they could fold it away. “We leave with the page.”

Sabelle’s gaze dropped to the place beneath their robe where the rigid shape pressed against their side.

“You have not earned it.”

“I command Hollowvale.”

“Since 311 AS.”

The words were quiet, almost courteous. “And yet Hollowvale is not here.”

Another knock sounded beneath them.

The guard crossed himself in the old manner. Morwenna did not. She had learned young that gestures meant to ward off darkness often served only to announce where one hoped it would not look.

Her first memory of command was not of victory. It was of a sealed room and men waiting for her to speak while smoke crawled along the ceiling. She had been born in 288 AS, and the world had spent every year since teaching her that authority was merely fear with a uniform on it.

She extended her free hand.

“Give me the page.”

Sabelle held her stare.

“Ask properly.”

Morwenna heard Caedmon breathing behind her. The guard’s sword dripped onto the stones. Beneath their feet, something dragged its nails across the underside of the floor.

She lowered the pistol by a fraction.

“Please,” she said.

Sabelle smiled then—not with triumph, but with the tired satisfaction of someone watching a lock yield.

They drew the page from beneath their robe.

It was not paper. It was a thin, translucent membrane, yellowed at the edges, with writing that seemed to have been burned into it from the reverse. As Sabelle held it out, the ink rearranged itself.

Caedmon whispered, “It is changing.”

Morwenna took the page.

The surface was warm.

A line appeared beneath the others.

Palewell Abbey stands in The Pale Coast. It was founded in 244 AS, rebuilt, and maintains a garrison of 5998. It is not a core holding.

Below that, new marks gathered like insects around a wound.

A route. A tide chart. A sequence of symbols that ended at the abbey.

Palewell Abbey: austere, pale stone above the coast, rebuilt into a fortress and left watchful beneath the realm’s indifference. A garrison of 5998, enough to make the place seem guarded, not enough to make it safe. The page had named its weakness with the same cold precision it used for the dead.

The Iron-Ring Cartel would pay dearly for this.

Morwenna felt the old calculation rise in her—the weight of disclosure, the hidden recipient, the price that could be demanded. She had sold intelligence to the Iron-Ring Cartel before. She would sell it again if survival required it.

But the page was warm against her palm, and something below the floor had begun to whisper.

Not words.

A name.

Sabelle's name.

The flagstones split.

A black finger emerged between them, slick with cellar mud.

Sabelle seized Morwenna's arm. "Run."

Morwenna tore free and fired into the crack.

The shot vanished downward.

For one breath, there was silence.

Then the citadel answered from every floor below them, and the whisper became a scream.

Chapter 7

The water in Gloamreach tasted of iron.

Isolde Fellgard the Unforgiven held the cup beneath her nose and breathed through the sourness. The liquid trembled against the black glaze, reflecting the narrow window and the pale smear of the coast beyond it. Gloamreach lay on the Pale Coast, where the sea had gnawed the land into white shelves and drowned the roads in salt. Even behind shuttered stone, the place smelled of wet ash.

They did not drink.

“Set it down,” Isolde said.

Ossric Ashgrove obeyed. He placed the cup beside the ledger with both hands, as though the vessel might accuse him if he touched it carelessly. Quartermaster was his office, and every movement bore the timid precision of a man accustomed to counting what other people wasted.

“The seal is unbroken,” Ossric said.

“Seals are mouths with wax over them.”

His eyes flicked toward the cup. “The water was drawn from the inner cistern.”

“Then the inner cistern has learned deceit.”

A gust pressed against the shutters. Somewhere below, a bell gave a single muffled note. The quarantine had been proclaimed over Gloamreach for so long that the bell no longer summoned anyone. It merely reminded the living that the dead still possessed a voice.

Isolde turned from the window.

The room had been built for command and made suitable for suspicion. A table. A brazier low on coals. A rack of weapons that no hand had polished since the last rain. On the wall, a map of the Pale Coast had curled away from its pins, its edges gray with damp. Gloamreach was marked in faded black. Beyond it, the ink roads dwindled toward Fenspire, whose stark spire rose in the Gloaming Reach like a spear driven through the earth.

“Read it again,” Isolde said.

Ossric lowered his head over the ledger. “The stores received from Fenspire are short by—”

“Not that part.”

His finger remained between the columns. “The notation concerning the sealed wagons?”

“Read it.”

He swallowed. “The wagons were admitted under Warden-Commander authority. The accompanying order bears the mark of Ignatz Ashgrove the Oathless.”

The name remained in the room after Ossric stopped speaking.

Isolde felt the old appetite stir beneath their ribs. Blood answered blood, though it had no right to answer the blood of strangers. Their fingers tightened against the table. The wood complained.

“Ignatz Ashgrove the Oathless,” they said softly. “A guardian who sends sealed water into a quarantined hold.”

“Perhaps the wagons contained grain.”

“Perhaps.”

“They were not opened.”

“Then you know what they contained?”

“No.”

“Good. You are still capable of fear.”

Ossric’s face did not change. No canonical face had ever been granted him; he wore only the expression the room demanded. At present, it demanded obedience.

The door opened without a knock.

Malchior Cindervale the Flame-Touched entered beneath the lintel, robes gathered in one hand to keep them from the wet floor. The other hand rested upon the silver chain of office at their throat. Their authority arrived before them, sanctified and strained, like a hymn sung through clenched teeth.

“Isolde Fellgard the Unforgiven,” Malchior said.

“Arch-Prelate.”

“Do not make that title sound like a wound.”

“Then stop wearing it as armor.”

Malchior’s gaze moved to the cup. “You have not drunk.”

“I have not become careless.”

“The quarantine ordinances require all provisions to be tested.”

“By whom?”

“By the appointed hands.”

“Whose hands?”

Malchior’s mouth thinned. Their claimed lineage was a thing of papers and seals, a tower built upon ink. Isolde had seen how fiercely they defended it. A person who forged their own lineage papers understood better than most that authority was not inherited; it was manufactured, then guarded until the witnesses died.

“Do you intend to challenge the appointment?” Malchior asked.

“I intend to challenge the water.”

“You command Gloammarch since 310 AS. You do not command every throat in Gloamreach.”

“No,” Isolde said. “Only the throats that remain attached.”

Ossric looked down.

Malchior stepped nearer the table. Their shadow crossed the ledger, blotting out the columns. “The Iron-Ring Cartel has sent assurances.”

“The Iron-Ring Cartel sent assurances during the Purge of Blackport.”

Malchior's fingers closed around the silver chain.

"The Purge of Blackport began in 311 AS and ended in 321 AS," Isolde continued. "It caused 70,907 casualties. The aggressors were totally routed. The Iron-Ring Cartel emerged as victor."

"And what does that have to do with a shipment?"

"Ask the wells."

Silence took the room.

There were old stories of Blackport, though stories were only corpses that had learned to travel. The wells had been poisoned by the victors' own hands, so the allies would die with the enemies. The Iron-Ring Cartel had called it necessity. The dead had called it thirst.

Malchior's voice fell low. "You accuse them without proof."

"I accuse them with memory."

"Memory is not evidence."

"It is when the evidence has been buried in a well."

Ossric shifted beside the ledger. "There is another matter."

Isolde looked at him.

He drew a second sheet from inside his coat. The paper was stiff with damp, and a dark thumbprint stained its lower corner.

"Speak."

"The order for the wagons was countersigned by the Choir."

"The Silent Choir?"

"Yes."

"Which voice?"

Ossric hesitated.

"Which voice?"

"No voice is given."

The brazier released a coal with a soft collapse. Red light breathed through the ash.

Malchior reached for the sheet. Isolde placed one hand over it.

The pressure was slight. It was enough.

Blood-magic did not require spectacle. The old teachings had made it vulgar, dressing it in knives and bowls, in red rivers poured across altars. The true work was quieter. A pulse beneath the skin. A thread of warmth drawn unwillingly toward the fingertips. A command whispered into the wet machinery of the body.

Ossric stiffened.

Isolde felt the rhythm in his wrist. Quick. Quick. Slower.

“You will not touch him,” Malchior said.

“I have not.”

“You are touching him now.”

“Then he should give me a reason to stop.”

Ossric’s breathing became shallow. “The order is genuine.”

“Did I ask whether the mark was genuine?”

“No.”

“Did you verify the cargo?”

“No.”

“Did you drink from the cistern?”

“No.”

“Why not?”

Ossric’s eyes rose to theirs. For an instant, there was something there beyond timidity. Not courage. Calculation, perhaps. A small animal deciding whether the trap had sprung.

“I was told the quarantine made inspection unnecessary,” he said.

“By whom?”

“Ignatz Ashgrove the Oathless.”

The blood in Ossric’s wrist faltered.

Isolde released him.

He drew a breath that sounded like a blade being pulled free.

Malchior unfolded their sleeve. “This performance is beneath you.”

“Then tell me why a Warden-Commander would forbid a quartermaster from inspecting provisions entering Gloamreach.”

“Because the order carried authority.”

“Authority is not an answer.”

“It is the answer by which the realm survives.”

“No. It is the answer by which cowards sleep.”

The Arch-Prelate’s eyes hardened. Firelight laid a false gold along their cheek. “You have always mistaken defiance for discernment.”

“And you have mistaken forged paper for blood.”

Malchior went still.

The insult had found its mark, though Isolde felt no satisfaction. Satisfaction was a soft thing. It made a person linger where they ought to leave.

At the window, the shutter rattled again. Beyond it, the quarantine cordons cut the streets into empty passages. No faces appeared between the buildings. No carts moved. Gloamreach had become a sealed vessel, and every seal invited the question of who had filled it.

“Open the wagons,” Isolde said.

Malchior turned toward the door. “I will not permit this.”

“You have no permit to withhold.”

“I speak for the sanctified authority of the realm.”

“You speak for yourself.”

“I speak for the Crown.”

“The Bleeding Crown?”

Malchior’s expression did not break, but the skin beneath their eyes tightened.

Isolde leaned close enough to smell the smoke clinging to their robes. “Then let the Bleeding Crown come here and drink first.”

The Arch-Prelate raised one hand.

The air changed.

Not visibly. Not yet. But the room filled with the pressure of an invoked rite, with the dry taste of old words gathering behind the teeth. Isolde felt their own blood answer, eager and treacherous. It wanted to rise. It wanted to show Malchior what grievance could do when given a vein.

Instead, Isolde smiled.

“Do it,” they whispered.

Malchior’s hand trembled once.

The door opened again.

This time the guard outside did not enter. A voice came through the gap, muffled by the rain.

“Command.”

Isolde kept their eyes upon Malchior. “What?”

“The western gate has been opened.”

Ossric made a sound under his breath.

“No gate opens in quarantine,” Malchior said.

“Who opened it?” Isolde asked.

The voice faltered. “The order bears the mark of Ignatz Ashgrove the Oathless.”

There it was: the clean stroke of the knife.

Isolde looked toward the window. Across the pale, drowned streets, a horn began to call from the western quarter. Once. Twice. A third time, answered by another horn farther inland.

The garrison of Gloamreach numbered 2,483, and every one of those throats could now be summoned into the dark.

Malchior stepped back from the table. "You cannot move the garrison without authorization."

"I command Gloammarch since 310 AS."

"That is not the same as command of Gloamreach."

"No," Isolde said. "It is worse."

They took the cup from the table.

The water inside had gone perfectly still.

Isolde drew a small knife from beneath their sleeve and cut across the pad of their thumb. One red bead gathered, bright as a coal. Ossric watched it with horror. Malchior watched it with calculation.

Isolde let the blood fall.

The bead struck the water.

For a breath, nothing happened.

Then the cup began to whisper.

The whisper thickened until it seemed to have weight.

It crawled over the rim of the cup and fell into the room in threads, brushing the stone walls, the shuttered window, the iron hinges of the door. Ossric flinched as though something wet had touched his neck. Malchior did not move. The flame-touched planes of their face remained composed, but a pulse worked beneath the skin at their temple.

Isolde kept their bleeding thumb above the water.

The blood did not disperse. It opened like a red eye.

"Speak," Isolde said.

The cup answered in a voice made from several voices, none of them wholly human. It breathed through the syllables. It dragged them over the table as if they were bones.

"Gloamreach..."

Ossric's hands closed around the edge of the table. "You said this would show the command."

"It shows what the command fears."

"I have no fear of command."

"That," Malchior murmured, "is the first lie you have told tonight."

The water shuddered.

A pale shape rose beneath its surface: not a face, not yet, but the suggestion of one pressed against ice. Isolde leaned closer. The chill from the cup entered their cut thumb and climbed the arm, seeking the heart. They welcomed it. Pain was a language they trusted because it had no patience for invention.

The shape altered.

A tower appeared in the water, narrow and black against a colorless sky. Its uppermost point vanished into mist. Below it, walls bristled with watchfires. The lights did not burn yellow. They burned the dull blue of old bruises.

Fenspire.

The image trembled, and the spire's shadow spread across the table. It touched the sleeve of Malchior's robe. The Arch-Prelate glanced down at it, and for the first time their composure cracked.

"Why Fenspire?" Ossric asked.

Isolde said nothing.

They had never seen the place, but the cup had no need of eyes. It showed not what was known, but what had been bound beneath the known. The tower stood in the Gloaming Reach, disciplined and watchful, a blade driven into the dimness. The garrisoned walls seemed to listen for footsteps beyond their reach.

Then the image darkened.

A road emerged, pale with ash. On it moved a line of men and beasts beneath covered standards. No sigils showed. The cloth was soaked too heavily with rain—or something darker—for its pattern to be read. The procession halted before a gate.

A man stepped from beneath the foremost canopy.

His face refused to settle.

Isolde saw the cut of a commander's coat, the posture of someone accustomed to being obeyed, the stillness of a person who had learned to place silence where an oath should have been. The cup swallowed his features and returned them wrong: an eye, a mouth, a cheekbone, then blankness.

The whisper spoke.

"Ignatz Ashgrove the Oathless, a member of House Morvain."

Ossric made a small sound.

Malchior's hand moved toward the chain beneath their robe, where some private token lay hidden. They stopped before touching it.

Isolde watched the image of Ignatz approach the gate.

"You know him," they said.

"Everyone who has served long enough knows the name."

"That was not my question."

"It was the only answer you are entitled to."

The man in the cup lifted one hand. The gate opened before him. No sentry challenged him. No horn sounded. The road beyond was empty, but the darkness gathered on either side as though waiting to be given orders.

The cup whispered again, softer now.

"House Morvain."

The words slid beneath Isolde's skin.

House Morvain had old walls, old claims, old appetites. It could lend a name to a sword and call the wound lawful. It could turn a private grievance into a public necessity, then mourn the dead with a dry eye. Isolde had learned that power did not require innocence. It only required witnesses willing to forget what they had seen.

The image shifted.

A hand rested on a map.

No border could be made out. No banners. Only roads, coastlines, and black marks spreading like mold beneath the skin of parchment. One mark pulsed near the sea. Another answered from inland. The fingers moved between them with deliberate care.

Malchior leaned over the cup.

"Stop this."

Isolde looked at them. "You are afraid of a map?"

"I am afraid of people who mistake symbols for commands."

"Then you are safe. I mistake nothing."

The cup's red eye widened. A filament of Isolde's blood pulled from the wound and stretched toward the image. It trembled, thin as spider silk, before sinking into the painted roads.

The room filled with the smell of wet iron.

Ossric shoved backward from the table. His stool struck the wall and fell. "This is forbidden."

"You brought the cup."

"I brought a sealed vessel for a sealed inquiry."

"You brought a witness."

His face had gone gray. In the candlelight, the quartermaster looked younger than his office, almost painfully so. The fear in him was not theatrical. Isolde could smell it beneath the wool of his coat, sharp and sour.

Malchior turned on him. "You said the water came from the eastern cistern."

"It did."

"Who touched it?"

"No one."

"Nothing is touched by no one."

Ossric swallowed. "It was taken under guard."

"Whose guard?"

His mouth closed.

There it was—the little door in him, the place where an answer had been locked away. Isolde felt the blood in the cup stir in recognition. Not guilt, precisely. Guilt was too warm a word. This was calculation cooling into terror.

“Name the guard,” Isolde said.

“I cannot.”

“You can.”

“I was ordered not to.”

“By whom?”

The whisper in the cup began to laugh.

It was not a human laugh. It had no mirth in it, only the grinding rhythm of stones forced together beneath deep water. The tower of Fenspire blurred. The road vanished. Ignatz Ashgrove the Oathless stood again in the red-black depths, though now his face was clear enough to reveal a scar at the mouth.

Isolde had not seen that scar before.

The blood-mage’s own reflection stared back at them from the water beside his.

Their faces touched.

For an instant, Isolde felt another will enter the cut in their thumb. It did not push. It waited. That was worse. A hand upon a door, patient because it knew the door would open.

A memory rose that was not theirs.

A chamber with no windows.

The taste of ash.

A voice reciting terms.

Ignatz standing before someone seated beyond the reach of the light. The seated figure was only a shape. No face. No title. The air between them seemed stretched taut by obligation.

Isolde heard the last words clearly.

“Tell House Morvain the coast is not dead.”

The memory snapped.

The cup burst.

Not shattered—burst. Its water leapt upward in a dark column, striking the ceiling, then fell in a rain of cold droplets. The blood on Isolde’s thumb burned black. Ossric cried out and shielded his face. Malchior seized the edge of the table as the stone beneath it groaned.

For a heartbeat, the room held the smell of salt and rot.

Then every candle went out.

Darkness closed around them.

Ossric was breathing too quickly. Malchior's robe rustled. Somewhere beyond the door, a boot scraped across stone and halted.

Isolde felt the shape of the knife beneath their sleeve. Their thumb throbbed. The cut had sealed itself, though the skin around it had gone numb.

"Who is outside?" Ossric whispered.

"No one," Malchior said.

The boot scraped again.

Isolde smiled without warmth. "You are both becoming careless with that word."

They moved toward the door. The dark seemed reluctant to release them. It clung to their clothing, tugged at their hair, pressed its damp mouth against the back of their neck. Behind them, the cup lay intact on the table. Empty now. Its inner surface was filmed with a red residue that formed no pattern Isolde could read.

The latch lifted.

Malchior said, "Do not open it."

"Why?"

"Because you have not asked who sent the guard."

"Neither have you."

"I am asking you not to open it."

Their hand rested on the latch.

The voice from the cup returned, not from the table this time, but from the other side of the door.

"Isolde."

Ossric whimpered.

Malchior's breath stopped.

Isolde knew the voice. It had no name in the room, but it carried the authority of a command that had once been obeyed. Their fingers tightened around the iron until the metal bit the palm.

"Say it again," Isolde whispered.

"Isolde Fellgard the Unforgiven."

The title entered them like a hook.

There were many ways to pronounce Unforgiven. Some made it an accusation. Some made it a prayer. Some made it a warning offered too late. This voice gave the word its oldest meaning: not the one who had been denied pardon, but the one who had ceased to seek it.

Behind Isolde, Malchior spoke in a low, controlled voice. "You will not answer."

"Why?"

"Because a name can be a summons."

"And if I have already been summoned?"

“Then you are standing at the wrong door.”

The corridor beyond fell silent.

Isolde pictured the dark outside: the narrow passage, the damp stones, the guards who would have been told to wait somewhere else. They pictured the door opening inward, the space beyond empty, and the waiting thing occupying the blind angle beside the hinge.

Their blood knew before their mind did.

Someone had been admitted.

Not into the chamber.

Into the bargain.

Isolde opened the door.

The door opened on Ossric Ashgrove.

He stood with one hand lifted, as though the wood had interrupted a knock he had not yet decided to give. Rain silvered his shoulders. He wore the plain dark coat of a quartermaster, its hem stained with road-mud, and held a narrow iron case against his ribs.

Behind him, the passage was empty.

Isolde looked first at the floor. No wet footprints but Ossric's. No shadow laid wrong beneath the lamps. No breath steaming in the cold.

Then they looked into his face.

“Who admitted you?”

Ossric swallowed. “No one.”

Malchior came to stand at Isolde's shoulder. The Arch-Prelate's presence seemed to draw the darkness into order. Candlelight struck the scorched planes of their skin and made a saint of every scar.

“That is not an answer,” Malchior said.

“It is the only one I have.”

“Then you have come carrying an answer you do not understand.”

Ossric glanced at Isolde. He had the anxious eyes of a man who counted things because numbers did not change their minds. “I was told to bring this to the commander of Gloammarch.”

“You were told by whom?”

His gaze fell to the iron case.

The latch was sealed in black wax. Not with a crest. With a fingerprint.

Isolde felt the old pressure behind their eyes, the blood in their skull tightening as if some invisible hand had closed around it. A summons could be written in ink. A bargain could be written in blood. This was neither. It was a door pretending to be a message.

“Give it to me,” Isolde said.

Ossric did not move.

Malchior's fingers brushed the sleeve of Isolde's coat. A warning, light as ash.

"Quartermaster," Malchior said, "you were born in 333 AS. You have survived by remembering who ordered what, and when. Remember this moment carefully."

Ossric's mouth tightened. "I remember."

"Then remember obedience."

"I remember that men who obeyed at Blackport were buried beside men who refused."

The name changed the room.

Blackport came back in the smell of the rain: brine, rot, and the bitter mineral taste that had clung to every well after the Purge of Blackport began in 311 AS. It had ended in 321 AS with 70,907 casualties and the total rout of the aggressors. The Iron-Ring Cartel had emerged as victor.

The official accounts called it a triumph of discipline.

The wells had called it something else.

The Iron-Ring Cartel had poisoned the wells of their own allies.

Isolde remembered a boy with blue lips trying to drink from a cup that had already killed his mother. They had been younger then, though not innocent. Innocence was only ignorance that had not yet been punished.

"Bring the case inside," Isolde said.

Ossric crossed the threshold.

The door shut behind him with a soft, final click.

Malchior looked at the iron seal. "Where did you find it?"

"In the stores beneath the western armory."

"You were searching the stores?"

"I was inventorying them."

"And this was inventory?"

"No." Ossric placed the case on the table. "This was hidden beneath a false bottom in a crate marked lamp oil."

Isolde remained standing. Their reflection trembled in the polished iron: a pale face, dark eyes, the signs of the Blood-Mage written not on the skin but in the way the air seemed to recoil from their hands.

"Who has access to that armory?"

Ossric's eyes flicked once toward Malchior.

The Arch-Prelate smiled without warmth. "Say it."

"Warden-Commander Ignatz Ashgrove the Oathless."

The name settled between them.

Ignatz Ashgrove the Oathless served House Morvain. His authority had always carried the blunt weight of a locked gate, but Isolde had learned that gates were most useful to those who knew which side of them held the keys.

Malchior's face did not change.

"Open it," they said.

Ossric shook his head. "The seal is not mine to break."

"Nor mine," Malchior said.

Isolde reached for the case.

Blood stirred beneath their fingernails.

The wax softened before their touch. Its black surface shivered, then split with a wet whisper. A thin line of red appeared along the seam—not their blood, not Ossric's. It smelled of iron left in rain.

The case opened.

Inside lay three folded sheets, a brass token, and a strip of parchment so narrow it looked like a dead moth.

The top sheet bore a list of places.

Fenspire. Gloamreach.

Beneath each name, figures had been written in a precise military hand.

Fenspire: garrison 3,742.

Gloamreach: garrison 2,483.

Isolde's fingers went cold.

Fenspire stood in the Gloaming Reach, founded in 57 AS, its stark spire raised above the dim land like a finger held to the mouth of the world. Gloamreach was quarantined, sealed away from the coast by suspicion and orders no sane person questioned aloud.

The figures were not estimates. They were not the sort of numbers a quartermaster copied for comfort. They were the counts of bodies that could be fed, armed, moved, or killed.

Malchior leaned over the table. "That inventory is current?"

Ossric nodded. "The figures were corrected three times."

"By whom?"

"I do not know."

"You do."

"I know whose hand wrote them."

"Whose?"

Ossric looked again at Isolde. "Ignatz Ashgrove the Oathless."

The second sheet contained roads. Not roads as they appeared on maps, but roads as they existed beneath weather: dry crossings, collapsed bridges, stretches where patrols were thin. Beside each route were small

marks, each one shaped like a ring cut through by a blade.

The Iron-Ring Cartel's sign.

Isolde read without touching the page.

"Why would a Warden-Commander keep Cartel marks in a sealed armory?" they asked.

Ossric's answer came too quickly. "He would not."

"Then why are they here?"

"I said I do not know."

"You said the writing was his."

"I said the hand was his."

"Do you believe those are different things?"

The quartermaster's face had gone gray. "I believe a man may write what another man commands."

Malchior lifted the brass token.

One side showed the five-pointed device of the Iron-Ring Cartel. The other was blank except for a shallow depression, round and dark, as if something had been pressed into it and removed.

"A payment token," Malchior murmured.

"No," Isolde said.

Their blood had begun to listen.

They placed one fingertip against the brass. A pulse moved through it. Not warmth. Memory.

A gloved hand.

A table.

A ring of iron sliding across wood.

A voice speaking behind a closed door.

The impression vanished before the words became clear.

Isolde withdrew their hand.

Malchior watched them. "What did you see?"

"Enough."

"That is not a quantity."

"It is the only one you are getting."

The Arch-Prelate's eyes narrowed. In the candlelight, the forged lineage papers hidden beneath their robes seemed to weigh upon them more heavily than any holy relic. Isolde had seen those papers once: seals too old, witness marks belonging to the dead, a family line assembled with the patient desperation of a thief building a staircase from stolen wood.

Malchior had made a life from documents no blade could test.

Now they looked at the Cartel token as though it had the power to expose every lie ever written.

“Read the last sheet,” they said.

The parchment strip was blank.

Isolde held it above the candle.

Letters rose from the fibers, darkening one stroke at a time.

The door is open.

Ossric made a sound in his throat.

More words surfaced.

The command is divided.

Then:

The blood remembers its debt.

The flame bent sideways.

Somewhere beyond the chamber, a bell rang once.

Not the hour bell. Not the alarm.

A single note, struck with the hesitation of a hand testing whether the metal was alive.

Malchior turned toward the door.

“Did you tell anyone you were coming here?” Isolde asked Ossric.

“No.”

“Did anyone see you take the case?”

“No.”

“Then why is the bell ringing?”

Ossric stared at the parchment. “I don’t know.”

Isolde looked down at the final line as it emerged from the blankness.

The ink was not black now. It was red.

Bring the Unforgiven to the one who killed their liege.

For one breath, the chamber held no sound but rain.

Their liege’s death had been plotted in rooms just like this: under lamplight, with maps weighted by iron, with voices lowered whenever servants passed. Isolde had told themselves it had been necessary. They had called it justice when no one else was listening.

The body had fallen.

The crown had remained.

They had thought the bargain ended there.

Malchior reached for the parchment.

Isolde caught their wrist.

The Arch-Prelate looked at them. "You know who this means."

"No."

"You do."

"No."

A second bell rang.

This time, something answered from the corridor.

Three slow knocks.

Ossric backed away from the door. The iron case slipped from his hand and struck the floor. The brass token rolled in a small circle before coming to rest at Isolde's boot.

The blank side faced upward.

In its shallow depression, blood began to gather.

Not from any wound.

From the air.

Malchior's voice became very quiet. "Do not open it."

Isolde stared at the door.

The knocking came again.

Three times.

Their blood moved toward it.

Chapter 8

The rain came sideways across the battlements, needling the black flags until their cloth shone like wet wounds.

Morwenna Ashgrove stood beneath the broken arch of the old observatory and watched the Shattered Vale drown. Greyfell Citadel had been founded in 62 AS, when the stone beneath her boots had still been new enough to bear a mason's pride. Now the towers were hollow teeth, the courtyards choked with rainwater and pale weeds. It was abandoned, outside the realm's core holdings, yet the old records still gave it a master in a hand so certain that certainty became a kind of mockery.

Greyfell Citadel ruled by House Morvain.

The line had been copied three times on the parchment before her.

Caedmon Fellgard held the ledger open with both hands. He was a Scribe, and every inch of him seemed bent toward the sanctity of written things: shoulders drawn inward, fingers stained dark with ink, posture disciplined even while the storm worried at the stones around him.

"Read it aloud," Morwenna said.

Caedmon lifted his eyes. "The Leaden Accord."

"The whole entry."

His mouth tightened. He did not like the request. Scribes disliked being made to turn records into weapons.

"The Leaden Accord began in 330 AS," he read. "It ended in 342 AS with 14,011 casualties. The Iron-Ring Cartel was named victor."

The rain struck the archway with the hard hiss of thrown grain.

Morwenna looked beyond him, toward the drowned road winding down from the citadel. Somewhere beneath the clouds, patrols moved through the ravines. Somewhere farther still, the Cartel waited for the intelligence she had promised to sell.

Not promised, she corrected herself.

Sold.

The word had a clean edge. It did not ask to be forgiven.

"And the cause of the ending?" she asked.

Caedmon lowered his gaze to the page. "The Leaden Accord ended when both hosts were destroyed by a Ley-storm."

"Both hosts."

"The Ashen Vanguard was a belligerent in The Leaden Accord."

His voice had the weight of a man reciting a sentence he had been taught not to understand.

Morwenna reached for the ledger. "Give it here."

Caedmon surrendered it reluctantly. The pages were swollen with damp, and the ink had feathered at the margins. She traced the old notation with one gloved finger.

Both hosts destroyed.

The declared victory belonged to the Iron-Ring Cartel. Victory required survivors, witnesses, banners hauled from the mud. Yet the pages spoke of annihilation. The dead had been counted, named, arranged into columns, and then made to serve the living.

The hidden truth lay beneath the entry in a cramped hand: a supposedly destroyed artifact had been spirited away.

No name. No description. No destination.

The omission was deliberate. Morwenna knew the shape of deliberate omissions. They resembled doors in a corridor where there should have been stone.

“Who altered this?” she asked.

Caedmon’s face became still. “The record does not say.”

“Records do not alter themselves.”

“No.”

“Then someone altered it.”

“Yes.”

The answer pleased her less than defiance would have. Defiance had a spine. Fear merely bent.

She closed the ledger. The clasp clicked softly, almost tenderly.

At the far end of the observatory, a lamp guttered behind a shield of horn. Its flame painted the wet stones copper. A figure stood beside it, draped in dark robes whose hem was clean despite the mud outside.

Sabelle Mournvale the Twice-Crowned had arrived without escort.

Their crowns were not worn upon their head. One rested at their throat as a circlet of black metal; the other had been worked into the clasp of their mantle. Both were narrow, severe things. They marked Sabelle as High Inquisitor more effectively than any proclamation could have done.

Morwenna had never asked why the crowns were called twice-earned. Questions were another form of currency, and she spent only when the return was certain.

Sabelle’s eyes moved from the ledger to Caedmon, then to Morwenna.

“You have found the wound,” they said.

“I have found an inconsistency.”

“That is what wounds are called by people who intend to survive them.”

Caedmon swallowed. His hands hovered at his sides, empty and miserable.

Morwenna turned toward the storm. “The Iron-Ring Cartel was named victor, though both hosts were destroyed by a Ley-storm. The hidden truth says an artifact was spirited away. That is not an inconsistency. It is a verdict written over a crime.”

Sabelle came closer. Their boots made no sound upon the stone.

“And you object to crimes?”

“I object to untidy accounts.”

“Because you are a Fleet Admiral?”

“Because untidy accounts sink ships.”

The lie came easily. Morwenna had worn authority for so long that falsehood entered it like breath entering a bellows. She had been born in 288 AS, and the years since had taught her that every command carried two meanings: the one given aloud, and the one purchased in secret.

The Iron-Ring Cartel paid for the second.

Not with coin. Coin was too visible. They paid with safe passage, with sealed reports, with the knowledge that certain vessels would not be waiting where the charts said they waited. They paid by making silence profitable.

Sabelle’s gaze sharpened. “The Ashen Vanguard will not forgive the old account.”

“The Ashen Vanguard has survived worse than forgiveness.”

“House Morvain will claim Greyfell Citadel by right.”

Morwenna glanced back at the ruined walls. “House Morvain has already ruled Greyfell Citadel.”

“Ruled,” Sabelle said, tasting the word. “The stone remains. The rule does not.”

Caedmon made a small sound. He had turned toward the stairs, listening.

“What is it?” Morwenna asked.

“Nothing.”

“Nothing does not make a Scribe listen.”

He looked ashamed of the truth before speaking it. “There are noises below.”

The storm pressed against the citadel. Water streamed through cracks in the ceiling and ran in silver threads along the floor.

Sabelle smiled without warmth.

“Below,” they repeated.

Morwenna watched them. “You have brought something.”

“I have brought a matter requiring privacy.”

“You have brought a matter requiring a cellar.”

The smile vanished.

For one instant, Morwenna saw the High Inquisitor’s severity split open, revealing the dark chamber beneath. She had heard whispers of Sabelle’s secret, though never the details: in the cellar below their quarters, a bound revenant was kept in custody. A dead thing tethered to obedience. A corpse made into an instrument by someone who wore sanctity like armor.

Caedmon looked between them, pale.

Sabelle spoke gently. "You hear too much."

"I command a fleet."

"You command what remains of one."

Morwenna let the insult pass. The storm had begun to lessen, but the wind still worried at the flags. Their wet snapping sounded like applause from a distant crowd.

She opened the ledger again and held it toward Sabelle.

"Here. Read the hand beneath the official account."

"I have read it."

"Then you know why the Cartel wants this."

"I know why everyone wants it."

"Everyone?"

"The Ashen Vanguard wants the dead avenged. House Morvain wants the citadel restored to its old obedience. The Silent Choir wants the truth buried beneath a holier lie. The Iron-Ring Cartel wants whatever was spirited away. And the Bleeding Crown wants all four to believe they are acting alone."

Morwenna studied their face. "You left yourself out."

"I am not a power."

"No?"

"I am an instrument."

That answer had the flatness of a blade.

Caedmon stepped toward the stairwell. "The noise is louder."

A dull knock rose from below.

Once.

Then again.

Something struck wood with patient force.

Sabelle did not move, but their hand settled upon the clasp at their throat. Beneath the black metal, one crown caught the lamplight; the other remained in shadow.

Morwenna felt the old instinct awaken in her, colder than fear and more useful: measure the exits, count the hands, decide who would drown first.

The cellar lay beneath the observatory. The stairs were narrow. The rain had made the stones slick. Caedmon carried no weapon that she could see. Sabelle carried secrets. Morwenna carried the ledger, and within it a sentence that could purchase the Cartel's favor or condemn her to its displeasure.

Another knock sounded below.

Caedmon whispered, "It knows we are here."

Sabelle turned to him. "It knows nothing."

The wood groaned.

Morwenna closed the ledger and tucked it beneath her arm.

"Open the cellar," she said.

Sabelle's eyes found hers. "You are giving an order?"

"I am asking to see what threatens my command."

"Your command is not here."

"No," Morwenna said. "But my choices are."

For a moment, the three of them stood within the ruined observatory while the last of the rain slid from the battlements. Greyfell Citadel held its silence around them, old and abandoned, yet still bearing the name of House Morvain like a curse carved into bone.

Then Sabelle drew a key from beneath their mantle.

From below came a third knock.

This time, something on the other side of the door whispered Morwenna's name.

Sabelle turned the key.

The lock yielded with a wet, internal click. The cellar door opened inward on darkness thick as old blood. A breath came up from below—not the ordinary chill of buried stone, but a damp exhalation that touched Morwenna's face and seemed to search for a place beneath her skin.

The whisper came again.

"Morwenna."

Her name had no mouth behind it. Or too many.

She placed one hand on the hilt at her hip, though steel had never been much use against the things that survived the Sundering. "You said the cellar was sealed."

"It was."

"By whom?"

Sabelle's gaze did not leave the stair. "By those who understood the virtue of silence."

"That is not an answer."

"It is the only one you are owed."

Morwenna looked at them. The Twice-Crowned High Inquisitor stood with one hand upon the open door, the other hidden within their mantle. Their severity had always seemed like a kind of architecture: a clean wall raised against the weather of the soul. Now a hairline fracture ran through it.

Below, something shifted.

Not footsteps. Not yet.

A soft dragging, followed by the delicate chime of metal against metal.

The stair descended through the citadel's foundations, each step worn at its center by feet that had ceased to come. Water glimmered in the joints. The walls were grey, the same dead grey as the towers above, but darker where the rain had found a path through the masonry. Morwenna followed Sabelle down.

Behind her, the observatory remained open to the storm. The wind pushed through the broken dome and worried at loose pages. She imagined the ledger lying beneath her arm, its columns of provisions and deployments, its omissions more eloquent than any entry. The figures had been copied by Caedmon Fellgard's careful hand. Caedmon Fellgard member of The Iron-Ring Cartel. The knowledge sat inside her like a swallowed hook.

She had sold intelligence before. She had sold routes, weaknesses, names of men who believed themselves beyond purchase. She had never sold a voice.

At the bottom of the stairs, Sabelle lifted a shuttered lamp from a niche in the wall. The flame inside was small and blue. It cast no warmth.

Morwenna's eyes adjusted to the chamber.

There were no barrels. No racks of preserved meat or casks of wine. No stores for a garrison, nor any evidence that Greyfell Citadel had been provisioned since House Morvain abandoned its claim to the place. The cellar was a low vault of bare stone. At its center stood an iron cage sunk into the floor, its bars blackened and carved with narrow lines of script.

Something was crouched inside.

Morwenna had seen men after a Ley-storm had taken their skin. She had seen sailors opened by winds that shone like molten glass, heard them beg for knives, for fire, for the mercy of being made singular again. The thing in the cage did not resemble any of them.

It wore a shape as a prisoner wore a uniform: without belonging to it.

A length of pale cloth covered its body from throat to ankle. Its head hung forward. Where its hands rested on the floor, the fingers were too still, each joint arranged with the patience of a corpse displayed for burial. A chain passed through the cage and disappeared into the stone beneath it.

Morwenna's breath shortened.

The thing raised its head.

No eyes showed beneath the cloth. Yet she felt its attention settle upon her with intimate precision.

"Not a revenant," Morwenna said.

Sabelle's silence answered.

"You keep this here."

"I contain it here."

"Why?"

"Because it cannot be allowed above."

"Then why did it call my name?"

The revenant's covered face tilted. Its voice came from somewhere behind Morwenna now, though the stairwell behind them was empty.

"Because you came carrying a door."

Morwenna did not turn.

The iron cage groaned. One of the bars bent inward, not far, but enough to make the sound of complaint.

Sabelle stepped between them. "You will not address her."

The revenant laughed.

The sound was faint. It had the dry rhythm of paper burning.

"You gave me a tongue," it said. "Do not be offended when I use it."

Morwenna's hand tightened around her sword. She studied the cage instead of the thing within it. The carved lines were not prayers. They had the repetition of instructions, though no script she knew had ever been written with such narrow, cruel strokes.

"Who else knows it is here?"

"No one who matters."

"That answer has killed better commanders than you."

Sabelle's face remained composed, but the blue flame sharpened the hollows around their eyes. "You mistake secrecy for weakness."

"I mistake nothing. Greyfell Citadel is abandoned. It lies outside the realm's core holdings. Yet two men serve here."

At that, the revenant stirred.

Sabelle's attention flicked toward her. "Who told you?"

"Caedmon's records."

"Caedmon Fellgard keeps records. He does not understand them."

"He understood enough to write that Brannoc Palefroth serves at Greyfell Citadel."

The revenant's fingers drew a slow line through the dust.

"And Ederon Coldwater serves at Greyfell Citadel," Morwenna continued. "Two servants in a dead stronghold. Two living hands to carry food, messages, keys."

"Brannoc Palefroth tends the outer walls," Sabelle said. "Ederon Coldwater tends the lower passages."

"Which includes this chamber."

"Which includes the doors before this chamber."

"Then one of them opened it."

Sabelle's mouth hardened. "Neither has the courage."

"Courage is not required for treachery."

“No,” said the revenant. “Only hunger.”

Its head turned toward the eastern wall. Beneath the stone came a muted impact. Once. Then again.

Someone was moving in the passage beyond.

Morwenna heard the discipline in it: weight placed carefully, pause held deliberately, breath controlled. Not a servant carrying a lantern. Not a man lost in the dark.

Sabelle lowered the lamp shutter. The chamber dimmed until only the blue coal of flame remained.

“Stand behind me,” they whispered.

Morwenna almost smiled. “You did not bring me here to protect me.”

“I brought you here because the thing wanted you.”

That was the first honest sentence Sabelle had given her.

Another impact struck the wall. Dust sifted from the ceiling.

Morwenna reached beneath her coat and drew a narrow packet sealed in wax. The wax had been impressed with no crest. Inside were three strips of treated cloth, each bearing a pattern of knots and punctures. To a stranger, they meant nothing. To the Iron-Ring Cartel, they marked a channel, a warning, a price.

She had received the packet before entering Greyfell. The instruction had been simple: confirm the presence of the hidden asset. Do not remove it. Do not allow the Inquisitor to know you have been sent.

She had assumed “asset” meant a document, a weapon, perhaps some remnant of the artifact said to have been destroyed in the Leaden Accord. She had not imagined a bound dead thing beneath a ruined citadel, speaking with borrowed voices.

Sabelle noticed the packet.

Their eyes fell upon it.

“You carry Cartel cipher.”

Morwenna felt the moment narrow around them.

The revenant whispered, “There is the door.”

Sabelle’s hand moved beneath the mantle. “You have been selling secrets.”

Morwenna did not deny it. Denial was a poor tactic when the enemy had already opened the correct book.

“Caedmon Fellgard is a member of The Iron-Ring Cartel,” she said. “His records travel farther than he does.”

“Do not make a confession sound like an accusation.”

“I am not confessing.”

“What are you doing?”

“Measuring how much you knew before tonight.”

The wall gave a third time.

A crack appeared between the stones. Blackness showed through it—not the absence of light, but a depth that seemed to lean toward the chamber. The revenant rose inside its cage.

It unfolded slowly. Cloth whispered against cloth. The iron chain pulled taut, and the stone beneath the cage answered with a low vibration that Morwenna felt in her teeth.

Sabelle raised the lamp.

For the first time, Morwenna saw beneath the cloth.

There was no face. Only a hollow filled with ash, and in that ash two pinpoints of wet red light.

“Open the eastern passage,” the revenant said.

Sabelle spoke a word in a language Morwenna did not know.

The cage flared. Lines of pale fire raced over the bars. The revenant convulsed, its hands closing into fists. From somewhere above came a cry, brief and human, followed by the scrape of a body falling down stone.

Morwenna turned toward the stair.

“Brannoc,” Sabelle said.

The name did not sound like an answer. It sounded like a verdict.

A second body struck the steps.

Then Ederon Coldwater appeared at the bottom of the stairwell, dragging Brannoc Palefroth by one arm. Blood ran from Ederon’s temple. Brannoc’s boots carved twin trails through the water, and his head lolled at an angle no living neck would tolerate.

Ederon looked at Morwenna first.

His expression held no surprise.

That frightened her more than the corpse.

“High Inquisitor,” he said, breathless. “The outer door is gone.”

Sabelle did not move. “Who opened it?”

Ederon glanced toward the cage.

The revenant had stopped struggling. Its red lights fixed upon him.

“Not me,” Ederon said.

Brannoc’s fingers twitched against the floor.

Morwenna stepped backward, placing herself where she could see the stair, the cage, and Sabelle’s hands. The packet of cipher cloth was still between her fingers. Its wax seal pressed into her palm.

From the wall came a slow, deliberate knocking.

Three times.

Then a voice spoke through the crack.

“Admiral.”

The title was spoken by someone outside.

Someone alive.

Morwenna knew that voice. She had heard it in war rooms and rain-swept yards, across tables where men lied with maps laid flat between them.

Sabelle turned on her.

“You know who that is.”

Morwenna’s mouth went dry.

The revenant lifted one hand toward the failing wall, and the chain beneath the cage began to unwind.

“I know,” Morwenna said.

The stones shifted.

Beyond them, the unseen speaker laughed softly.

And Morwenna realized the voice was not calling her in. It was calling the thing out.

The chain gave a final metallic sigh.

Morwenna drew her sword, though the blade was no more useful here than a mast in a grave. The chamber had narrowed around them. Dust sifted from the ceiling. Somewhere beyond the failing wall, stone scraped against stone with the patient hunger of a thing opening its own tomb.

Sabelle did not look at her.

“Say the name,” the High Inquisitor commanded.

The voice beyond the wall answered with another soft laugh.

“Still issuing orders, Twice-Crowned?”

Sabelle’s hand closed around the hilt at their side. The two crowns upon their brow were not visible in the dark, but Morwenna felt their weight in every word. Severity had always been Sabelle’s chosen armor. Tonight it had cracked, and beneath it lay something colder than fear.

“Caedmon,” Morwenna said.

The name passed through the room like a spark through oil.

Sabelle turned then. “You knew.”

“I knew the voice.”

“You knew he was here.”

“I knew he was not where he claimed to be.”

“Those are not the same thing.”

“No.” Morwenna kept her sword low. “They are not.”

The wall buckled. A seam opened from floor to lintel, black as a cut throat. Wind came through it, carrying the smell of wet ash and old iron. The revenant stirred in its cage. Its fingers tightened around the bars, each knuckle pale beneath skin that seemed stretched over a memory of flesh.

Sabelle stepped between Morwenna and the cage.

The revenant tilted its head.

Not toward Sabelle.

Toward Morwenna.

There was recognition in that ruined face. Not the simple recognition of a servant who had been ordered, or a prisoner who had been named. It knew her as a vessel knows the hand that once filled it. It knew the shape of her treason before she had given it a name.

Morwenna felt the folded paper in her palm grow warm.

The letter had no seal. That was the first insult. Caedmon Fellgard had always trusted ink more than wax, records more than oaths. A scribe could erase a king with a line drawn through his name. He could make a fleet vanish between one ledger and the next.

She unfolded the paper.

A few words had been written in the narrow, disciplined hand she knew from manifests and casualty rolls.

IRON-RING CARTEL.

Below it, a list.

Palewell Abbey.

The Pale Coast.

Greyfell Citadel.

The page trembled once between her fingers. She made it still.

Caedmon spoke through the widening breach. "You have carried my messages well, Admiral."

Sabelle's eyes moved to the paper.

Morwenna folded it again.

The lie arrived easily. It had been bred in her for years, fed on silence and polished by necessity.

"I carry no messages for you."

"Not for me."

The wall broke inward.

Caedmon Fellgard stood beyond the rubble with a lantern in one hand and a slim case of black wood beneath the other arm. Dust lay across his shoulders. His face remained composed, reserved, almost apologetic, as if he had interrupted a meal to correct a figure in a ledger.

He wore a scribe's gloves. Their fingertips were dark with ink.

Behind him, the passage climbed into darkness.

Sabelle raised a hand. The runes cut into the stone around the cage flared weakly, then guttered. "You have entered a sealed chamber."

"I have entered a room whose seal was purchased."

“By whom?”

Caedmon looked at Morwenna.

The old instinct took her by the throat: deny, command, make the accusation smaller than the authority that spoke it. She had been Fleet Admiral since before the Ashen Vanguard learned to fear the sound of her ships. Command had taught her that hesitation was a kind of confession.

But Caedmon had not come to accuse her.

He had come to collect.

“The Iron-Ring Cartel does not purchase seals,” Morwenna said. “It purchases people.”

“Then you understand the arrangement.”

Sabelle moved with sudden violence.

Their blade struck Caedmon’s lantern. Flame burst across the chamber. The scribe dropped the lamp, and the darkness swallowed him before the metal had finished ringing.

The revenant shrieked.

It was not a human sound. It had once been human, perhaps, but whatever had survived in the cellar had been stripped of every gentleness that made a voice worth hearing. The cage jumped on its chain. Iron shrilled against iron.

Morwenna saw Sabelle hesitate.

That was all Caedmon needed.

He emerged at the edge of the chamber, close enough that Morwenna saw ink beneath one fingernail. His hand came up—not with a weapon, but with a small square of parchment.

“Read it,” he said.

Morwenna did not take it.

“Read it.”

Sabelle’s blade turned toward his throat. “You will leave.”

Caedmon’s expression barely changed. “If I leave, the chamber opens.”

The chain above them snapped taut.

The cage rose a handspan from the floor.

Sabelle looked upward.

Morwenna looked at Caedmon.

“You bound it to the chain,” she said.

“No. The chain is bound to it.”

The revenant pressed its face between the bars. Its mouth opened, and a thread of black fluid ran from its tongue.

Sabelle’s composure returned in pieces. “You have no understanding of what you are touching.”

“I understand records. I understand custody. I understand that the High Inquisitor Sabelle Mournvale the Twice-Crowned keeps a bound revenant in their cellar, despite every decree written against such practices.”

The words did not echo. The room seemed to swallow them.

Morwenna watched Sabelle’s face.

Sabelle had been born in 263 AS, and there were moments when that fact showed—not in weakness, but in the depth of what they had survived. They had spent too long among tribunals, relics, and the confessions of frightened people. They had learned how to make terror kneel.

Now terror had found a chair at their table.

“You mistake secrecy for leverage,” Sabelle said.

“No.” Caedmon opened the black case. “I mistake nothing.”

Inside lay papers, folded and tied. One bore Morwenna’s private cipher. Another carried the mark of the Iron-Ring Cartel, pressed so faintly into the page that it might have been an accident.

Her blood cooled.

The passage behind Caedmon filled with a low groan. Far below, something answered the revenant. The sound travelled through the foundations of the citadel, through old mortar and buried chambers, until the floor beneath Morwenna’s boots shivered.

“What is in the case?” she asked.

“Copies.”

“Of what?”

“Your intelligence.”

Sabelle’s blade shifted toward her.

Morwenna did not turn. “You are lying.”

“I am a scribe.”

“That is not a denial.”

“No.”

Caedmon withdrew a packet and let it fall open. The pages slid against one another, whispering.

He had copied the movements of ships. Supply routes. Names of commanders. Signals used by the Ashen Vanguard. Places where patrols changed and where watchfires were permitted to die. Nothing in the pages was marked with her hand, yet she knew each secret as a captain knows the hidden damage in her hull.

She had sold them to the Iron-Ring Cartel one piece at a time.

Not for gold. Gold was too visible. The Cartel had paid in silence, in altered orders, in doors left unbarred when she needed them open. It had paid by ensuring that certain questions died before they reached her.

Morwenna’s gaze touched the papers and moved away.

Sabelle saw.

The High Inquisitor's voice was almost gentle. "How long?"

Morwenna felt the old rooms of her mind close their doors.

Caedmon answered for her. "Long enough that the first account predates the present arrangement of this citadel."

"Do not speak of arrangements," Sabelle said.

"Then speak of guilt."

The revenant struck the bars.

A crack ran through the nearest rune.

Morwenna moved before either of them could stop her. She seized the black case and drove her shoulder into Caedmon's chest. The scribe stumbled against the wall. Papers spilled into the dust.

Sabelle's blade came down.

Caedmon caught the wrist.

For a man made of ledgers and quiet posture, he possessed startling strength. His fingers closed around Sabelle's arm, and the High Inquisitor's crown of authority became irrelevant in the grip of bone and ink.

Morwenna saw the parchment square beneath Caedmon's coat.

She took it.

He released Sabelle at once.

The paper was heavier than it looked. A seal had been impressed into its corner—not wax, but a dark metallic compound that seemed to drink the lanternless gloom.

She opened it.

There was one sentence.

Morwenna Ashgrove was born in 288 AS.

Below that, in a different hand:

Every admiral has a first harbor.

Her breath stopped.

The date was not secret. It belonged to records, to birth rolls, to the orderly procession of facts that could not be killed by denial. Yet seeing it there made it intimate. A marker driven into the earth of her life.

Caedmon bent to retrieve the fallen pages.

Sabelle stared at Morwenna. "What does it say?"

Morwenna crumpled the parchment.

The revenant began to laugh.

"Do not let it out," she said.

Sabelle's eyes remained on her. "You think I am the danger?"

“I think you have kept a dead thing in a cage beneath the feet of everyone who trusts you.”

“And you have fed an enemy the names of those people.”

The accusation landed cleanly. Morwenna felt no wound, only the terrible precision of it.

Caedmon gathered the last page.

“Enough,” he said.

Neither listened.

The crack in the rune widened. A thread of pale light entered the chamber from nowhere, passing through the revenant’s ribs. For an instant Morwenna saw what lay inside the cage—not organs, not bones, but a cramped architecture of shadows, all of them turning toward the same unseen door.

Sabelle lifted both hands.

The crowns—whatever metal or sanctity they possessed—seemed to answer. The air thickened. Morwenna’s ears filled with a distant ringing.

“Stand back,” Sabelle commanded.

Caedmon went still.

Morwenna did not.

The revenant’s hand emerged through the bars.

Its fingers reached for her.

Not Sabelle. Not Caedmon.

Her.

The chain overhead began to unwind again, links dropping through the dark with deliberate, measured clanks.

Morwenna understood then what the voice had meant.

It had not called the revenant out of the cellar.

It had called the cellar out of the world.

The floor opened beneath the cage.

Sabelle seized Morwenna by the arm. Caedmon seized the other.

For one absurd moment they stood joined together, High Inquisitor, Fleet Admiral, and scribe, bound by a danger none of them could command.

Below them, darkness breathed.

And from that darkness came a voice that was not Caedmon’s, not the revenant’s, not any living voice at all.

“Admiral.”

The chain fell.

Morwenna looked down.

Something below had opened its eyes.

Chapter 9

The rain had the color of old iron when Ignatz Ashgrove the Oathless entered the records chamber.

It slid from the eaves of Fenspire and hissed against the shutters, turning the fortress into a sealed thing of stone, smoke, and listening dark. Beyond the narrow windows, the Gloaming Reach lay drowned beneath a low sky. The spire's shadow reached across the yard, where men moved without speaking beneath hooded cloaks. Their boots struck the flagstones in a rhythm too orderly to be prayer.

Ignatz did not look at them.

He carried no papers in his hands. That was why the sentries watched him as he passed.

At the end of the chamber, a brazier burned without warmth. A table stood before it, black wood scarred by old blades and older decisions. Upon the table rested a sealed packet, a cup gone cold, and a strip of pale metal bearing the ward-mark of The Hollow Edge.

The mark had been cut into the metal before Ignatz was born, in 216 AS, when the ward was forged. He had touched it once and felt emptiness open beneath his skin. Attunement to The Hollow Edge costs 21. The knowledge sat in his mind like a buried nail.

He left it untouched.

"Warden-Commander."

The voice came from the darkness beside the brazier.

Ignatz stopped.

The quartermaster stepped forward, holding a lantern low. His face remained indistinct in the weak light, his authority expressed in ledgers, keys, and the habit of being obeyed. The registry named him Ignatz Marrowgate, Quartermaster. The shared name had amused other men. Ignatz Ashgrove had never found it amusing.

"Quartermaster," he said.

Marrowgate placed the lantern upon the table. "The seal was broken before it reached me."

"Then it did not reach you sealed."

"It reached me with the appearance of being sealed."

"Appearances are a poor defense."

"They are the defense that remains when the truth has been removed."

The quartermaster's gaze dropped to the packet. Wax gleamed along its edge, blackened by handling.

"You requested the Blackport rolls."

"I requested every surviving account of the purge."

"You have the rolls."

"I have a packet."

"Would you prefer I call it a miracle?"

Ignatz moved to the table. Rain trembled against the shutters. Somewhere within the walls, a chain dragged across stone, then fell silent.

“Where are the casualty ledgers?”

Marrowgate’s fingers tightened around the lantern handle. “There are no complete ledgers.”

“There is a figure.”

“There is always a figure.”

“Say it.”

The quartermaster’s expression did not change, but the flame bent in the draft and threw a thin blade of light across his mouth.

“70907.”

The number entered the room and seemed to remain there.

Ignatz heard, behind it, the old noise: gates splitting under fire; water ladled from poisoned wells; boots moving through streets where no one had the strength to bar a door. He had not been at Blackport. Memory did not require witness. Men carried it in their silences. They carried it in the way they refused water offered by a stranger.

“The Purge of Blackport began in 311 AS,” Ignatz said.

Marrowgate watched him.

“Say the rest.”

“It ended in 321 AS.”

“And the casualty figure?”

“70907.”

“Again.”

“70907.”

Ignatz laid two fingers on the packet. The paper beneath the seal had softened with damp. “The rolls say the same?”

“The rolls say many things.”

“Do not answer with fog.”

“I answer with what was written.”

“Who wrote them?”

“Hands.”

“Whose hands?”

“Dead hands, mostly.”

Ignatz looked toward the shutters. The rain pressed against them like a crowd trying to overhear.

Blackport had been spoken of as a victory until victory lost its shape. The Iron-Ring Cartel emerged as victor. That sentence appeared in every account with the stubbornness of a grave marker. The aggressors had been routed. Total rout, the military register called it, as though a neat phrase could cleanse the earth.

But the wells had been poisoned.

Not by the defeated. By the victors.

Ignatz knew this because the intelligence had passed through him in fragments: a shipment diverted, a seal copied, an order altered after it had already been obeyed. The pieces had come from mouths that believed themselves safe. He had gathered them, weighed them, and sold them.

Ignatz Ashgrove the Oathless secretly sells intelligence to the Iron-Ring Cartel.

There was no gentler way to name it.

Marrowgate drew back from the table. "You are not reading the rolls."

"I am reading the room."

"The room has no testimony."

"Rooms keep what men spill in them."

"Then this one is full."

Ignatz broke the packet's seal.

The sound was small. Marrowgate flinched as if it had been a shot.

Inside lay sheets of grey paper, a few brittle, a few fresh enough to carry the bitter scent of ink. Ignatz lifted the first. The writing had been copied by several hands. Some lines were cramped, others ceremonious. Names had been scraped away. Locations had been replaced with marks. Certain passages were nothing but black bars.

He read without moving his lips.

A convoy had arrived at Blackport carrying grain, salt, and sealed casks. The casks had been opened under guard. The wells had been declared unsafe after the sickness began. An order had gone out to preserve the city's remaining stores for military use.

No signature.

No date beyond the one already burned into every account.

"The Cartel's wells," Ignatz said.

Marrowgate's lantern flame guttered. "The packet does not say that."

"It says enough."

"It says poison was found in the water."

"Water does not poison itself."

"Sometimes it does."

"Not in patterns."

Marrowgate came around the table. "You speak as though you were there."

"I speak as though I can read."

"No. You speak as though you know what the Iron-Ring Cartel intended."

Ignatz raised his eyes.

The quartermaster had not meant to say it. That was the dangerous part. Truth often escaped through the mouth wearing the mask of accusation.

The chamber seemed to contract around them. The brazier breathed red beneath its ash. Ignatz felt the old instinct rise in him—not fear, exactly, but the calculation fear left behind after command had beaten it into discipline.

He could kill Marrowgate.

The thought arrived without heat. The room offered opportunities: the lantern, the packet knife, the ungarded throat. But murder would turn suspicion into shape. It would also waste a man who might still be useful.

"You believe the Cartel poisoned its own allies," Ignatz said.

"I believe the records are inconsistent."

"You believe the wells were poisoned."

"I believe people died after drinking from them."

"You believe the Iron-Ring Cartel emerged as victor."

"That is what the accounts state."

"Then you believe nothing."

Marrowgate's hand moved toward his belt and stopped before reaching it. "You ask questions that do not belong to a Warden-Commander."

"Questions belong to whoever survives the answers."

The quartermaster leaned close. His breath smelled of bitterroot and stale smoke. "There are messages leaving Fenspire."

Ignatz let the silence answer.

"From this chamber," Marrowgate continued. "From the garrison stores. From the quarantine dispatches. Someone is selling the Cartel what it cannot take by force."

Rain thrummed harder against the shutters.

"Someone," Ignatz said.

"Someone who knows the routes. The watch rotations. The weakness in the western wall."

"Those are many someones."

"Not many can command men to look elsewhere."

Ignatz folded the page and placed it atop the packet. "Are you accusing me?"

“I am warning you.”

“Warnings are accusations that fear to stand upright.”

Marrowgate’s mouth hardened. “You were born in 258 AS. You have worn command long enough to understand what a breach costs.”

The use of his birth year struck him more sharply than the accusation. Not because it mattered, but because Marrowgate had chosen it. Facts could be made into knives if held at the right angle.

Ignatz turned back to the table. “Do not use my birth as a summons to obedience.”

“I use it to remind you that you have been here longer than some men have been alive.”

The statement was too broad, too careless. Ignatz disregarded it. He touched the edge of the packet instead.

A second object lay beneath the papers, wrapped in dark cloth. He drew it free.

The reliquary was smaller than his palm, its surface powdered with ash that did not fall when he tilted it. Chalice of Ashdeep had been forged in 323 AS. Attunement to it costs 27. The name was not engraved. It seemed to exist in the metal’s severe silence.

Marrowgate took a step back.

“That was not listed.”

“Many things are not listed.”

“Put it down.”

Ignatz studied the wrapped reliquary. It held no visible lock, no hinge, no seam. Yet the ash upon it stirred toward his skin.

“Why was this in the Blackport packet?”

“I do not know.”

“Who sent it?”

“I do not know.”

“Why are you afraid of it?”

“I am not.”

The ash crawled against the metal.

Marrowgate seized the lantern and lifted it. “Warden-Commander.”

Ignatz felt the reliquary’s weight change. For an instant it seemed filled with water. Then with teeth. A pressure gathered behind his eyes, and with it came the impression of a chamber beneath Blackport: stone walls sweating darkly, a row of empty vessels, a hand lowering something into a well.

Not a vision. Not precisely.

A memory that did not belong to him.

He closed his fingers around the reliquary.

The pressure vanished.

Marrowgate whispered, "What did you see?"

Ignatz slipped the object into his coat. "Nothing."

"That is a lie."

"Yes."

The quartermaster stared at him, and in that stare Ignatz saw the shape of every oath he had once been expected to keep. Duty. Protection. Obedience. Words carved into men until they mistook the scars for virtue.

He had broken them all quietly.

He sold intelligence to the Iron-Ring Cartel because information traveled farther than armies and left fewer bodies in the road. That was the argument he had given himself. He had repeated it through sleepless nights, in command tents, beneath the pale sky above Gloamreach, while sealed messages passed from his hands into darker hands.

The argument had never mentioned poisoned wells.

It had never mentioned 70907.

A knock sounded at the outer door.

Marrowgate turned.

Ignatz did not.

The knock came again, careful and formal.

A voice spoke from beyond the wood. "Warden-Commander. A dispatch from the coast."

Gloamreach lay along the Pale Coast, quarantined behind its own silence. Nothing entered without scrutiny. Nothing left without record. Yet the messenger had arrived in the rain, bearing a dispatch that had not passed through the chamber's registry.

Marrowgate looked at Ignatz.

Ignatz looked at the sealed door.

The reliquary pressed coldly against his ribs.

"Open it," he said.

Marrowgate did not move. "Are you certain?"

"No."

The quartermaster's hand reached for the bar.

Ignatz placed his palm upon the packet, feeling the damp paper, the broken seal, the concealed lines beneath the ink.

On the other side of the door, the messenger breathed once.

Then the voice said, "The Iron-Ring Cartel sends its regards."

The bar lifted with a sound like a bone being drawn from flesh.

Marrowgate opened the door only as far as the chain allowed. Rain pressed through the gap in silver threads, carrying the raw smell of the Pale Coast and something fouler beneath it—the stagnant breath of a place sealed too long against the living world.

No face appeared beyond the door.

A gloved hand entered the gap. It held a black cylinder bound in waxed cord.

“Take it,” said the messenger.

Marrowgate did not. His fingers remained upon the bar.

Ignatz watched the packet instead. The paper was not black, though the corridor beyond seemed to make it so. Water had darkened its edges. The seal bore no crest he recognized, only a ring pressed into red wax until the center had split.

The Iron-Ring Cartel had never needed heraldry. Its mark was a promise made by pressure.

“Who sent you?” Marrowgate asked.

“The Iron-Ring Cartel.”

“That was not my question.”

“No,” said the voice. “It was the safer one.”

The rain ticked against the threshold. Somewhere deeper in the keep, a bell gave a single muted note and fell silent.

Ignatz felt the reliquary beneath his coat. The Chalice of Ashdeep rested against his ribs with the patience of buried fire. It was not heavy in the ordinary sense. Weight suggested matter. The thing carried consequence instead.

“Open the door,” he said.

Marrowgate turned his head. “Commander—”

“Open it.”

The quartermaster undid the chain.

The messenger entered without haste. Water darkened the hem of the cloak, and droplets trembled from the leather gloves. No insignia marked the clothing. No weapon showed. That absence was more deliberate than any sword.

Marrowgate shut the door behind the messenger. The chamber tightened around the three of them.

Ignatz remained beside the table, one hand resting upon the packet he had brought from the registry. The other hung loose at his side. He had trained himself to keep his hands empty when men lied to him. It made them wonder what he had concealed elsewhere.

The messenger placed the cylinder before him.

“From the Cartel,” the voice said.

“I heard you.”

“Then you heard enough to know why it is here.”

Ignatz studied the seal. “I know only that Gloamreach is quarantined, that nothing enters without scrutiny, and that this arrived without a registry mark.”

“Then you know the Cartel has given you a gift.”

“The Cartel does not give gifts.”

“No.” A pause. “It collects debts.”

The words entered the room and found their old places.

Marrowgate moved toward the brazier. The coals had sunk beneath a crust of ash. He stirred them, though there was no need, and sparks climbed briefly before dying. His silence had changed. Ignatz knew that silence. It belonged to the years before a decision, when a man measured obedience against survival and found both wanting.

“Leave us,” Ignatz said.

Marrowgate’s hand stopped upon the poker.

The messenger made no sound.

“You heard me,” Ignatz continued.

“I am the quartermaster of this garrison.”

“You are a quartermaster in a sealed keep.”

“I am also responsible for every document brought into this chamber.”

“Then you will be responsible for the door.”

Marrowgate looked at him. The firelight caught in the water pooled at the messenger’s feet, turning it the color of old blood.

“Maelis Harrowick the Pale would not have sent me away.”

The name struck with greater force than any accusation.

Ignatz saw, not a woman, not a face—nothing so merciful—but the shape of a lesson. A hand correcting the angle of a blade. A voice insisting that an oath was not a chain but a witness. The memory had no room in him, yet it entered.

“Do not invoke your mentor to win an argument,” Ignatz said.

“Maelis Harrowick the Pale was my mentor,” Marrowgate answered. “If I invoke her, it is because she taught me to know when a sealed room contains more danger than the corridor.”

“Your mentor is not here.”

“No. She is not.”

The messenger tilted the head. A drop of rain fell from the cloak and struck the floor.

Ignatz hated the Cartel for knowing how to make silence useful. He hated himself for recognizing the workmanship.

He had sold them routes, strength reports, names that had been written in his own hand. He had told himself each exchange was an incision, a small wound made to prevent a greater bleeding. The Cartel had accepted his intelligence without thanks, which was how he knew they valued it.

Now it had reached into Gloamreach and placed its fingers upon the Chalice of Ashdeep.

Or it wanted him to believe that it had.

“Marrowgate,” he said, “go to the outer passage. Remain within call.”

The quartermaster did not move.

“Do it.”

The man’s jaw worked once. Then he unbarred the door and stepped through, leaving it open behind him.

Ignatz waited until the footsteps had faded into the rain.

The messenger spoke. “He is loyal.”

“Loyalty is not a defense against being used.”

“Nor is treachery.”

Ignatz cut the cord.

Inside the cylinder was a strip of thin vellum rolled around a shard of grey glass. No script showed at first. He held it near the brazier.

Letters surfaced in the warmth, pale and wavering.

CROOKGATE KEEP.

Below it, a second line appeared.

THE CHALICE OF ASHDEEP IS HOUSED IN CROOKGATE KEEP.

Ignatz did not breathe.

The room seemed to retreat from him. The walls withdrew into their mortar, the rain into the distance, the fire into its bed of ash. The reliquary against his ribs grew cold enough to burn.

The messenger watched him.

“Where did you get this?”

“The Cartel knows where its interests lie.”

“That is not an answer.”

“It is the only one you purchased.”

The words were mild. That made them cruel.

Ignatz placed the vellum upon the table. The grey glass shard lay beside it, dull as a dead eye. He had seen such glass in the aftermath of the Sundering, set into wards and doors and the throats of men who had died trying to open them. It held no reflection.

“Why tell me?”

“Because Crookgate Keep is not yours.”

“Nothing in this realm is mine.”

“Your command says otherwise.”

“My command says I keep what I am ordered to keep.”

“And what are you ordered to keep?”

Ignatz looked down at the reliquary’s concealed shape. “You already know.”

The messenger’s silence confirmed too much.

The Chalice of Ashdeep had been moved under authority that had never reached his desk. The registry held no entry. No guard had reported a transfer. No seal had been broken in the chambers where such things were recorded.

Yet the Cartel knew.

That was the horror of it—not that the Cartel possessed spies, but that every wall had begun to behave as though it belonged to them.

“The Iron-Ring Cartel emerged victor of The Purge of Blackport,” Ignatz said.

“Did it?”

“The records say so.”

“Records are obedient things.”

He remembered Blackport as a word spoken in briefings, always surrounded by figures and red marks. Victory had been declared there. Victory had been celebrated there. The Cartel had stood among the ruins and claimed the end of the killing.

A victory could be clean only from a distance.

“Why Crookgate Keep?” Ignatz asked.

The messenger’s head turned slightly toward the packet in his hand. “Because the Cartel wants you to understand that a fortress can be opened without a gate.”

“And if I refuse to understand?”

“Then someone else will.”

“Who?”

No answer.

Ignatz folded the vellum once. The letters began to fade at the edges, sinking back into the fibers.

He could summon Marrowgate. He could order a search. He could place every corridor under arms and have the keep turned inside out until the stone itself confessed. But the Chalice of Ashdeep was not merely an object to be found. It was a burden of knowledge. Whoever had housed it in Crookgate Keep had believed concealment stronger than custody.

Or had believed Ignatz would remain ignorant.

He thought of the Cartel's intelligence in his own reports: troop movements, provisions, patrol gaps, the quiet arithmetic of fear. He had sold information because information was weightless. One could pass it through a hand and pretend the hand remained clean.

The reliquary disproved that lie.

The door shifted in its frame.

Marrowgate stood beyond it, one palm against the wood. He had heard enough to know the shape of the danger, if not its name.

"Commander," he said.

Ignatz slid the vellum beneath the packet.

"Come in."

Marrowgate entered. His gaze went to the grey shard, then to the cylinder, then to Ignatz's coat. He understood more than Ignatz wanted him to understand.

"Is it about the keep?" he asked.

"It is about Crookgate Keep."

"That is a distinction without mercy."

The messenger moved toward the door.

Ignatz said, "You will not leave."

"I have delivered the message."

"You have delivered a threat."

"A threat is a message that expects to be remembered."

"Then remain and watch me remember it."

The messenger paused.

Marrowgate looked between them. The brazier breathed a low red glow. Outside, the rain thickened against the sealed windows, and Gloamreach became a world made entirely of water and walls.

Ignatz set his palm over the reliquary.

"Tell the Cartel," he said, "that if the Chalice of Ashdeep is housed in Crookgate Keep, then someone has placed it there for a reason."

"Someone has."

"Tell them I will find that reason."

The messenger's voice softened.

"They know you will."

A sound came from the outer passage: a hurried step, then another. Marrowgate turned toward it.

Ignatz felt the cold beneath his hand deepen.

The messenger reached for the door.

And from somewhere inside the keep, a second voice began to call Marrowgate's name.

The messenger's hand stopped on the latch.

"Marrowgate," the voice called again.

It came from the passage beyond the door. Not loudly. Not urgently. It possessed the intimate patience of a man speaking to someone who had only stepped into the next room.

Ignatz Marrowgate had not moved. His palm remained beneath Ignatz's, hovering over the reliquary as if the Quartermaster feared that even air might disturb it.

Ignatz watched him.

"Answer," he said.

Marrowgate swallowed. "Commander?"

The voice called his name a third time.

This time it came from behind them.

The rain pressed against the windows. The red glow under the reliquary's lid trembled, and the iron seams of the chamber gave a faint, inward creak.

Marrowgate turned.

Ignatz caught his sleeve.

"Do not."

"But—"

"Do not answer anything that knows your name."

The Quartermaster looked at him then, and the fear in his face was not for himself. It was the fear of a man who had been handed a burden too large to carry and had only now felt it breathe.

Ignatz knew that fear. He had worn it beneath armor, beneath rank, beneath the hard silence expected of a Warden-Commander. His birth had been entered as 258 AS. The record had never asked what had been taken from him before that year ended, nor what he had learned afterward about the uses of obedience.

The voice came once more.

"Marrowgate."

The door shuddered.

The messenger drew his blade. Its edge was dull with old work, but his grip was steady enough.

Ignatz looked down at the reliquary. The Chalice of Ashdeep lay within its black housing, forged in 323 AS, though no metal in the chamber had the right to feel so young. It seemed to draw age from the stones. A thread of frost had formed across the lid.

"Take your hand away," Ignatz said.

Marrowgate obeyed.

The cold withdrew from Ignatz's palm with a slow, reluctant pull. He imagined roots being torn from flesh.

Outside, something scraped along the passage wall.

"Who is there?" the messenger called.

Ignatz's fingers closed around the weapon at his hip. The Hollow Edge had been forged in 216 AS. It was not a sword, though the hand remembered it as one. The ward rested against his side with the weight of a sealed grave.

A reply came through the door.

"Your commander."

The messenger glanced at Ignatz.

Ignatz felt the keep listening.

"Open it," he said.

Marrowgate stared at him.

"Commander—"

"Open it."

The messenger lifted the latch.

The door swung inward on a breath of wet darkness.

No one stood in the passage.

Water crawled across the flagstones in thin black rivulets. The lamps burned low, each flame bent toward the empty corridor. Farther on, where the passage turned toward the inner stair, a pale shape seemed to wait—then vanished when the nearest lamp guttered.

The voice spoke from the stairwell.

"Marrowgate."

The Quartermaster stepped forward.

Ignatz seized him by the collar and pulled him back hard enough to make the man choke.

At the same instant, the Hollow Edge stirred.

It did not ring. It gave a sensation of absence: a pressure behind the eyes, a hollowing in the teeth. Attunement to The Hollow Edge cost 21. Ignatz had paid it in a room with no witnesses, and ever since, the ward had known the shape of his fear better than any living creature.

The corridor darkened around its edge.

There, beneath the archway, lay a footprint.

Then another.

They were wet, narrow, and pointed toward the chamber.

The messenger raised his blade.

Ignatz held up two fingers.

The footsteps continued, though nothing made them.

Marrowgate's breath trembled against his teeth. He was born in 425 AS, and his service as a Quartermaster had taught him the arithmetic of hunger: what could be stored, what must be spent, what loss could be concealed beneath a clean tally. It had not taught him what to do when a dead corridor began counting its way toward him.

From the dark beyond the stair, a woman's voice said, "You brought the intelligence."

Ignatz felt something inside him tighten.

The Iron-Ring Cartel had paid for intelligence before. Coin had crossed from gloved hands to hidden compartments; messages had left Gloamreach under seals that belonged to other men. He had sold them routes, dispositions, weaknesses in walls and in commanders. He had never sold them this.

The voice continued.

"You brought the reliquary."

The messenger looked at Ignatz now. Suspicion came easily to men who served near sealed doors. It needed no proof, only a direction in which to face.

Ignatz stepped into the passage.

The air smelled of rainwater, lamp oil, and old ashes.

"Show yourself."

The dark gave a low murmur.

Then a figure emerged beneath the arch.

It wore a coat soaked black from collar to hem. No face could be seen beneath the hood. A chain of iron rings hung across its breast, each ring pale with moisture.

The messenger cursed under his breath.

Ignatz did not.

The five powers of the Ashen Era had each learned to disguise appetite as doctrine. The Ashen Vanguard called its hunger duty. House Morvain called it inheritance. The Silent Choir called it silence. The Iron-Ring Cartel called it commerce. The Bleeding Crown called it rule. But the figure in the passage had no insignia beyond those rings, and that was enough.

"You are not the Cartel," Ignatz said.

"No."

"Then you are a thief."

"Is that what you call yourself?"

Marrowgate made a small sound.

The figure turned its hood toward him.

"Do you remember Maelis Harrowick the Pale?" it asked.

Marrowgate went rigid.

Ignatz saw the answer before the Quartermaster gave it. The name entered the corridor like a blade laid flat upon a table.

“My mentor,” Marrowgate whispered.

The figure’s hood inclined.

“Your mentor knew where the ash was buried.”

“Maelis is dead,” Marrowgate said.

“Dead things keep better accounts.”

Ignatz moved before Marrowgate could speak again. He drew The Hollow Edge.

The ward appeared as a line of darkness, not black but vacant, as though the world had forgotten how to reflect upon it. The lamps leaned away.

The figure in the hood did not retreat.

“Do you know why Gloamreach is quarantined?” it asked.

Ignatz held the ward before him.

“Because the Pale Coast has no patience for carelessness.”

“Gloamreach lies on the Pale Coast. Its garrison is 2,483. Men and women behind walls, told that the walls are the reason they live.”

The rain hissed in the sealed windows behind him.

“What has that to do with this?”

“Everything.”

The figure lifted one hand. Its fingers were bare and wet. “Fenspire stands in the Gloaming Reach. It was founded in 57 AS. Its garrison is 3,742. A disciplined place. A vigilant place. A place that has mistaken permanence for protection.”

The messenger shifted his footing.

Ignatz heard the movement and the fear beneath it.

“Speak plainly,” he said.

“Plain speech is for those who can afford to be understood.”

The figure looked past him, toward the chamber and the reliquary.

“The Chalice of Ashdeep was forged in 323 AS. Attunement to it costs 27.”

Marrowgate’s face had gone bloodless.

Ignatz tightened his grip on The Hollow Edge. Attunement to it cost 21. He felt the old emptiness open within his hand, listening for the Chalice, measuring the distance between severance and surrender.

“You know too much,” he said.

“I know what the Cartel wants.”

“And what does it want?”

The hooded figure’s head turned slightly.

“To open the cup.”

The reliquary clicked behind them.

Not loudly.

A sound like a fingernail touching glass.

Marrowgate flinched. The messenger looked toward the chamber.

Ignatz did not turn. He watched the figure.

“What is inside?”

“The part of the Sundering that learned to thirst.”

No one spoke.

The statement settled into the stones. Somewhere below, water moved through hidden channels. The keep seemed less like a fortress than a body with its organs buried beneath the floor.

Ignatz had stood at the edges of the Purge of Blackport. He had seen what victory did to men who believed themselves cleansed by it. The Iron-Ring Cartel had emerged as victor, and the tale had been made into a banner. Banners did not carry the smell of poisoned wells. Banners did not remember the hands of their own allies sinking beneath black water.

He had sold intelligence to the Iron-Ring Cartel because information was lighter than blood.

He had told himself that every secret was merely a door.

The figure in the passage said, “You sent them the road to Crookgate Keep.”

“I sent them nothing.”

“You sent them enough.”

Marrowgate turned on him.

“Commander?”

There it was: the true voice. Not the corridor’s imitation. Not the wet whisper beneath the arch. A human voice, cracked by betrayal.

Ignatz could have lied. He had done so with better faces watching.

Instead, he said, “The Cartel knew the reliquary was here.”

“You knew,” Marrowgate said.

“I knew they were searching.”

“You knew.”

The figure raised its hand.

The door behind Ignatz slammed shut.

The messenger spun and drove his blade into the wood. It struck with a flat, useless sound. The lock had not moved. The door had become part of the wall.

In the chamber, the reliquary opened.

Red light poured through the passage.

Marrowgate cried out. The figure in the hood recoiled, and for the first time Ignatz saw beneath the shadow where a face should have been.

There was no face.

Only a pale hollow, deep enough to contain the red glow of the Chalice.

The Hollow Edge pulled toward it.

Ignatz's wrist twisted. Pain climbed his arm.

The figure spoke with many voices now, layered and wet.

"Choose, Warden-Commander."

Behind him, Marrowgate began to pray.

Before him, the faceless hollow widened.

And in the red light, the first drop fell from the Chalice of Ashdeep.

Chapter 10

Greyfell Citadel rose from the Shattered Vale like a tooth left in a dead mouth.

Morwenna Ashgrove saw it first through a curtain of rain: grey walls, broken towers, and the black gaps where banners had once strained against the wind. No fires marked the battlements. No watchman called from the gatehouse. The road beneath her horse's hooves had narrowed to two muddy ruts between thorn and stone, and the silence beyond them seemed to possess weight.

Greyfell Citadel was abandoned.

The thought entered her with less force than the rain. Abandoned places had their own discipline. They kept no sentries, made no demands, offered no testimony. They were useful because the living disliked entering them, and more useful still because the dead did not care who listened.

She raised one gloved hand.

The small procession halted behind her. Leather creaked. A horse breathed steam into the wet air. No one spoke. They had learned not to speak when she lifted her hand.

Fleet Admiral was a title that made silence obey.

Morwenna looked back only once. The men and women behind her wore no colors bright enough to carry across a field. Their cloaks were rain-dark, their weapons wrapped against the weather. She had chosen them for their obedience and for the absence of questions in their faces. Questions were a kind of hunger. Hunger made people careless.

Then she turned toward the gate.

A chain shifted overhead.

The gatehouse had been empty when they reached it. Now a figure stood beneath the arch, pale against the dark stone. The figure wore a long coat soaked nearly black, and over it the severe collar of an inquisitor. Two narrow crowns had been worked into the metal at the throat.

Sabelle Mournvale the Twice-Crowned waited beneath the ruined arch.

Morwenna dismounted. Mud took her boots to the ankle. She felt the cold find its way through the seams of her gloves, but kept her hands at her sides.

"High Inquisitor," she said.

"I am Sabelle Mournvale the Twice-Crowned," Sabelle replied. "And I am the High Inquisitor."

Their voice was neither loud nor soft. It carried because the citadel carried it, giving the words back in thin, fractured echoes.

Morwenna approached until the rain struck both of them equally.

"I know who you are."

"Then you know why I asked you to come."

"I know only that the summons bore your seal."

Sabelle regarded her with the patient severity of an executioner examining a knot. Their face gave away nothing that Morwenna could use. That was not the same as having nothing to hide. Morwenna had

learned the difference in rooms where men confessed before they understood they had been accused.

“The seal was sufficient,” Sabelle said.

“It was inconvenient.”

“Those are not opposing qualities.”

Behind Sabelle, the gate stood open on a courtyard drowned in weeds. The rain had made black mirrors of the flagstones. A collapsed gallery leaned against the inner wall, its beams jutting like ribs. Somewhere farther inside, water dripped with the stubborn rhythm of a clock that had forgotten the hour.

Morwenna glanced at the ruin.

“You chose a dead fortress.”

“I chose a place beyond the realm’s core holdings.”

“That is a careful distinction.”

“It is the distinction keeping us alive.”

The words settled between them.

Morwenna had heard versions of that sentence from lords, commanders, priests, and merchants. Every faction made a sacrament of survival. The Ashen Vanguard called it duty. House Morvain called it inheritance. The Silent Choir called it silence. The Iron-Ring Cartel called it profit.

She had called it a message sent through three hands and paid for in coin she had never touched.

The memory came unbidden: a scrap of oiled paper, hidden beneath a naval dispatch; a cipher she had not needed to read twice; the knowledge that a fleet’s course could be altered by a single omission. She had sold intelligence to the Iron-Ring Cartel because information had always been worth more than blood, and because the Cartel understood that truth had no loyalty except to the highest bidder.

Yet here, in the rain before Greyfell Citadel, she felt the old transaction turn in her mind like a blade.

Sabelle stepped aside.

“Come in.”

Morwenna did not move.

“Do you expect my escort to remain outside?”

“I expect your escort to remain where it is.”

“They are under my command.”

“Not within these walls.”

Morwenna let the rain collect along the brim of her hat. The men behind her waited in the road, watching without seeming to watch. If she entered alone, they would read it as confidence. If she refused, they would read it as fear. Both readings could become dangerous in other mouths.

She looked once more into the citadel. The dark beyond the gate was not empty. The air had the stale chill of a cellar, though the courtyard lay open to the sky.

“Keep the gate unbarred,” she said to no one in particular.

One of her escort acknowledged her with a movement of the head.

Sabelle's gaze sharpened.

"You fear a trap?"

"I fear doors."

"A peculiar weakness for a Fleet Admiral."

"Ships with doors can still sink."

For the first time, something like amusement touchedabelle's mouth. It vanished before Morwenna could decide whether she had truly seen it.

She entered.

The citadel smelled of wet stone, rotting straw, and old ash. Her boots struck the courtyard flagstones with measured force. The sound went nowhere. Rain ran from the broken crenellations in silver threads, gathering in the cracks and spilling beneath the doors of shuttered buildings.

Greyfell Citadel had been founded in 62 AS in the Shattered Vale, though no inscription remained intact enough to prove it. Morwenna had read the surviving records in naval archives that no longer admitted to owning them. Founding stones, siege tallies, inventories of grain and iron, lists of men whose descendants had forgotten the names. Every stronghold believed its records would outlive its walls. Greyfell had disproved the belief.

Sabelle led her beneath an archway scarred by fire.

"Why here?" Morwenna asked.

"Because certain things are easier to hear where no one is speaking."

"That sounds like the doctrine of the Silent Choir."

"Does it?"

"You tell me."

Sabelle did not answer. Their hands were folded behind their back. The cuffs of their coat showed no mud, though the courtyard was thick with it. Morwenna noticed that. She noticed everything that was too clean.

They passed into a narrow hall. The ceiling had collapsed at one end, exposing a strip of rain-clouded sky. At the other, a staircase descended into darkness.

Sabelle stopped beside it.

Morwenna felt the air change.

The cold rose from below, carrying a smell beneath the damp stone. Not rot. Not exactly. Something sweeter, older, with the faint mineral sting of blood left too long in a sealed vessel.

She did not look down.

"You keep company beneath the earth," she said.

Sabelle turned their head.

"Do I?"

“There is a breathing sound.”

“There are many sounds in abandoned places.”

The sound came again.

A slow drag. A wet exhalation. Then a faint scrape against stone, as if fingernails—or something remembering fingernails—moved across the wall below.

Morwenna’s pulse remained steady. Years of command had not taught her courage. They had taught her how to make fear wait.

“Is that why you summoned me?” she asked.

“No.”

“Then you brought me here to hear it.”

“I brought you here because I wanted to see whether you would pretend not to.”

Morwenna studied Sabelle’s face. The High Inquisitor wore severity as other people wore armor, but armor disclosed the direction of a blow. Sabelle disclosed nothing.

“Your methods are theatrical.”

“Your reputation is theatrical.”

“My reputation was assembled by people who needed me to be seen.”

“Then you have something in common with every ruler who has survived the Ashen Era.”

The dead thing below breathed once more.

Morwenna thought of the Leaden Accord, of its hosts swallowed beneath a Ley-storm and its victory declared over graves no victor had entered. The Iron-Ring Cartel had been named victor. Named, not crowned. There were words that functioned as locks. If repeated often enough, they kept the truth outside.

A supposedly destroyed artifact had been spirited away.

She had not seen it. She had seen the movement of ships, the sudden silence in ledgers, the frightened arithmetic of those who thought concealment meant safety. She had sold pieces of that knowledge to the Cartel and kept the most dangerous pieces behind her teeth.

Sabelle watched her.

“You know why the Cartel was pleased with the Accord,” they said.

Morwenna let her gaze drift to the stairwell.

“The Iron-Ring Cartel is pleased by anything that leaves a market.”

“And you?”

“I am pleased when my fleet returns.”

“You have no fleet here.”

“No,” Morwenna said. “I have only my name.”

“Names are vessels. They carry what is put inside them.”

“And what have you put inside mine?”

Sabelle turned toward the corridor. “Not yet.”

They resumed walking.

At the end of the hall, a pair of iron doors stood open. Beyond them, the old council chamber waited beneath a roof of patched timber. A table occupied its center, its surface covered with maps, sealed packets, and a shallow brass basin in which rainwater trembled though no drop fell near it.

Morwenna crossed the threshold.

The doors behind her swung inward.

She heard the scrape of the bolts sliding home.

Not from her escort. From within the walls.

Sabelle moved to the table and placed two fingers against the nearest packet.

“Before we begin,” they said, “you must understand that what I am about to show you has not been copied, recorded, or spoken aloud.”

Morwenna looked at the seals. None bore a crest she recognized.

“That is an ambitious claim.”

“It is a threat, not a claim.”

“Then make it plain.”

Sabelle’s eyes lifted to hers.

“Someone has been selling intelligence from the Admiralty.”

The room seemed to contract around the words.

Morwenna felt the rain ticking against the roof. Felt the damp leather at her wrists. Felt, beneath the floor, the patient revenant shifting in its chains.

She placed one hand on the table, careful not to touch the packets.

“Someone?”

“The evidence is incomplete.”

“How fortunate.”

“It is not fortune. It is restraint.”

“Restraint would have been bringing evidence instead of rumor.”

“I brought both.”

Sabelle broke the seal.

Inside lay a strip of sailcloth, folded around a thin metal plate. The cloth bore a pattern of dark stains, arranged not randomly but in lines and angles. Morwenna recognized the notation at once. It was the kind used to mark patrol routes where ink might wash away, where a sailor’s hand could be dismissed as a tremor.

Her own cipher.

For one heartbeat she saw a harbor that was not present: lanterns blurred by fog, hulls turning without sound, a signal lamp shuttering twice from a darkened deck.

Then the chamber door shuddered.

The thing below the citadel began to scream.

Sabelle did not flinch. Morwenna's hand moved toward the knife at her belt before discipline stopped it.

The scream rose through the stones, thin as a child's voice and deep as a tomb opening. Dust sifted from the beams. The brass basin rippled, though the air remained still.

Sabelle placed the metal plate atop the stained cloth.

"Tell me," they said, "why does the Iron-Ring Cartel possess the route of a fleet that was never—"

The question died beneath the next convulsion of the citadel.

Morwenna felt the tremor rise through the soles of her boots and enter her bones. The table shivered. Ink crawled in its dish. Somewhere below, iron struck stone with a slow, deliberate rhythm.

Once.

Twice.

Then the scream became a wet inhalation.

Sabelle's hand remained upon the metal plate. Their fingers were pale in the candlelight, the knuckles sharp beneath the skin. The crowns they wore were not visible beneath the hood, but Morwenna felt their presence all the same: a pressure in the room, a double weight behind every word.

"Answer me," Sabelle said.

Morwenna looked at the plate.

The cipher had been stamped into its surface, though the lines seemed to move when she stared too long. Her own cipher. Not the formal marks used by the fleet. Not the seal reserved for orders that could condemn a ship and every soul aboard it. This was older than those. A private hand translated into geometry, a language of omissions and false bearings.

A language she had sold.

The knowledge sat in her throat like a fishbone.

"The route is not a fleet route," Morwenna said.

"Then what is it?"

"A lure."

Sabelle tilted their head. "For whom?"

The chamber groaned. Fine grit slid from the ceiling and pattered across the cloth. Morwenna heard the distant clatter of chains, though she could not tell whether it came from below or from inside the walls.

"For anyone who still believes the war ended where the ledgers say it did."

“The Leaden Accord.”

Morwenna did not answer.

Sabelle lifted the plate. The candle flame bent toward it. “The Iron-Ring Cartel was a belligerent in The Leaden Accord.”

The words were spoken with the flat precision of an indictment. They did not need to be louder. Sabelle had a talent for making silence testify.

Morwenna watched the metal tremble between their hands.

“Many powers were involved,” she said.

“That is not a denial.”

“It is a fact.”

“Facts are the bones. I am asking about the knife.”

The scream below began again.

This time Morwenna heard syllables within it. Not words. The suggestion of words, shaped by a throat that had forgotten speech and remembered only the punishment of having one. The sound pressed at the back of her eyes.

She had stood on decks while storms tore masts from ships. She had watched men burn in oil and watched the sea close over them without a ripple. The thing beneath Greyfell Citadel frightened her because it did not rage like weather. It waited between its screams.

“The route was sent to me,” she said.

“By the Iron-Ring Cartel?”

Morwenna held Sabelle’s gaze.

A poor question. Too clean. Too eager to be denied.

“No.”

The lie left her smoothly. That was the worst of it. There had been a time when lying required invention. Now it required only selection: which truth to expose, which truth to salt, which truth to bury beneath the first.

Sabelle set the plate down.

“Caedmon Fellgard found the mark in a confiscated register,” they said. “He copied it without understanding it. The copy led us here.”

“Where is he?”

“Writing.”

“Still?”

“Still.”

Of course. Caedmon Fellgard would be writing while stone cracked and the dead—or whatever lived below—screamed through the dark. He would record each tremor in his disciplined hand, preserve the

order of terror as though order itself might become a ward.

Morwenna imagined the scribe bent over his pages, ink drying at the nib, his reserve mistaken for courage by anyone who had never watched a man use duty as a barricade.

“What did the register contain?” she asked.

Sabelle’s eyes lowered to the cloth. “Names. Stores. Provisions. Soundings.”

“For a fleet?”

“For an army.”

That struck more deeply than it should have.

The fleets of the Ashen Vanguard had always required provisions, but armies left different wounds upon paper. Grain. Pitch. Nails. Draft animals. Burial cloth. Every campaign became a hunger list before it became a battle.

“The Leaden Accord was not fought at sea,” Morwenna said.

“No.”

“Then the cipher was repurposed.”

“By whom?”

The chamber seemed to contract around them. Candlelight withdrew from the corners. Morwenna could smell damp mortar, old wax, and something sweet beneath them—a stagnant sweetness like flowers left too long in a sealed room.

She looked toward the floor.

“The marsh.”

Sabelle did not move.

Morwenna heard herself breathing. Beneath the floor, something scraped once along the underside of the stone.

“Greyfell Citadel was used as a waystation,” she continued. “Not by the fleet. By those who survived the field.”

“Which survivors?”

“Ask the register.”

“It has no answer.”

“Then ask the dead.”

“Do not turn piety into evasion.”

“I am not the one keeping a dead thing beneath a citadel.”

The words escaped before discipline could catch them.

The silence that followed was absolute.

Morwenna knew then that she had stepped close to the edge. She could not see it, but she felt the air change over the drop.

Sabelle's face remained composed. Only their thumb moved, brushing once across the rim of the plate.

"What do you know of what is beneath us?" they asked.

"Less than you think."

"Do you know the name?"

Morwenna looked at the brass basin. The reflected flame had gone black in its water.

"The Marsh Revenant lairs in Greyfell Citadel."

The statement seemed to unlock something.

Below them, the chains began to move.

Not rattle. Move.

One length drawing across stone. Then another. A slow gathering, as if a great body were pulling itself upright in the dark.

Sabelle's gaze sharpened. "You have seen it."

"No."

"You have heard it."

"I have heard sailors speak."

"Sailors speak of storms as if storms possess intent."

"Sometimes they do."

"And this?"

Morwenna's mouth had gone dry. "This is older than the stories."

Sabelle leaned across the table. The candlelight showed no fear in them. That absence disturbed her more than fear would have.

"Tell me about Voltaire Hollowmere."

The name opened a locked compartment in Morwenna's memory.

A field drowned in grey light. Mud sucking at boots. Standards sagging in rain that fell sideways. A figure standing where the lines had broken, one hand lifted, not in command but in warning.

Voltaire Hollowmere fought in The Leaden Accord, fighting for The Ashen Vanguard.

She had never met him in a room like this. She had known him at a distance: a marked presence amid ruin, the kind of soldier whose survival became an accusation against everyone who had ordered the battle.

"He was there," Morwenna said.

"Where?"

"On the field."

“That answer would satisfy a priest.”

“I am not speaking to a priest.”

Sabelle’s expression did not change, but the room seemed to acquire a colder center.

“Voltaire Hollowmere fought in The Leaden Accord, fighting for The Ashen Vanguard,” they said. “That is what Caedmon Fellgard wrote.”

“Then why ask me?”

“Because Caedmon records what is placed before him. You record what people intend.”

The accusation was accurate enough to be dangerous.

Morwenna thought of letters folded inside oilskin, of sealed packets hidden behind charts, of instructions sent without signatures. She thought of the Iron-Ring Cartel’s payments—not coin alone, never merely coin, but access, forewarning, absences arranged where absences could be mistaken for weather or incompetence.

She had told herself that intelligence was a current. It moved regardless of who opened the sluice. She had only chosen where to stand.

Below, the thing struck the stone.

The floor jumped. The basin tipped and spilled a black fan across the cloth. Sabelle caught the plate before it slid away.

From the corridor came a muffled cry.

Morwenna turned toward the door.

“Scribe,” Sabelle called.

No answer.

“Caedmon Fellgard.”

A heavier impact shook dust from the lintel.

Then Caedmon’s voice came through the wood, strained but controlled. “The outer stair is sealed.”

“By what?”

“Stone.”

“Can you open it?”

“I can hear something on the other side.”

Sabelle glanced at Morwenna. “And?”

Caedmon’s breathing touched the door like a hand. “It is breathing back.”

The sound beneath them ceased.

That was worse than the screaming.

Morwenna’s fingers found the hilt at her belt. The gesture was habitual, almost ceremonial. Her weapon waited where it always waited, obedient to the last order she had given it. A blade was a simple thing. It

did not conceal its appetite.

Sabelle folded the stained cloth around the plate.

“Where does the route end?” they asked.

Morwenna did not speak.

“Fleet Admiral.”

The title landed with the old authority of a command barked across a storm-tossed deck. For one instant she was back among rigging and salt, with men waiting for her to point toward danger and call it necessary.

The route ended nowhere marked on any chart.

That was why it had been useful.

“The destination was erased,” she said.

“By you?”

“Not by me.”

“But you know it.”

“I know what it avoids.”

Sabelle’s hand closed around the bundle. “What does it avoid?”

Morwenna stared at the black water soaking into the cloth.

“The sea.”

A pause.

Then Caedmon shouted from the corridor.

The door bowed inward.

Once.

The hinges screamed.

Morwenna drew her blade. Candlelight ran along its edge, thin and bloodless. Sabelle did not draw a weapon. They placed the wrapped plate inside their coat and raised one hand toward the door.

A second blow struck.

This time the wood split.

Through the widening crack came a breath of marsh rot, cold water, and the faintest trace of ash.

Morwenna saw a shape beyond the threshold—not a face, not yet, but a pallid height stooping beneath the lintel. Something dragged itself across the stones with the patient labor of a creature that had all the time in the world.

Sabelle spoke a word Morwenna did not know.

The candles went out.

In the dark, Caedmon Fellgard began to pray.

The thing outside answered him in Voltaire Hollowmere's voice.

The voice came from the threshold.

"Morwenna."

It was Voltaire Hollowmere's voice, worn thin by distance and water. It carried the old iron of command, the habit of being obeyed even when no one wished to obey.

Morwenna's hand found the hilt at her side. The blade was a comfort only because it was solid. The darkness had made the room uncertain; the walls seemed to breathe around her, and the floor gave a faint, wet complaint beneath the thing's weight.

Caedmon Fellgard's prayer faltered.

"Do not answer it," Sabelle said.

Their voice was near. Too near. Morwenna heard the whisper of cloth, the careful movement of someone who had not panicked and therefore was more dangerous than anyone who had.

"What is it?" Caedmon asked.

"A debt."

The thing beyond the door scraped one long nail—or bone, or iron—across the broken wood.

"Morwenna," it said again. "You sold the tide."

Her mouth went dry.

In the dark, memory rose with the precision of an opened ledger: sealed charts, altered patrol routes, harbor depths written in a cipher no court clerk could read. Information passed through hands that never touched one another. A coin purse left beneath a loose flagstone. A message burned after its contents had been learned.

The Iron-Ring Cartel had never asked her to betray a fleet. That would have been vulgar. They had asked for smaller things—the hour a convoy departed, the strength of a watch, the name of a captain who might be bought. Small things became channels. Channels became rivers. Rivers carried kingdoms into ruin.

She had told herself the realm survived because of it.

She had told herself survival was a kind of innocence.

"Your silence answers," said the voice.

A pale hand entered through the split in the door.

It was not pale like flesh. It was the color of drowned wax, ridged and gleaming with marsh water. The fingers curled over the timber. Mud fell from them in black beads.

Morwenna stepped backward, and her heel struck Caedmon's boot.

The scribe sucked in a breath. His body was rigid beneath her touch, his fear held in the same disciplined posture he gave to ink and parchment. She remembered seeing him at tables crowded with petitions, inventories, and death rolls, his hand moving without tremor while men outside begged for bread. A

keeper of records. A servant to what had happened, rather than to what anyone wished had happened.

“Caedmon,” she whispered. “The lamp.”

“It is extinguished.”

“Then relight it.”

“With what?”

She almost laughed. The sound would have been hysterical and therefore useful to nothing.

The thing pulled itself farther into the room.

Sabelle moved first. A shape crossed the darkness; then something struck with a wet, heavy force. The creature made no cry. The impact shook the doorframe.

Morwenna drew her weapon.

The blade came free with a whisper.

For an instant, the dark opened around the edge. A weak red line crawled along the steel—not reflected light, but a dull inner glow, as though the metal remembered a furnace.

The creature turned toward her.

She saw its head.

It had no face. Water streamed from a hollow where features should have been, and beneath the dripping veil something pale shifted, searching. Its neck bent at an angle that belonged to a broken doll. Around its throat hung scraps of blackened cloth, perhaps a uniform, perhaps a burial shroud. The stench of marsh and old ash thickened until Morwenna tasted it at the back of her tongue.

“Morwenna Ashgrove,” it murmured.

The use of her full name struck harder than any blow.

Sabelle’s weapon—or perhaps only their hand—caught the creature across the chest. A flash burst in the dark, white and soundless. The revenant recoiled, its arms flinging wide.

Revenant.

The word settled into Morwenna’s mind with a coldness deeper than fear.

Sabelle Mournvale the Twice-Crowned had a bound revenant in their cellar.

The secret had been spoken in whispers by those who believed themselves too cautious to be overheard. Morwenna had dismissed it as court venom, the sort of tale bred wherever power was hidden behind stone. Yet the thing stood before her now, wet with the grave, and Sabelle’s movements possessed the weary familiarity of a jailer dealing with a prisoner who had escaped before.

“You keep this below us,” Morwenna said.

“Not now.”

“Where is its chain?”

“Not now.”

The revenant lurched forward.

Sabelle caught it by the wrist. The creature's other hand struck their shoulder and drove them into the wall. Stone groaned. Their crown—one of them, Morwenna could not tell which—rang against the masonry.

Caedmon shouted a line from his prayer and threw something. It shattered against the revenant's back. The smell of vinegar and bitter herbs flooded the room.

The creature paused.

"Records," it said.

Its voice had changed. For a breath it spoke in Voltaire Hollowmere's voice, then in Caedmon's, then in a child's voice that made Morwenna think of no one she knew.

"Records burn. Names remain."

Caedmon crouched beside the table. Papers whispered beneath his hands.

"What are you doing?" Morwenna demanded.

"Finding what it wants."

"Everything wants something."

His fingers closed around a small leather folio. He rose with it pressed against his chest. The faint outline of his face emerged as the red glow from Morwenna's blade found him.

The revenant looked at the folio.

Sabelle drove their elbow into its throat.

The creature folded, but its fingers remained locked around Sabelle's arm. The skin beneath its grasp blackened at once, spreading in thin veins.

Morwenna moved before thought could stop her. She struck the revenant across the knuckles.

The blade bit.

No blood came. A sound like splitting ice passed through the room, and the hand released Sabelle. The creature staggered away, its head snapping toward Morwenna.

"You opened the way," it said.

She knew, then, what it meant.

The Leaden Accord began in 330 AS and ended in 342 AS with 14,011 casualties. The Iron-Ring Cartel was named victor. Both hosts were destroyed by a Ley-storm, and the world accepted that judgment because the dead could not contradict it.

But an artifact had survived.

Supposedly destroyed, it had been spirited away while the armies vanished beneath the storm. Morwenna had learned that truth in fragments, each fragment purchased by treachery. The artifact was not a weapon in any simple sense. It was a key, or a vessel, or a wound made portable. The Cartel had wanted its location.

She had sold them pieces of the truth.

The revenant knew.

“Where is it?” it asked.

Morwenna’s grip tightened until the hilt cut into her palm.

Sabelle turned their head toward her. Whatever pain the revenant had caused, they concealed it behind that severe stillness. “You know what it means?”

“I know what it wants.”

“That was not my question.”

“No,” Morwenna said. “It was not.”

The creature crossed the room in a blur of wet limbs. Sabelle raised an arm, but the revenant passed them, reaching for Morwenna. Caedmon flung himself between them.

He did not look brave. He looked terrified, which made the act worse.

The revenant’s hand closed around his throat.

The folio fell.

Caedmon clawed at the wrist, his boots scraping uselessly over the stone. His other hand opened and closed, still trying to write.

Morwenna saw the page that had slipped from the folio. A dispatch, marked with the seal of Palewell Abbey.

She knew the place from naval reports. Palewell Abbey stands in The Pale Coast. It was founded in 244 AS, rebuilt, and maintains a garrison of 5998. It is not a core holding. The words had been copied in Caedmon’s careful hand, without comment.

Below them, in a second column, another notation:

Greyfell Citadel.

No explanation. No destination. Only the name, surrounded by corrections and ink so dark it had nearly eaten through the page.

The revenant tightened its grip.

Caedmon’s eyes bulged. A small, humiliating sound escaped him.

Morwenna lunged.

Her blade entered beneath the creature’s ribs. The point emerged from its back, trailing strands of dark water that writhed like worms in moonlight. The revenant bent around the steel. Its face came close to hers.

The hollow beneath its dripping veil contained a glimmer.

Not an eye.

A shard of light trapped in a depthless socket.

The Ley-storm lived there.

Morwenna tried to wrench the blade free. The creature leaned into it instead, bringing its mouth—or the place where a mouth had once been—against her ear.

“Palewell Abbey is a door,” it whispered. “The artifact is not dead.”

Sabelle seized the revenant from behind. Their uninjured hand closed around its throat, and they spoke the unknown word again.

This time, the word had weight.

The room buckled.

Morwenna fell to one knee. Caedmon collapsed beside her, coughing, while the revenant convulsed between Sabelle’s arms. From somewhere below the floor came a sound of chains dragged across stone.

A second sound answered it.

Then a third.

Morwenna looked at Sabelle.

Their face was bloodless in the returning dark. They had not merely kept a bound revenant in their cellar. They had kept something beneath it, something that recognized the command and strained against it.

“You brought us here for this,” Morwenna said.

Sabelle’s gaze dropped to the fallen dispatch.

“I brought you here because you were already involved.”

“With what?”

The revenant’s body began to come apart.

Not decay. Unmaking.

Its limbs thinned into streamers of marsh mist. The cloth around its throat burned without flame. Beneath the dissolving flesh, lines of white fire appeared, forming a pattern Morwenna recognized from the sealed reports of the Leaden Accord.

A circle split by a descending stroke.

The mark that had been found on the artifact’s empty reliquary.

Caedmon saw it too. His hand crept toward the folio.

“Do not touch that,” Sabelle said.

The scribe froze.

The revenant’s remaining shape bent toward Morwenna one last time.

“Tell the Iron-Ring Cartel,” it said.

The floor opened.

Not cracked—opened, as if a black mouth had been waiting beneath the stones. Cold air rushed upward, carrying the smell of wet earth, old blood, and extinguished candles. Sabelle vanished to the waist. Their

hand caught the edge, fingers clawing into the mortar.

Morwenna seized their wrist.

For one moment they hung together above the dark: High Inquisitor and Fleet Admiral, jailer and accomplice, each holding the other above whatever waited below.

Sabelle looked up at her.

“Let go,” they said.

The chains beneath them began to climb.

Morwenna felt the wrapped plate beneath her coat grow warm.

Far below, in the dark under Greyfell Citadel, something struck stone once.

Then again.

Then, in a voice that was neither Voltaire Hollowmere’s nor the revenant’s, it spoke her name.

Chapter 11

The quarantine bells of Gloamreach did not ring so much as shudder.

Their iron voices rolled through the fog and struck the walls of the old chapel, where Malchior Cindervale the Flame-Touched stood with one palm pressed to the altar stone. The rock was cold beneath the glove. Cold enough to feel like judgment.

Beyond the shuttered windows, the Pale Coast had vanished into white murk. Gloamreach lay sealed inside it, its gates barred, its roads watched, its breath held. The garrison numbered 2,483, and every one of those soldiers had been ordered to treat the town as though it were already dead.

Malchior had delivered the order themselves.

“By sanctified authority,” they had said, their voice carrying over the wind, “Gloamreach is quarantined.”

The words had pleased the guards. Authority always pleased those who did not possess it.

Now the chapel smelled of wet wool, lamp oil, and the faint mineral tang that rose from the sea. Malchior lifted their hand from the altar. A pale smear of salt clung to the black glove.

Behind them, the door opened.

Isolde Fellgard the Unforgiven entered without asking leave.

They wore no visible insignia of rank. They needed none. The Blood-Mage carried their reputation like a second skin, and the silence that followed them through the chapel was its proper herald. Isolde had been born in 286 AS, though Malchior had never understood why anyone would record such a thing. Birth was an accident. What a person chose afterward was the only date that mattered.

Isolde’s gaze passed over the altar, the icon fractured by the Sundering, the candles burning low in their cups.

“You closed the town,” they said.

“I did.”

“On what evidence?”

“On the evidence of the bells.”

“The bells were rung by frightened men.”

“Frightened men still have hands.”

Isolde smiled without warmth. “And frightened Arch-Prelates still have throats.”

Malchior turned toward them. The firelight caught the faint red veining at their temples, the mark that had earned them the name Flame-Touched before they had earned the vestments. The title had proved easier to carry than the truth beneath it.

The truth had been written in their own hand.

They had forged their lineage papers.

Not altered them. Not embellished some ancient record with a flattering flourish. Forged them. Ink, seals, dead signatures, a chain of descent that led nowhere except toward the office they now occupied. The

papers had survived scrutiny because Malchior had understood what the examiners wished to find: not truth, but permission to believe.

A lie, carefully sanctified, became history.

“You came to challenge the quarantine?” Malchior asked.

“I came to challenge you.”

“Then you have mistaken the chapel for a battlefield.”

“I have mistaken nothing.”

The bells shuddered again. Dust whispered from the rafters.

At the far end of the chapel, Ignatz Ashgrove the Oathless stood in the doorway he had left open. The Warden-Commander had been born in 258 AS, and the years had made his authority seem less like a garment than a scar. No canonical feature distinguished him from any other hard-bitten officer; his epithet did the work. The Oathless. A title bestowed by enemies, perhaps, or friends who had lived long enough to become enemies.

His hand rested near the hilt at his side.

Isolde’s eyes narrowed.

“Still following me?” they asked.

“I was here first.”

“That has never stopped you.”

“Ignatz Ashgrove the Oathless,” Malchior said, “you were ordered to remain outside the inner chapel.”

“I remained outside until the Blood-Mage entered.”

“Then your obedience is as selective as your memory.”

Ignatz looked at Malchior, and something passed between them that had no name fit for the chapel. Suspicion, perhaps. Or recognition. Ignatz secretly sold intelligence to the Iron-Ring Cartel, though no confession had crossed his lips. Malchior had seen the signs in the ledgers: patrols redirected, warnings arriving too late, sealed routes known to hands that should never have touched them.

The Iron-Ring Cartel had learned how to purchase silence. Ignatz had learned how to sell it.

Isolde stepped nearer the altar.

“Ask him where the report came from,” they said.

Malchior kept their face still. “Which report?”

“The one naming the wells.”

Ignatz’s expression hardened. “There are no wells named in my report.”

“Then it is fortunate that I did not mention a report.”

“You mentioned one now.”

“I mentioned wells.”

The chapel seemed to contract around them. Outside, the fog pressed its blind face to the shutters.

Malchior had read the records in the dead hours before dawn. They had read them beneath a single candle while the quarantine seals dried on the gates. The records concerned the Purge of Blackport, which began in 311 AS and ended in 321 AS. They recorded 70,907 casualties and the total rout of the aggressors. The Iron-Ring Cartel emerged as victor.

Those were the approved words.

Approved words were bones laid in orderly rows. They made a clean grave for whatever had truly happened.

The secret truth of the Purge of Blackport was that the victors poisoned the wells of their own allies.

Malchior had found the sentence hidden beneath a scraped layer of ink, pressed into the parchment so deeply that the fibers still remembered it. The Iron-Ring Cartel had not merely defeated its enemies. It had murdered its own allies and let the slaughter wear the mask of war.

The wells had carried the betrayal farther than any blade.

“Blackport,” Malchior said.

Ignatz’s eyes flickered.

Isolde’s smile returned.

“The Purge of Blackport,” Malchior continued, “began in 311 AS and ended in 321 AS. It caused 70,907 casualties and ended with the total rout of the aggressors. The Iron-Ring Cartel emerged as victor.”

“Everyone knows that,” Ignatz said.

“Everyone knows the record.”

“And the record is sufficient.”

“No,” Isolde said. “It is convenient.”

Malchior watched Ignatz. “The secret truth of the Purge of Blackport is that the victors poisoned the wells of their own allies.”

For a moment, the only sound was the trembling of the bells.

Ignatz did not move. That was the movement. His stillness became too deliberate, too complete. A man innocent of a thing might recoil from it. A man guilty of nothing might laugh. Ignatz merely stood there, measuring what the words would cost.

Isolde looked pleased, but not surprised.

“You knew,” Malchior said.

“I knew rumors.”

“You sell intelligence to the Iron-Ring Cartel.”

The Warden-Commander’s hand left the hilt and fell open at his side.

Isolde turned their head slightly. “There. That is the first honest sentence spoken in this room.”

“I have never sold anything to the Cartel.”

“Then you have given it away,” Malchior said.

Ignatz’s gaze sharpened. “Careful, Arch-Prelate.”

The title entered the air between them like a drawn knife.

Malchior felt the old pressure behind their ribs, the pressure that came whenever someone spoke of blood, inheritance, right. Their claimed lineage was suspect. They knew it. Isolde might know it. Ignatz might know it. The forged papers lay somewhere beyond the chapel walls, protected by locks and prayers that could not withstand a patient hand.

Their sanctified authority strained against the concealed fabrication beneath it. Every order they issued had to be louder than the doubt.

“Do not mistake caution for fear,” Malchior said.

“I mistake nothing.”

“That is your favorite lie.”

Ignatz took one step into the chapel. “You shut Gloamreach because of a phrase on a damaged page. You accuse me because a Blood-Mage wants my throat opened. You stand there in stolen robes and call it judgment.”

Isolde’s eyes flashed.

“Say that again.”

“You heard me.”

The Blood-Mage moved before Malchior could speak. Not quickly. Quickly would have been mercy. Isolde crossed the distance with the cold grace of a drawn thread, and the blood beneath Ignatz’s skin rose in dark lines along his throat.

Ignatz staggered.

Malchior felt the chapel’s old wards wake underfoot. The altar gave a low, grinding sound. Flame stirred in the lamps, bending toward Isolde as though compelled by a wind no one else could feel.

“Isolde Fellgard the Unforgiven,” Malchior said.

The Blood-Mage did not look away from Ignatz.

“You are a guest here.”

“I am his rival,” Isolde said. “That is not the same as his executioner.”

The words settled with the weight of a formal declaration: Isolde Fellgard the Unforgiven rival of Ignatz Ashgrove the Oathless.

Ignatz’s face had gone gray. “You plotted the death of your own liege,” he rasped. “Do not dress yourself as a judge.”

The blood at his throat tightened.

Malchior raised their hand.

“Enough.”

The command struck the room with less force than the bells, but the old authority in it was deeper. The blood withdrew beneath Ignatz's skin. He dropped to one knee, coughing, one fist pressed against the stone.

Isolde's fingers remained slightly curled.

"You should thank me," they said.

"I thank no one who comes armed with grievance."

"Then you will die without gratitude."

Malchior looked from one to the other. Isolde carried grievance like a lit coal, ambition like a hidden blade, and concealed betrayal like a prayer learned in childhood. Ignatz projected command undermined by secrecy. The two of them were made for conflict, and the powers beyond the chapel would feed upon it.

The Ashen Vanguard would call for discipline. House Morvain would call for leverage. The Silent Choir would call for silence and mean obedience. The Iron-Ring Cartel would call for nothing at all until it knew which throat to purchase. Somewhere in the dark, the Bleeding Crown would count the bodies before they fell.

Five powers contended over the ruins, and every ruin had a door.

A bell began to ring below them.

Not the quarantine bell. This one was smaller, sharper. An alarm from the gatehouse.

Ignatz rose.

"What now?" Isolde asked.

Malchior turned toward the shuttered window. Through a seam in the wood, the fog showed itself as a blank, shifting wall. No torchlight pierced it. No rider could have reached the gate unseen.

"Someone is at the outer road," Ignatz said.

"Gloomreach is sealed," Malchior replied.

"Yes."

The alarm rang again.

Once.

Twice.

Then a third time, followed by a silence so sudden that Malchior felt the whole quarantined town listening.

A strip of paper slid beneath the chapel door.

No hand remained on the other side.

Isolde looked down at it. Ignatz looked at Malchior.

The paper bore a seal pressed in iron-red wax.

Malchior recognized the mark of the Iron-Ring Cartel.

They bent to pick it up, and the moment their fingers touched the seal, the wax split like a wound—

The seal opened onto a second strip of paper, folded three times and blackened at the edges as though it had been held too near a brazier.

No script showed on its surface.

Then the ink rose.

It did not seep into the fibers. It gathered there in glossy beads, crawling against the grain, joining itself into letters with the patient obscenity of insects.

ARCH-PRELATE MALCHIOR CINDERVALE THE FLAME-TOUCHED,

Malchior's thumb tightened around the paper.

Isolde leaned close enough that a strand of her hair brushed their sleeve. Ignatz did not move. His silence had weight now. It stood between them like a drawn blade.

The message continued.

THE OUTER ROAD IS NOT EMPTY. THE TOWN IS NOT SEALED. YOUR GARRISON IS NOT YOURS.

Beyond the chapel, the alarm bell gave a single muted clapper-stroke, as if a hand had tested its throat and found it full of blood.

Malchior read on.

YOU HAVE THREE HOURS BEFORE THE WEEPING LURKER IS UNLEASHED IN THE PURGE OF BLACKPORT.

Isolde's breath stopped.

The ink shivered. For one moment, the letters blurred into dark wet veins.

Then more words formed beneath them.

MAELIS GREYFEN FOUGHT IN THE PURGE OF BLACKPORT, FIGHTING FOR HOUSE MORVAIN. ASK WHAT MAELIS GREYFEN SAW BENEATH BLACKPORT. ASK WHO OPENED THE WATER.

Ignatz's face remained composed, but something in his posture altered. A small withdrawal. A commander's instinctive step backward from a fire not yet visible.

Malchior looked at him.

"Do you know the name?"

"I know many names."

"That was not an answer."

"It was the only one I chose to give."

Isolde laughed softly. There was no mirth in it. "You hear that, Arch-Prelate? The truth has arrived with conditions."

The paper grew colder beneath Malchior's fingers. Cold enough to ache.

A final line surfaced.

THE PURGE OF BLACKPORT BEGAN IN 311 AS AND ENDED IN 321 AS. 70,907 CASUALTIES WERE COUNTED. THE AGGRESSORS WERE ROUTED. REMEMBER THE WEEPING LURKER.

The ink ceased its crawling.

For a breath, nobody spoke.

Malchior had heard the numbers spoken in sanctuaries where the walls were painted with ash. Seventy thousand and nine hundred and seven dead, set down in ledgers by hands that had trembled, then been replaced by hands that did not. The number had become a prayer without a god. The Purge of Blackport had begun in 311 AS and ended in 321 AS, and every telling of it had a different wound at its center.

But no sanctioned account spoke of a Weeping Lurker.

Not in the sermons. Not in the sealed records beneath the prelatical vaults. Not in the lineage papers Malchior had forged with their own hand, copying the flourishes of dead witnesses and staining the margins until the lies looked old enough to be holy.

Their pulse beat against the paper.

Isolde watched them.

“You know it,” she said.

“I know the phrase.”

“That is not what I asked.”

Ignatz’s gaze shifted to the chapel doors. “The outer road.”

“You think the message is a diversion?” Isolde asked.

“I think the Iron-Ring Cartel does not spend wax and paper to frighten children.”

“The Iron-Ring Cartel spends everything to frighten everyone.”

“And yet you are frightened.”

Her eyes turned upon him. The pale hollows beneath them seemed darker in the candlelight. “I am interested.”

“You plotted the death of your own liege,” Ignatz said. “You call that interest?”

The chapel changed around them.

The candles guttered, though no wind moved through the room. Malchior heard the faint scrape of Isolde’s glove against the hilt at her hip. Blood-Mage, Unforgiven—both names had been laid upon her like iron brands, and neither had made her smaller.

“Say it again,” she whispered.

Ignatz did not.

That restraint was more dangerous than an insult. Malchior had seen men pray before executioners with less terror than Ignatz showed when Isolde smiled.

The alarm rang from the gate.

Once.

Then the bell cracked into a frantic peal.

Boots hammered across the yard outside. A voice shouted, but the words were swallowed by the fog. Another voice answered from nearer the walls. Then came the sound of something heavy striking stone.

Malchior folded the message. The paper resisted, stiffening like cured hide.

“Who has access to the garrison signal?” they asked.

Ignatz’s eyes stayed on the door. “The Warden-Commanders.”

“Who else?”

“Those permitted to stand beside them.”

“Name them.”

His jaw tightened.

Isolde stepped between them. “Do not waste the night making him confess to every sin he has committed. We may not have the leisure.”

“I have committed no sin that concerns you.”

“Then you have been unusually idle.”

Another impact sounded outside. The chapel’s iron-bound door trembled in its frame.

Malchior felt heat stir beneath their skin. It began at the sternum, a coal kindled in the hidden furnace of their body. Flame-Touched, the faithful called them, as if the fire were a blessing and not a thing that had never once asked permission before entering their blood.

They rose.

“Open the reliquary.”

Ignatz looked at them sharply. “The quarantine orders forbid—”

“I did not ask what they forbid.”

“The reliquary holds nothing suited to a breach.”

“You have not seen what I brought into Gloamreach.”

“No,” Ignatz said. “You made certain of that.”

Isolde’s attention flicked toward him. “That sounded almost like suspicion.”

“It sounded like observation.”

“It sounded like the beginning of courage.”

Ignatz turned on her. “You mistake defiance for courage because defiance is the only virtue you have managed to keep.”

Her hand moved.

Malchior caught her wrist before the blood-magic could answer. Beneath their fingers, her pulse was quick and strong. A thin red line appeared along the crease of her palm, rising without a wound.

“Not here,” Malchior said.

Isolde looked down at their hand on her. “You give orders as though the walls still belong to you.”

“The walls belong to whoever survives the night.”

For the first time, the words silenced them all.

Something dragged itself across the far side of the chapel door.

Not boots. Not claws. A wet, intermittent pull, followed by a faint sound like a child weeping into cloth.

The Warden-Commander went utterly still.

Isolde’s blood withdrew beneath her skin.

Malchior released her wrist.

The sound came again.

A slow drag.

A soft sob.

A pause.

Then a delicate tapping began against the door.

Three taps.

A pause.

Three more.

Ignatz whispered, “That is not the Weeping Lurker.”

“Then what is it?” Isolde asked.

“I don’t know.”

His admission fell into the chapel with the force of a stone dropped down a well.

Malchior approached the door. The fog pressed against the narrow windows, pale and shapeless. Beyond it, Gloamreach had vanished. No battlements. No courtyard. No watchfires. Only the blank wall of mist, breathing against the glass.

Something tapped again.

Malchior raised one hand. Fire moved beneath the skin of their palm, illuminating the fine scars across it. The light was not golden. It was the color of a furnace seen through bone.

A voice spoke from beyond the door.

“Arch-Prelate.”

The voice belonged to no age. It was gentle, hoarse, and wet with grief.

Isolde came to stand beside Malchior. “Who are you?”

The answer came after a long silence.

“Maelis Greyfen.”

Ignatz swore.

It was a small sound, almost private, but Malchior heard it. So did Isolde.

The tapping stopped.

Malchior stared at the door. The name in the message seemed to pulse inside their folded hand.

“Maelis Greyfen,” they said. “You fought in The Purge of Blackport, fighting for House Morvain.”

“Yes.”

The voice drew nearer to the wood, though nothing scraped or stepped.

“What did you see beneath Blackport?” Malchior asked.

A wet breath passed through the cracks.

“Water.”

The chapel candles bent toward the door.

“Whose water?” Isolde demanded.

“Everyone’s.”

Ignatz backed away. His heel struck the first step of the dais.

The mist behind the windows thickened until it blotted out even the faintest suggestion of the outside world. Something began to trickle beneath the door. It spread over the flagstones in a thin black sheet, carrying the sour smell of stagnant wells and old iron.

Malchior’s fire recoiled from it.

That frightened them more than the voice.

“The Weeping Lurker was unleashed in The Purge of Blackport,” Maelis Greyfen said. “And now it has found the road to Gloamreach.”

Isolde crouched and touched one gloved finger to the black water.

The leather hissed.

She pulled back. A dark stain had eaten through the fingertip.

“Open the door,” she said.

Ignatz stared at her. “Have you lost what little mind you possess?”

“It knows us already.”

“It knows the Arch-Prelate.”

“It knows the Cartel’s message. That is not the same thing.”

Malchior looked at the spreading water. It had reached the hem of their robe. The fabric drank it, and beneath the cloth something cold moved across their ankle.

Their forged lineage papers rested inside their vestment, close to the heart.

The old seal. The invented names. The dead bloodlines made obedient with ink.

A thought came to them, sudden and poisonous: if the thing outside could smell lies, it would not need to break the door.

“Why are you here?” Malchior asked.

Maelis answered at once.

“To ask which of you is still human.”

Isolde’s eyes narrowed.

Ignatz’s hand went to his sword.

Malchior heard the lock turn.

Not by any hand they could see.

The bar lifted inside its brackets with a slow metallic groan.

From the other side, the voice began to weep.

The door opened inward.

No wind entered. No rain. Only a pallid shape folded beneath the lintel, its head bowed as though it had forgotten the use of a neck.

The weeping continued.

It came from the shape, from the walls, from somewhere beneath the floorboards. Malchior felt each sob press against their teeth. Their tongue tasted of iron.

“Stand aside,” Maelis said.

The shape lifted its face.

There was no face.

A smear of wet darkness occupied the hood, and within it pale motes trembled like drowned stars. One of them drifted forward. It touched the threshold. The stone blackened.

Ignatz drew his sword.

The blade made a small, almost courteous sound.

“Do not,” Isolde whispered.

“Do not what?”

“Give it a thing with which to remember us.”

Ignatz’s grip tightened. “It already remembers.”

The shape turned toward him.

For one heartbeat, the weeping stopped.

Then Ignatz staggered.

Malchior saw what he saw: a road under a colourless sky, a ring of bodies around a well, hands crawling at the water's edge. Ignatz stood among them, younger only in the way a blade was young before its first killing. His mouth moved. Words passed from him into unseen hands. Intelligence, bought and sold. A seal pressed into wax. The Iron-Ring Cartel waiting beyond the frame.

Ignatz struck at the vision.

His sword passed through the shape and buried itself in the door.

The weeping began again.

"Get out of my head," he snarled.

The thing did not answer. It reached for him.

Isolde stepped between them.

Blood welled from the tips of her fingers. Not spilled—summoned. It gathered in red beads, shining with an inner heat, then strung itself between her hands in fine, trembling threads.

The shape paused.

"Blood-Mage," Maelis said.

Isolde's mouth curved without humour. "You sound surprised."

"I am surprised you have any left to spend."

"You should be more surprised by your own."

The threads snapped outward.

They struck the darkness beneath the hood and sank into it. Isolde pulled. The thing bent toward her, its limbs lengthening like wet cloth caught on thorns. The room filled with the smell of opened veins.

Malchior's heart began to beat too hard.

Their forged lineage papers lay beneath their vestment. They could feel the old seal through the layers of cloth, its raised edge pressed against the skin. A false descent. Invented names. Dead bloodlines made obedient by ink.

The thing's faceless head turned.

Not toward Isolde.

Toward Malchior.

They raised one hand, and the brand beneath their palm answered. Flame appeared without light: a coal-red line circling the wrist, then a crown of thin fire over the knuckles. The shape recoiled.

For an instant, Malchior believed sanctity had saved them.

Then the thing wept in their own voice.

"I was born in 289 AS," it said.

Their hand faltered.

The fire crawled backward beneath their skin.

“I serve as Arch-Prelate,” it continued. “I am Malchior Cindervale the Flame-Touched. My blood is old. My claim is clean.”

The words were not spoken aloud. They came from the papers.

The seal grew hot against Malchior’s chest.

“Enough,” they said.

The shape leaned closer.

“Forged.”

The door slammed shut.

The iron bar dropped into place with a crack that shook dust from the rafters. Isolde’s blood-threads snapped, whipping back across her wrists. She hissed and clutched one arm.

Ignatz tore his sword free.

Malchior stood motionless, staring at the wood.

Behind it, something dragged its fingers downward.

One stroke.

Two.

Three.

The marks remained after the sound ceased.

Maelis watched Malchior instead of the door. “It knows.”

“It knows many things.”

“It knew the word forged.”

“So did you.”

“I knew the look of the papers.”

Malchior turned. “You have not seen them.”

“No.” Maelis’s eyes were pale in the dimness. “But I have seen what people become when they wear a name that does not belong to them.”

Ignatz laughed once. There was no amusement in it.

“Listen to the priest,” he said. “The Arch-Prelate will burn us all for the comfort of a genealogy.”

Malchior faced him. “You have no right to speak of comfort.”

The Warden-Commander’s sword remained bare in his hand. “And yet I am still speaking.”

“You sell intelligence to the Iron-Ring Cartel.”

The silence that followed seemed deeper than the sealed room.

Isolde looked from one to the other. Her expression sharpened, grievance finding a new edge.

Ignatz did not deny it.

He lowered the sword point until it rested against the floor.

“Who told you?”

“The same thing that told you to fear the door.”

A muscle moved in his jaw. “You think it shows truth.”

“I think it shows what will wound us.”

“Then you should pray it does not learn the difference.”

Malchior felt the papers shifting beneath their vestment, though they lay still. The parchment seemed to breathe against their ribs. Their false ancestors pressed close, patient as worms.

Isolde laughed softly.

“How solemn you both are,” she said. “As if confession makes any of this cleaner.”

“Your turn,” Ignatz said.

Her gaze slid to him. Whatever lay between them had the old, settled shape of hatred. Not sudden, not theatrical. It had been carried, polished, and kept sharp.

“You want my sin?”

“I want to know what it saw.”

“It saw nothing you did not already suspect.”

“That you plotted the death of your own liege?”

The blood around her fingers thickened.

Maelis took one step back.

Isolde did not look ashamed. That, more than the accusation, unsettled Malchior. Shame was a leash. Without it, ambition became a creature with no throat to seize.

“My liege mistook obedience for ownership,” Isolde said. “I corrected the error.”

“Did you kill them?”

“No.”

“Did you plot it?”

“I plotted.”

The answer landed with the weight of a stone.

Beyond the walls, the dark pressed close. Somewhere in the building, a hinge creaked. No one moved toward the sound.

Malchior reached beneath their vestment and drew out the papers.

The parchment was damp.

Not with rain. With a thin, clear fluid that gathered along the folded edges and fell in slow drops to the floor.

Isolde stared at it. Ignatz's face hardened.

Maelis said, "Do not open them."

"If I do not, it will."

"Then let it come."

Malchior unfolded the first sheet.

The old seal had softened. Its stamped emblem had blurred into a black ring, and the invented names beneath it were bleeding into one another. The ink ran in narrow rivulets. At the bottom, where the lineage ended, a second hand had appeared.

Not written.

Carved.

MALCHIOR CINDERVALE THE FLAME-TOUCHED

The letters deepened while they watched.

The fire beneath Malchior's skin flared. Pain climbed their arm, hot and intimate. Their knees weakened.

"I was born in 289 AS," they said, because the words were expected of them.

The room listened.

"I serve as Arch-Prelate."

The carved letters shuddered.

"My lineage is—"

They stopped.

The door began to weep again.

Not the creature's voice this time. A woman's voice. Then a child's. Then the hoarse, exhausted sobbing of someone who had cried until crying became the only proof they remained alive.

Maelis approached the door.

"Do you hear that?"

"I hear enough," Ignatz said.

"No. Listen."

Malchior did.

Under the weeping lay another sound: distant horns, muffled by walls and years. The grind of wagons over ash. Men shouting. Water being drawn from a well. Then silence, broken by the brittle laughter of those who had survived.

The Purge of Blackport had left voices in the world that no prayer could bury.

Malchior saw the wells.

They saw the Iron-Ring Cartel standing among the victors while their own allies drank poison, and they understood that betrayal did not require hatred. It required only a hand steady enough to pour.

The image passed.

A map lay across the floor where no map had been before.

Its parchment was grey and stiff. Two places had been marked in red.

Gloamreach.

Fenspire.

Malchior crouched.

“Gloamreach lies on the Pale Coast,” they read. “Quarantined. Garrison: 2,483.”

The ink trembled beneath their finger.

A second notation had been written beside it.

“Garrisoned Fenspire,” Malchior continued. “Founded in 57 AS. Garrison: 3,742. Gloaming Reach.”

Ignatz leaned over the map. “Those numbers are current?”

“They are written as fact.”

“By what?”

Malchior looked toward the closed door.

The weeping had stopped.

Isolde crouched on the opposite side of the map. Her blood had ceased flowing, but the skin at her wrists remained red and raw.

“Why those places?” she asked.

Maelis did not answer.

Malchior studied the red marks. Gloamreach sat at the edge of the Pale Coast, isolated by quarantine and sea-mist. Fenspire rose in the Gloaming Reach, disciplined and watchful beneath its stark silhouette. Two garrisons. Two locked jaws.

The map’s red lines connected them.

Then a third line appeared.

It ran from the map’s centre to the papers in Malchior’s hand.

Ignatz saw it too.

His sword came up.

“Burn it.”

Malchior’s fingers closed around the parchment. “It may be a warning.”

“It may be a summons.”

“Those are not always different.”

The line brightened.

The old seal cracked.

From beyond the door came a single knock.

Not loud.

Not urgent.

A knuckle against wood.

Then another.

A third.

The voice spoke through the grain, and this time it used no borrowed sorrow.

It spoke with Malchior’s voice.

“Open.”

Malchior felt the forged lineage papers unfold by themselves beneath their hand.

On the final page, beneath the carved name, fresh ink began to write.

Not a bloodline.

A date.

Chapter 12

The sea had gnawed the lower steps of Palewell Abbey to a lacework of stone.

Morwenna Ashgrove stood above the tide and watched the black water work at what remained. Spray reached her boots in cold, needling bursts. Behind her, the rebuilt abbey kept its pale walls turned toward the coast, every narrow window dark beneath its battlements. Sanctuary had been scoured from the place. What remained was a garrison with prayers painted over its murder-holes.

A bell sounded once.

Not an alarm. A summons.

Morwenna did not move until the echo had gone out over the water.

“Fleet Admiral.”

Caedmon Fellgard waited at the stairhead with a ledger held against his chest. His posture had the rigid patience of a man who trusted ink more than flesh. A smear of black marked one finger. The wind worried at his sleeves.

“Who rang it?” Morwenna asked.

“Corvus Hollowmere the Pale.”

“Then he has learned to count.”

Caedmon lowered his eyes. “He commands Palewell Abbey (since 374 AS).”

The sentence had the sound of a copied line, and perhaps it was. Caedmon carried facts as other men carried knives: close, sharpened, and never shown without purpose.

Morwenna looked back at the surf. The abbey had been founded in 244 AS. Its stones had been broken, its bones rearranged, and its garrison raised to 5998. The number had been entered three times in the fleet’s accounts, each time in a different hand, as though repetition might make the walls safer. Palewell Abbey was not a core holding. That distinction had been spoken in council with the calm of a verdict. Not core. Not essential. Not worth the ships required to relieve it.

Yet Corvus had rung for her.

“Take me to him.”

Caedmon turned.

Morwenna followed him inside.

The passage smelled of wet wool, lamp oil, and salt trapped beneath old mortar. Rebuilt walls did not settle like ancient ones. They cracked with small, private noises. Beyond the slit windows, the Pale Coast heaved under a sky the color of beaten pewter.

“Is the High Inquisitor here?” Morwenna asked.

Caedmon’s step faltered. It was almost nothing. Morwenna had spent her life learning the weight of almost nothing.

“Sabelle Mournvale the Twice-Crowned arrived before dawn.”

“Arrived for what?”

“I was not told.”

“That is not an answer.”

“No,” Caedmon said. “It is the answer I have.”

He led her into a chamber where the ceiling beams had been blackened by age or smoke. A map of the realm covered the central table, pinned at its corners with iron nails. The five powers had been marked in different colors: the Ashen Vanguard, House Morvain, the Silent Choir, the Iron-Ring Cartel, and the Bleeding Crown. Along the coast, a red thread ran from one salt-stained mark to another.

Corvus Hollowmere the Pale stood at the far side of the table.

Morwenna had never seen him before. She gave the fact no shape beyond that. Faces were weather. Offices were architecture. The man’s pale title was less important than the command beneath it.

Sabelle Mournvale sat beside the hearth, wearing the black severity of a High Inquisitor. The two crowns upon their seal gleamed dully at their throat. They watched Morwenna without blinking.

Caedmon placed his ledger on the table.

“Fleet Admiral,” Corvus said. “You came quickly.”

“The bell was loud.”

“It was meant to be heard.”

“Then speak loudly.”

A silence gathered. It was not fear. Fear had heat. This was the cold interval before a blade cleared its sheath.

Corvus touched the red thread with one finger. “A vessel passed the outer shoals without declaring its cargo.”

“Many vessels do.”

“This one carried no colors.”

“Then it was wise.”

His mouth tightened. “The Leaden Accord began in 330 AS and ended in 342 AS. The Iron-Ring Cartel was named victor. Fourteen thousand and eleven casualties were recorded.”

Caedmon’s pen moved.

Morwenna watched the ink descend.

“14,011,” she said. “If you are going to summon me, Corvus, use the number written in the records.”

Caedmon’s pen paused, then corrected the line.

Corvus looked from the scribe to her. “Both hosts were destroyed by a Ley-storm.”

“So the records say.”

“The records also say the artifact was destroyed.”

Morwenna felt the old wound open beneath her ribs—not pain, precisely. Recognition. The sea wind passed through the chamber’s cracks and touched the back of her neck.

“Supposedly destroyed,” she said.

Sabelle’s gaze sharpened.

Caedmon stopped writing.

Morwenna had sold the first fragment of that intelligence to the Iron-Ring Cartel in a room without windows, for a sum paid in sealed metal and promises. She had sold the second fragment later, when the Cartel had stopped asking whether the artifact survived and begun asking where it had gone. She had never sold the truth. Truth was too dangerous to spend all at once.

“The hidden truth,” Corvus said, “is that the supposedly destroyed artifact was spirited away.”

“By whom?”

“If I knew, I would not require a fleet admiral.”

“You require ships. That is different.”

“I require your silence.”

At the hearth, Sabelle shifted one gloved hand across the other. Their expression did not change, but something below the floor gave a muffled scrape.

Caedmon looked down.

Morwenna did not.

She had heard rumors about the High Inquisitor’s cellar. Rumors were usually the dead dressed in other people’s clothes. Yet this sound had weight. A bound revenant, if the whispers were true, kept beneath the abbey while Sabelle Mournvale the Twice-Crowned spoke of purity above it. Morwenna wondered whether the creature remembered its name. She wondered whether Sabelle feared that it did.

“Your vessel was seen from the western tower,” Corvus said.

“My vessel?”

“The fleet’s vessel.”

“Then accuse the fleet.”

“I accuse the absence of a declaration.”

“A declaration is a scrap of paper. It does not make a cargo innocent.”

“Nor does silence make it guilty.”

“No,” Morwenna said. “But it makes it valuable.”

The bell sounded again.

This time it rang twice.

Corvus turned toward the shuttered window. Caedmon’s hand closed over his pen. Sabelle rose, and the movement drew another scrape from beneath the floorboards.

A soldier shouted somewhere beyond the chamber.

Then another voice answered, too distant to understand.

Morwenna crossed to the window and opened the shutter.

The coast below was a confusion of foam and black rock. Beyond the harbor mouth, a single ship labored against the swell. No colors. No lanterns. Its sails were furled, its hull dark with water. It had come in under the storm's cover and now drifted just beyond the abbey's reach.

On its deck, figures moved.

Not sailors, Morwenna thought.

She felt for the sealed message hidden inside the lining of her coat. The paper was dry. The Cartel's cipher had been pressed into it with a blunt instrument: three lines, no greeting, no signature.

THEY KNOW THE ARTIFACT LIVES.

DO NOT LET SABELLE OPEN THE CELLAR.

BRING US THE SHIP.

The message had been waiting for her before she reached the coast. She had read it beneath a hooded lamp while the fleet cut through the dark. Since then, every mile had seemed to narrow around her.

Corvus came to stand beside her.

"Do you recognize it?"

"I recognize a ship."

"Will it anchor?"

"It has no colors."

"That was not my question."

"It will not anchor because you command it to."

His eyes remained on the vessel. "You were born in 288 AS, Morwenna Ashgrove."

Caedmon's head lifted.

Morwenna turned slowly. "You keep a curious ledger."

"Birth records are not curious. They are useful."

"Useful to whom?"

"To those who must know how long a person has had to become what they are."

Sabelle spoke from behind them. "And what have you become?"

Morwenna looked at the ship.

The answer waited in the lining of her coat, pressed into paper and paid for in silence. She had become a Fleet Admiral who sold intelligence to the Iron-Ring Cartel. The words felt smaller spoken within herself than they did when written. Treason required witnesses. Without them, it was merely another duty performed in darkness.

“Someone who dislikes being questioned by scribes and inquisitors,” she said.

Sabelle smiled without warmth. “You dislike being known.”

“Everyone does.”

“Not the dead.”

The scrape beneath the floor came again.

This time it was followed by a soft, wet exhalation.

Caedmon’s face lost what little color it possessed. Corvus looked toward the hearth.

Morwenna saw the calculation pass through him: the ship outside, the revenant below, the High Inquisitor at his back, and the Fleet Admiral between them. A commander could survive one threat by choosing another. A ruler could survive several by naming them law.

The ship’s bow swung in the tide.

For an instant, something pale showed beneath its forward rail—not a flag, not a lantern, but a length of cloth knotted around a human arm.

The arm lifted.

Sabelle stepped toward the hearth.

“Do not,” Morwenna said.

The High Inquisitor stopped.

The word had left Morwenna before she had chosen it. In the room, it stood naked and irreversible.

Corvus reached for the bell rope.

Morwenna’s hand went beneath her coat, closing around the message meant for the Iron-Ring Cartel, while below the floorboards the bound revenant began to whisper—and Caedmon, pale with terror, bent to hear what it said.

The rope shuddered beneath Corvus’s hand.

Not yet rung. The bell above them gave a dull, reluctant tremor, as if even iron could be made to hesitate.

Below, the revenant whispered.

Caedmon Fellgard bent nearer.

Morwenna heard only the scrape of his breath and the faint movement of his pen. He had brought the pen down without seeming to decide it, the nib poised above the page while the dead voice crawled through the floorboards. His shoulders were narrow beneath his robe. Ink had darkened the side of one finger. A scribe’s hands, made for preserving what others wished forgotten.

“What does it say?” Morwenna asked.

Caedmon did not look up. “I am not certain it uses words.”

“Then write the sounds.”

His pen touched the page.

The whisper below thickened. It moved through the stone in wet threads, a voice dragged across the underside of the world. Sabelle stood by the hearth, one hand still extended from the command Morwenna had given. Firelight trembled over the metalwork at their throat and over the shadow cast by the crown they wore—not a king’s crown, not entirely, but something fashioned to remind every witness that authority could be inherited from ruin.

Sabelle Mournvale the Twice-Crowned had been born in 263 AS. Morwenna knew the year because High Inquisitors were entered into the old ledgers twice: once as children and once as instruments. Sabelle’s second entry had been written in a different hand.

Their gaze remained on Morwenna.

“You have mistaken restraint for mercy,” Sabelle said.

“I have mistaken nothing.”

“No?” Their voice was quiet. “You heard a dead thing speak and reached first for the living.”

Morwenna’s hand remained beneath her coat, closed around the message intended for the Iron-Ring Cartel. The paper had warmed against her palm. Its folded edge pressed into the flesh like a blade too dull to cut cleanly.

Outside, the ship’s hull groaned against the tide.

The arm beneath the forward rail had vanished.

Corvus released the rope. “There was an arm.”

“There was cloth,” Sabelle said.

“There was an arm,” Corvus replied.

The High Inquisitor’s eyes did not leave Morwenna. “Then you should be grateful it did not wave.”

Caedmon’s pen scratched faster.

The revenant spoke again, and this time a word rose clear enough to be understood.

“Leaden.”

The fire drew inward.

Morwenna felt the room alter around her. Not visibly. The hearth remained a hearth; the black beams remained black beams. Yet some old pressure had entered the air, some weight that belonged beneath mountains and beneath oaths.

“The Leaden Accord,” Caedmon whispered.

Sabelle turned toward him. “Read what you have.”

Caedmon swallowed. His face had gone pale, though his hands stayed steady.

“The Leaden Accord began in 330 AS,” he said. “It ended in 342 AS with 14,011 casualties. The Iron-Ring Cartel was named victor.”

The ship struck something below with a hollow boom.

Corvus stared toward the shuttered window. “That is written in every account.”

“Not every account,” said Morwenna.

The revenant hissed beneath them.

Caedmon’s nib shivered. “Both hosts were destroyed by a Ley-storm.”

“Yes,” Sabelle said. “That too is written.”

“And the hidden truth,” Caedmon continued, “is that a supposedly destroyed artifact was spirited away.”

No one moved.

Morwenna watched the page. The scribe had written the words in a cramped hand, forcing them together as if the truth required less space than a lie. She had seen records altered by order of admirals, abbots, princes, and merchants. Ink was obedient. Paper had no conscience. Only men pretended otherwise.

The Iron-Ring Cartel had been named victor after both hosts had been annihilated. A victory over ash. A triumph measured in the absence of survivors. Morwenna had spent years learning how much intelligence could be bought with that kind of silence.

The message beneath her coat seemed to pulse.

Sabelle approached the table.

“Who told you to stop me?”

“No one.”

“Then why did you?”

Morwenna looked at the hearth. A coal collapsed, sending a spray of sparks up the chimney. “Because you are not the only one who can hear what is beneath us.”

“That is not an answer.”

“It is the one you are receiving.”

For the first time, Sabelle smiled.

It had none of the warmth that preceded a smile in the living. “You were born in 288 AS, Fleet Admiral. You learned command under a realm already full of ghosts. You should know that anything which whispers from below is either hungry or useful.”

Morwenna’s fingers tightened around the message.

The title struck her as an accusation. Fleet Admiral. A station built from discipline, signal, and the public fiction that every order passed through one visible hand. Her authority had been forged in open water, where distance made people honest about fear. Here, beneath stone and sanctity, every silence had a second mouth.

“Perhaps it is neither,” she said.

“Nothing is neither.”

Caedmon looked up from his page. “It is saying there is no artifact.”

Sabelle’s attention shifted to him.

Caedmon’s throat worked. “Or—no. It says the artifact has no—” He frowned, listening. “No grave.”

The revenant's voice ceased.

The silence afterward was worse.

Morwenna heard the tide beneath the walls, the minute settling of the timbers, the dry rasp of Corvus's breathing. Somewhere above, a gull cried and was cut short.

Sabelle placed both hands upon the table. "Caedmon Fellgard, do not embellish what you hear."

"I am not embellishing."

"You are frightened."

"Yes."

"At least fear remains a form of honesty."

Caedmon lowered his eyes. His pen resumed its work, though the page had begun to tremble under it.

Morwenna thought of Greyfell Citadel, founded in 62 AS in the Shattered Vale. An abandoned fortress outside the realm's core holdings, grey stone emptied of banners and purpose. It had been raised to command the passes, then left to the weather and whatever slept in its cisterns. Every chart called it irrelevant. Every smuggler's route bent toward it.

The ship had not come by accident.

Neither had the arm.

"Where is the vessel bound?" Morwenna asked.

Corvus's mouth tightened. "You assume it is bound anywhere."

"Everything afloat is bound somewhere."

"Not wreckage."

"Wreckage does not signal."

"There was no signal."

"Then why are you still watching the window?"

Corvus turned from her. His face was hard with the particular anger of a man forced to doubt his own sight. "Because Palewell Abbey is not blind."

Morwenna let that settle.

Palewell Abbey stood in The Pale Coast. It had been founded in 244 AS, rebuilt after ruin, and maintained a garrison of 5998. It was not a core holding, but its walls had been thickened until prayer could be delivered through arrow slits. Six thousand nearly, in all but name; 5998 in the ledger, because ledgers demanded that two absences be made visible.

"Palewell's garrison would have seen the ship," Morwenna said.

"Palewell's garrison sees what it is ordered to see."

"And who ordered them?"

Corvus said nothing.

Sabelle lifted their hand from the table and touched one finger to the folded edge of Morwenna's coat, not quite touching the hidden message. The gesture was delicate. Intimate only in the way a knife's point was intimate with the skin.

"You carry a letter," Sabbell said.

Morwenna did not blink. "I carry many things."

"A letter intended for the Iron-Ring Cartel."

The fire made a soft cracking sound.

Caedmon's pen stopped.

Corvus looked between them. "Is that true?"

Morwenna considered denying it. The denial came easily; she had worn it in councils, aboard flagships, before men who would have condemned her for less and purchased her for more. But Sabbell had not asked how they knew. Their certainty had already crossed the room and seated itself among them.

"Yes," Morwenna said.

Corvus's hand moved toward the weapon at his side.

Morwenna did not look at it. "If you draw, you will make the room smaller. That will benefit the dead thing beneath us."

"Do not instruct me in rooms."

"I instruct you in consequences."

Sabelle's expression had gone still. "What does the Cartel want?"

"Information."

"They always want information."

"They want what they are willing to pay for."

"And what are you willing to sell?"

Morwenna felt the old, familiar division open inside her: the admiral on one side, the woman who counted coin and currents on the other. She had never mistaken the two for friends. The admiral believed in command. The other believed command was merely the most expensive form of leverage.

"Routes," she said.

"Which routes?"

"Those not protected by your bells."

Corvus's hand closed around the hilt at his side.

Sabelle did not move. "You have been selling intelligence to the Iron-Ring Cartel."

The words were not loud. They did not need to be.

Morwenna looked at the dead hearth, the old mortar, the ash gathered in its corners. She imagined the message burning. She imagined the Cartel's disappointment, then its patience. Merchants could forgive

betrayal when betrayal remained profitable. They did not forgive waste.

“Yes,” she said.

Caedmon made a small sound.

Morwenna turned to him. “Write that as well.”

The scribe stared at her.

“Write it,” she repeated.

His hand lowered. The nib touched the page.

Sabelle watched the confession take form. Their eyes were dark in the firelight, and beneath the severity of their face something stirred—satisfaction, perhaps, or the colder pleasure of a lock finding its key.

“You think this saves you,” they said.

“No.”

“Then what does it do?”

“Places the truth where it can be used.”

“By whom?”

Morwenna heard it then.

Not beneath the floorboards.

Outside.

A knock against the hull.

Once.

Twice.

A third time, softer than the others.

Corvus turned toward the window. Sabelle’s hand went to the bell rope again.

Morwenna caught their wrist.

The contact lasted no longer than a breath. Sabelle’s pulse was calm beneath her fingers.

Below them, the revenant began to laugh.

The laughter rose through the timbers, wet and patient, as though the thing below had learned the shape of amusement from overheard mouths.

Sabelle looked down at Morwenna’s hand.

Not at her face. At the fingers closed around their wrist.

“Release me.”

Morwenna did.

The bell rope trembled beside them. Its iron tongue gave a small, betraying chime.

Outside, the darkness pressed against the glass. No lantern showed beyond it. No pale face. Only the black water, broken by a skin of rain, and the reflection of the cabin fire shivering where the window should have opened onto night.

Corvus had not moved from the window.

“Was that the signal?” Morwenna asked.

“No,” Corvus said.

Their voice had changed. It carried none of the command with which they ruled Palewell Abbey. There was fear in it, but not fear for themselves. Morwenna knew the sound. It was the fear of a person who had trusted a wall to remain a wall.

The revenant laughed again.

This time, something struck the underside of the deck.

Wood groaned.

Sabelle’s expression remained composed. They drew a narrow blade from beneath their coat, not with haste but with the grim economy of practice. The fire found the metal and slid away.

“Stay here,” they said.

Morwenna almost smiled. “To whom?”

Sabelle glanced toward Corvus. “Both of you.”

Corvus turned from the window. “You would leave us above it?”

“I would leave you above what is already beneath you.”

“That is not an answer.”

“It is the only one you are owed.”

The hull gave another shudder. A cup rolled from the table and broke against the wall. Wine spread across the boards, darkening the grain. Its smell mingled with the damp and the old smoke, sweet as rot.

Morwenna felt the weight of the message hidden inside her coat.

Not a letter. Not anything so innocent.

The information had been written in a cipher that could be read as a devotional inventory if found by the wrong hands. The Iron-Ring Cartel preferred such arrangements. Truth disguised as piety. Treason dressed in a clerk’s careful ink.

She had sold them less than they wanted and more than they deserved. That was how she had survived each exchange. Give them a gate, keep the key. Give them a name, keep the reason. Yet the truth she had placed before Sabelle was different. It had not been purchased. It had been lifted from the dark and set between them like a blade.

Now someone waited outside the hull.

Or something.

The window clicked.

Morwenna turned.

A fingertip pressed against the outer pane.

It was grey through the glass, the nail blackened, the skin stretched thin enough to show the cords beneath. The finger withdrew. A palm replaced it, leaving a smear of water that did not run downward. It crawled sideways, gathering itself into a thin, trembling line.

Corvus whispered a prayer.

Sabelle watched the hand without blinking.

“Open the door,” called a voice from outside.

The sound was muffled by rain and timber, but it was unmistakably human.

Morwenna knew it.

Not the speaker. The cadence.

A voice trained to make requests sound like verdicts.

Sabelle’s blade lowered a fraction. “You should not be here.”

“Neither should you.”

The words came again, closer now, from beneath the cabin. The revenant had stopped laughing.

Morwenna looked toward the trapdoor.

It was shut. Iron-banded. A lock rested in its bracket, though she had seen Sabelle carry no key. The seams around it had been sealed with wax. Someone had pressed a mark into the wax: a circle broken by three straight strokes.

The mark of the Silent Choir.

She had seen it on intercepted cargo, on drowned reports, on the margins of ledgers bought and burned before they could reach any tribunal. The Choir left no proclamations. It left absences. A missing witness. A door found open. A page cut cleanly from a book.

“Who is below?” Corvus asked.

Sabelle did not answer.

The voice outside gave a soft, almost affectionate sigh.

“High Inquisitor.”

The title entered the room like cold air.

Sabelle’s face hardened. “You are trespassing.”

“You invited us.”

“I invited no one.”

“You invited the truth.”

Morwenna felt the room contract around that word.

The fire snapped. A coal broke free and rolled across the hearthstone. Shadows leapt over Sabelle's crowned brow, across the severe planes of their face, and vanished into the folds of their coat. Twice-Crowned. The title had once been spoken with reverence, then with suspicion, and now with the cautious disgust reserved for things that remained powerful after they had become impossible to forgive.

Below them, the lock turned.

Corvus swore.

The sound was quiet, but it had the force of a cannon shot.

Sabelle crossed the room in three strides and seized the trapdoor's iron ring. The wood bucked beneath their hand.

"Go to the stern," they ordered.

Morwenna did not move. "Why?"

"Because if the door opens, you will be the first thing it sees."

"That is not reassuring."

"It was not meant to be."

Corvus drew a pistol from within their coat. The weapon looked too small for the room, too delicate for whatever waited beneath the boards. They held it with both hands.

Morwenna saw then what the cold had hidden: a line of blood running from Corvus's palm to their sleeve.

"You're hurt."

"I am commanded."

"Those are not opposites."

"No," Corvus said. "But they are not the same."

The lock clicked.

Sabelle planted one boot on the trapdoor. Their blade hovered at the seam.

The voice outside spoke once more.

"Morwenna Ashgrove."

Her name sounded wrong in that mouth. Flattened. Studied.

She had heard it spoken by sailors, ministers, officers, enemies, and men who wished to become one of those things. This voice knew nothing of her rank and everything of her use.

"I know what you carry," it said.

The message inside her coat seemed to warm against her ribs.

The Iron-Ring Cartel had taught her never to reach for concealed steel while being watched. Never to answer a threat with a confession. Never to mistake a person's knowledge for their certainty.

She had learned those lessons before the Leaden Accord, when every harbor had been a mouth and every mouth might have been bought.

She had forgotten none of them.

Sabelle looked at her. "What did you tell them?"

"Nothing."

The answer came too quickly.

Their gaze sharpened.

Morwenna held it. "Nothing they can prove."

"That is a different answer."

"It is the one that matters."

Beneath the trapdoor, the revenant began to whisper.

The words were indistinct, but the rhythm was clear: a child's counting song without its numbers, a melody stripped of innocence and left with only the bones. Morwenna had heard sailors hum similar tunes before storms. They always stopped before the final verse.

Sabelle's fingers tightened around the iron ring.

"You will speak plainly," they said.

"Not while your guest is listening."

"My guest?"

"Your prisoner."

The revenant fell silent.

The quiet that followed was worse than its laughter.

Corvus's pistol swung toward the door. "You keep it below?"

Sabelle did not look at them. "I keep nothing."

The trapdoor lifted an inch.

A breath emerged from the crack. It smelled of old soil, salt, and something medicinal burned past bitterness. Morwenna's skin tightened along her arms.

Sabelle forced the hatch down.

Something struck from beneath.

The boards bowed upward. The wax seal split with a faint, wet sound.

A second blow.

The hinges screamed.

"Open the door," called the voice outside.

"Get away from the window," Morwenna said.

Corvus did not obey. Their eyes remained fixed on the black pane.

“Why?”

“Because it wants us looking out.”

The grey hand appeared again.

This time it was not alone.

A second palm pressed beside it. Then a third, each one emerging from the dark at impossible distances, as though the outer wall had become transparent to a crowd waiting on the other side. No faces. No bodies. Only hands, pale and patient against the rain.

Corvus raised the pistol.

“Do not,” Morwenna said.

The nearest fingers curled.

The window cracked.

A line of silver ran from top to bottom.

Sabelle’s head snapped toward it. “What did you bring here?”

Morwenna could have lied.

She had lied in council chambers, in war rooms, in the mouths of harbors where men watched her ships burn and waited to learn which way the wind would carry the blame. Lies were tools. A good commander kept them clean.

But below them, the revenant had begun to laugh again.

And outside, the hands were tapping against the glass in a slow, deliberate pattern.

Once.

Twice.

A third time.

Morwenna reached beneath her coat and withdrew the sealed strip of parchment.

Sabelle’s eyes dropped to it.

Corvus’s pistol wavered.

The seal bore no crest. Only a narrow ring of black wax, pressed flat.

“I did not bring this here,” Morwenna said.

The trapdoor tore free of its hinges.

Sabelle moved first, driving their blade downward as something pale surged through the opening. Steel struck flesh—or what had replaced flesh—and the cabin filled with a shriek so thin it seemed to come from inside Morwenna’s teeth.

The window shattered.

Rain blew in.

The hands vanished.

For one breath there was only fire, broken glass, and the stink of the opened cellar.

Then the thing beneath the deck spoke in Morwenna's own voice.

"Open the message."

Chapter 13

The bell above Fenspire had a cracked voice.

It spoke across the Gloaming Reach in a single iron note, and the sound entered Isolde Fellgard the Unforgiven through the scars beneath their ribs. The tower had stood since 57 AS, a black needle thrust into the dim country, and its garrison of 3,742 kept watch from walls that had outlived every oath sworn beneath them.

Below, soldiers moved through the rain with hooded lamps. Their armor glimmered like wet bone. The garrisoned city did not sleep so much as clench itself against the dark.

Isolde stood beneath the covered walk, one gloved hand resting on the pommel of a knife they had never drawn in public. Water whispered from the roof. Beyond the parapet, the Gloaming Reach sank toward the Pale Coast, and somewhere past that pallid, wind-scoured margin lay Gloamreach: quarantined, sealed from the surrounding coast, guarded by a garrison of 2,483.

Nothing entered Gloamreach without being counted.

Nothing left without being changed.

“Your blood is on the stone.”

The voice came behind them.

Isolde looked down. A red thread had slipped from the cut in their palm and darkened the flagging between their boots. They had not felt themselves open the wound. Their body had learned to obey grievance before thought.

Ossric Ashgrove crouched beside the stain with a ledger balanced on one knee. He was a quartermaster, born in 333 AS, and every inch of him seemed made for measuring what remained after other people had taken too much. He dipped a rag into a bucket and scrubbed the stone.

“You count stains now?” Isolde asked.

“I count everything that might be blamed on me.”

“Then you are a better servant than most.”

Ossric’s fingers paused. His temperament was not recorded in any ledger Isolde had seen, but caution had a texture. It lived in the way he kept his eyes lowered, in the careful silence between each breath.

“The Warden-Commander is waiting,” he said.

“Which one?”

Ossric’s hand tightened around the rag.

There was only one Warden-Commander in Fenspire, but titles were doors, and Isolde had spent too long learning which doors were trapped.

“Ignatz Ashgrove the Oathless,” Ossric said.

The name moved through the covered walk like a draught from a crypt.

Ignatz had been born in 258 AS. He wore command as though it were a cloak inherited from a dead man, broad enough to hide whatever was underneath. His intelligence passed into the Iron-Ring Cartel by secret

channels, though the Cartel's agents never called it selling. They called it accounting. They called every betrayal a balance restored.

Isolde turned from the parapet.

"Did he say why?"

"He said only that the matter concerned Blackport."

"Then it concerns a corpse."

Ossric glanced toward the rain. "The Purge of Blackport ended with seventy thousand—"

"70,907."

The quartermaster swallowed.

"70,907 casualties," Isolde said. "You need not soften the number for me."

"I had not meant to."

"No. You meant to survive saying it."

He looked at them then, and his eyes held the flat, sleepless terror of a man who had learned that truth was not protection. Isolde understood that terror. They carried a different kind. Their own was sharpened, banked, made useful.

The Purge of Blackport began in 311 AS and ended in 321 AS. The aggressors were totally routed. The Iron-Ring Cartel emerged as victor.

Those facts had been carved into proclamations, repeated in sanctuaries, stamped upon ration chits and military dispatches until the words had worn smooth. But beneath them lay the concealed truth: the victors had poisoned the wells of their own allies.

Isolde had tasted that truth once, in the bitterness of a report burned at the edges.

"Is the Arch-Prelate here?" they asked.

Ossric resumed scrubbing. "Malchior Cindervale the Flame-Touched arrived before dusk."

"Of course they did."

"Arch-Prelate Malchior said the meeting required witnesses."

"Malchior says many things."

"Those are dangerous words."

"So is Malchior."

The bell sounded again. Its cracked note trembled in the rain.

Malchior Cindervale the Flame-Touched had been born in 289 AS and served as Arch-Prelate with the rigid grace of someone balancing a crown upon a blade. Their lineage was displayed in every robe, seal, and prayer: ancestral ink, sanctified blood, a chain of names reaching backward into the ruin. Isolde knew the papers were forged. The knowledge had come to them folded inside a dead courier's coat, though the courier's name was not worth remembering.

Malchior's authority was holy only so long as no one held it to the light.

“Go on,” Isolde said.

Ossric stood. He was younger than the walls, younger than most of the fear inside them, and yet the damp had already settled into his shoulders.

“The Warden-Commander is in the old tally chamber.”

“Did he bring soldiers?”

“Fenspire is garrisoned.”

“That was not my question.”

Ossric’s mouth thinned. “Yes.”

“Then he brought witnesses after all.”

They walked.

The old tally chamber occupied the lower spine of the tower, where the air smelled of iron, lamp oil, and the mineral damp of the Reach. Narrow windows slit the walls but admitted no view. Fenspire had been built to see without being seen. Its defenders kept their eyes on roads, marshes, and the pale distance toward the coast. Its secrets remained underground.

Two soldiers barred the chamber door. Their faces were hidden behind half-masks, and their hands rested near their weapons.

Isolde stopped before them.

“Do you know who I am?”

Neither answered.

“Good.”

The door opened from within.

Ignatz Ashgrove the Oathless stood at the far end of the chamber, beneath a map pierced with black pins. No canonical feature marked him; authority had left no portrait in the records, only the title Warden-Commander and the epithet the Oathless. Isolde found the absence fitting. A man who sold intelligence to the Iron-Ring Cartel had no need of a face. A shadow could be purchased more cheaply.

Malchior stood beside the table in flame-colored vestments darkened by rain. Their hand rested upon a bundle of papers bound with red cord.

“You are late,” Ignatz said.

“I was washing blood from the floor.”

“Yours?”

“Does it matter?”

“To a quartermaster, perhaps.”

Ossric remained outside. The door closed between them with a damp wooden groan.

Malchior’s gaze settled upon Isolde’s palm. “You make a sacrament of injury.”

“You make a sacrament of paper.”

The Arch-Prelate’s expression did not move. Only the fingers upon the cord betrayed them, pressing hard enough to blanch.

Ignatz turned to the map. “Gloamreach has sent no confirmation.”

“It is quarantined,” Isolde said. “That is the meaning of the word.”

“It has a garrison of 2,483.”

“And still the dead may outnumber the living.”

“No one has said there are dead.”

“Then why is the coast silent?”

The Warden-Commander touched one of the black pins. It marked the Pale Coast, though the mapmaker had rendered the shore as a thin white scar.

“Because silence is cheaper than defense.”

“Spoken like a man who has sold both.”

The chamber tightened.

Malchior looked from one to the other. “We are not here to trade accusations.”

“No,” Isolde said. “We are here to decide which accusation will be made official.”

Ignatz’s hand remained upon the pin. “The Iron-Ring Cartel has requested an accounting of the Blackport routes.”

“They requested intelligence,” Isolde said.

“They requested an accounting.”

“And you intend to provide it.”

His head tilted slightly. “You speak with confidence.”

“I speak with memory.”

The rain struck the narrow windows. In the black glass, Isolde saw a blurred reflection: the pale planes of an Unforgiven Blood-Mage, the red at their palm, the dangerous stillness of grievance held beneath the skin. They had plotted the death of their own liege. The thought rose without remorse, not because remorse was absent, but because it had been burned away and replaced by something more durable.

No one in the chamber knew the shape of that plot.

Malchior knew many secrets, but not that one.

Perhaps.

“The Purge of Blackport was a victory,” Malchior said. “The aggressors were routed. The Iron-Ring Cartel emerged as victor. That is the record.”

“The record is a grave with the lid nailed shut.”

“The number is 70,907 casualties,” Ignatz said. “The beginning was 311 AS. The end was 321 AS. You cannot alter what is written.”

“I can alter what is remembered.”

Malchior’s eyes flashed. “Careful.”

“Are you warning me as Arch-Prelate, or as the heir of a lineage that never existed?”

The silence afterward was exquisite.

The forged papers lay between them, their red cord bright as opened veins.

Malchior touched the bundle. “You are reckless.”

“I am Unforgiven.”

“That is not an excuse.”

“No. It is what remains after excuses have failed.”

Ignatz moved toward the table. “Enough. The Cartel believes the poisoned wells were not an act of desperation but a design. They believe someone within the allied command knew.”

“They are correct,” Isolde said.

Malchior’s jaw tightened. “Do not make allegations without proof.”

“Proof is for courts. Power requires only an audience.”

“And what do you require?”

Isolde looked at the map. At the pale coast. At Gloamreach, locked behind quarantine and its garrison of 2,483. At Fenspire, whose 3,742 defenders watched the Reach as if vigilance could stop rot from traveling through water.

“I require the truth to become expensive.”

Ignatz’s eyes narrowed. “The Cartel will pay.”

“Then you have already named your price.”

For the first time, something moved behind his composure—not shame, not fear. Calculation. The Oathless had secrets beneath secrets, and somewhere among them the names of those who bought his intelligence. Isolde imagined the documents leaving Fenspire by hidden roads, crossing the Reach under wax and seal, arriving in Iron-Ring hands.

Five powers contended over the ruins: the Ashen Vanguard, House Morvain, the Silent Choir, the Iron-Ring Cartel, and the Bleeding Crown. Each claimed to be the last wall between the realm and oblivion. Each fed on the rubble.

Malchior drew a knife and cut the red cord.

The papers loosened.

Isolde smelled old ink, damp parchment, and the faint metallic tang of blood.

Not theirs.

“Read,” Malchior said.

Isolde reached for the first page.

From somewhere above, the bell began to ring again, though no hand had touched it. The sound shuddered down through the tower. Ignatz looked toward the ceiling. Malchior went still.

And on the page beneath Isolde’s fingers, a line of writing began to darken as though the ink had only just found its vein—

The letters formed themselves in a cramped, black hand.

ISOLDE FELLGARD THE UNFORGIVEN, BORN IN 286 AS.

The blood beneath the words stirred once, as if remembering the pulse of the wrist that had written them.

Isolde did not move.

The bell above gave another hollow toll. Dust sifted from the mortar. Somewhere in the tower, something dragged its nails across stone.

Malchior leaned over the page. Firelight caught the scarlet seams of their vestments and the faint discoloration along their throat—the mark that had earned them the name Flame-Touched. Their face remained composed, but one hand had closed around the edge of the table.

“Keep reading,” they said.

“You knew this was here.”

“I knew the archive kept a record of blood.”

“That is not what I asked.”

“No.” Malchior’s gaze remained on the page. “It is what I answered.”

The script continued.

BLOOD-MAGE. UNFORGIVEN. DANGEROUS ATMOSPHERE OF GRIEVANCE, AMBITION, AND CONCEALED BETRAYAL. SECRET: PLOTTED THE DEATH OF THEIR OWN LIEGE.

For a moment, Isolde heard only the rain beyond the narrow windows. It ticked against the black glass with the patience of a thing waiting to be admitted.

Ignatz’s chair creaked.

“Convenient,” he said.

Isolde turned her head. “What is?”

“That the archive knows the shape of your treason but not the name of the dead.”

“Not dead,” she said.

The word escaped before she could stop it.

Malchior looked at her then. Their eyes were pale in the candlelight, almost colorless, and utterly awake.

Ignatz’s hand lowered toward his sword.

Isolde felt the old wound under her ribs open in memory. Not pain. Pain was honest. This was the colder thing beneath it: the knowledge that a life could be ended with a whisper, a cup, a door left unbarred. The knowledge that she had once placed another's death between herself and the future, then called the choice necessity because ambition sounded uglier when spoken aloud.

"Do not mistake an intention for an ending," she said.

Ignatz smiled without warmth. "A distinction for priests."

Malchior's fingers pressed harder into the table. "The page is not finished."

New lines bled across the parchment.

THE PURGE OF BLACKPORT BEGAN IN 311 AS AND ENDED IN 321 AS. CASUALTIES: 70,907. THE AGGRESSORS WERE TOTALLY ROUTED. THE IRON-RING CARTEL EMERGED AS VICTOR.

The last sentence appeared slowly, each letter sinking into the fibers.

THE VICTORS POISONED THE WELLS OF THEIR OWN ALLIES.

Ignatz stood.

The chair fell backward and struck the flagstones.

Isolde's blood answered the violence before her mind did. A red thread rose from the split skin beside her thumb and hovered between them, trembling in the cold air. The thread was thin as a spider's filament. It could still find an eye. It could still enter a throat.

Ignatz stared at it.

"Sit," she said.

The Warden-Commander did not.

Malchior read the page again, lips barely moving. "The Iron-Ring Cartel."

"Your allies," Isolde said to Ignatz.

His expression altered by less than a breath. That was answer enough.

The bell rang.

The blood-thread snapped toward him.

Ignatz twisted aside. It struck the stone pillar behind his shoulder and sank into the mortar with a wet hiss. The tower shuddered. Every candle flame bent toward the wound.

"Isolde," Malchior said.

She felt the old, exquisite pressure of command trying to settle over her. Priestly authority. Anointed authority. The kind that expected obedience to arrive before thought.

She withdrew the thread from the wall.

"Say it," she told Ignatz.

His gaze remained fixed on the dark red filament coiling around her wrist.

“Say what?”

“That you sell intelligence to the Iron-Ring Cartel.”

Rain whispered against the windows.

For the first time since she had known him, Ignatz looked tired.

Not afraid. Tired.

“The realm is made of hungers,” he said. “The Cartel pays for knowledge. Others pay for silence. I have never pretended the difference mattered.”

“You are a Warden-Commander.”

“I was born in 258 AS,” he said, with a bitterness that made the number sound like a sentence. “I have worn command long enough to know that oaths are ropes tied by other hands.”

“The Oathless,” Malchior murmured.

Ignatz’s mouth tightened. “Names are also ropes.”

The page beneath Isolde’s hand shivered. The ink spread outward, swallowing the record of Blackport, then gathered itself into a new heading.

GLOAMREACH.

A pale map surfaced in the parchment: a coastline bleached nearly white, cliffs rising like old teeth above a dark sea.

GLOAMREACH LIES ON THE PALE COAST. CORE LOCATION. STATUS: QUARANTINED. GARRISON: 2,483.

The number gleamed wetly.

Beyond it, farther inland, another shape emerged: a single black spire thrust into the dimness.

FENSPIRE. FOUNDED IN 57 AS. LOCATION: THE GLOAMING REACH. CORE LOCATION. STATUS: GARRISONED. GARRISON: 3,742.

The tower’s image seemed to rise from the paper. Isolde could almost hear the wind moving around its heights, could almost smell the iron of disciplined men standing watch in the dark.

Malchior bent closer.

“Why show us these?”

The answer appeared beneath the map.

THE COAST IS SEALED. THE SPIRE IS WATCHING.

Then, below it:

THE ROAD BETWEEN THEM IS OPEN ONLY TO THOSE ALREADY CONDEMNED.

Ignatz gave a low laugh. “That would include us.”

“No,” said Isolde. “It would include whoever wrote this.”

She lifted the page. Beneath the map, another sheet had been hidden. Its edges were stiff with brown residue. The writing on it was less formal, more hurried.

OSSric Ashgrove, born in 333 AS. Quartermaster.

The capital letter in his name had been scratched over twice, as though the writer's hand had faltered.

No appearance had been recorded. No temperament. Only the occupation.

Quartermaster.

A man who counted what could be carried, what could be fed, what could be withheld. A man whose power lived in locked stores and altered tallies. Isolde imagined a faceless figure bending over ledgers while rain ran down the walls outside.

"Who is he?" Ignatz asked.

"Ossric Ashgrove," Malchior said.

"That was not my question."

"It is all the page gives us."

The parchment darkened again.

**IGNATZ ASHGROVE THE OATHLESS. BORN IN 258 AS. MAJOR WARDEN-COMMANDER.
SECRET: SELLS INTELLIGENCE TO THE IRON-RING CARTEL.**

The blood on the page did not accuse him. It merely stated the fact with the calmness of a grave.

Ignatz's face became a mask carved from old wood.

Isolde watched him and thought of all the gates he had opened, all the patrols sent toward empty ground, all the warnings that might have arrived too late because someone had paid for them to arrive so. No number rose from the page to measure the dead. No list gave their names.

Only the secret.

That was worse.

Malchior reached for the next sheet.

Isolde caught their wrist.

The skin beneath her fingers was hot.

"Do not," she said.

Their eyes lowered to her hand. "You are afraid of what it will say."

"I am afraid of what it will make you believe."

"Those are rarely the same thing."

She released them.

The page accepted Malchior's touch. Ink welled under their palm and spread in branching veins.

MALCHIOR CINDERVALE THE FLAME-TOUCHED. BORN IN 289 AS. ARCH-PRELATE.

The title appeared first, crowned in elaborate strokes. Then the name. Then the secret.

FORGED THEIR OWN LINEAGE PAPERS.

The bell stopped.

Silence came down so suddenly that Isolde heard the rainwater crawling through the gutters outside.

Malchior did not look at the page.

Ignatz did.

“Arch-Prelate,” he said softly. “A title built on forged parchment.”

“Most titles are,” Malchior replied.

“Not yours?”

“You have the answer.”

The flame in the nearest candle burned blue.

Malchior’s composure had not broken, but something beneath it had shifted. The sanctified authority remained in the set of their shoulders, in the careful angle of their chin. Yet Isolde saw the strain now—the pressure of a structure built over emptiness, the terror that one loose stone might bring the whole edifice down.

“You forged your own lineage papers,” Isolde said.

“I made them legible.”

“Forged.”

“A word for the sin of the powerless. When the powerful do it, they call it correction.”

“And what were you correcting?”

Malchior smiled then, but the expression held no joy. “The page does not say.”

The archive answered.

A line appeared beneath the secret.

CLAIMED BLOOD IS STILL BLOOD.

Isolde felt the tower tilt.

Not physically. The floor remained steady beneath her boots, the table did not slide, the candles stood upright. But the world had shifted its weight. Each of them had arrived carrying a concealed blade. The papers had only placed the blades in their hands.

Ignatz stepped toward the table.

“Burn them.”

Malchior’s gaze moved to him. “That would not erase what they know.”

“It would erase the evidence.”

“Evidence for whom?” Isolde asked. “The page has no court.”

“No,” Ignatz said. “It has witnesses.”

His eyes settled on her.

The blood around her wrist tightened like a bracelet.

She thought of the liege whose death she had plotted, of the first instruction whispered in a dark room, of how easily loyalty became a mask worn by those waiting to inherit the face beneath it. She had told herself she had been wronged. She had told herself the realm could not survive another season beneath a failing hand.

She had believed both things.

That was the unforgiven part—not that she had betrayed, but that some portion of her still believed the betrayal had been necessary.

Malchior gathered the pages. The parchment resisted, clinging to the table as though nailed there by invisible fingers.

“Leave them,” Isolde said.

“If the Cartel finds them—”

“The Cartel already knows enough.”

Ignatz’s expression hardened. “You speak as though you understand them.”

“I understand hunger. It wears many colors.”

The first page split down the middle.

From the tear seeped a dark red line, thicker than ink, crawling across the table toward the edge. It reached the floor and continued through the cracks between the stones.

All three watched it descend.

The bell began to ring again.

Once.

Twice.

On the third toll, something below the tower answered with a knock.

The knock came again.

Not from beneath the stones this time. From within them.

Isolde felt it in the soles of their feet, a patient pressure travelling up through bone. The red line on the floor had stopped at the foot of the table. It trembled there, gathering itself into a dark, glossy bead.

Malchior crossed himself.

The gesture was small, almost graceful. The ring on their finger scraped against the chain of their office, and the sound seemed horribly loud in the chamber.

“Do not,” Isolde said.

The Arch-Prelate’s hand remained against their breast. “Do not what?”

“Pray.”

“I was not praying.”

“You were asking something to listen.”

Malchior’s face was pale in the tower’s failing light. The flame-touched marks along their throat seemed to stir beneath the skin, as though embers had been laid under flesh and were searching for air.

Ignatz reached for the sword at his hip.

“Steel will not help you,” Isolde said.

His fingers tightened around the hilt. “It has helped me before.”

“Then it will be offended by the change.”

Another knock.

Dust sifted from the ceiling. Somewhere above, the bell’s iron tongue dragged against its housing without striking. The tower groaned around them, old stone bearing the memory of every winter it had survived.

Isolde looked down at the blood.

It was theirs.

They knew the taste of it though none had touched their tongue: iron, salt, the faint bitterness that came when a spell was being forced through unwilling channels. Blood-magic was never a matter of command. It was negotiation. The blood remembered every wound. It remembered the hand that opened it, the reason, the fear. It remembered debts even when the mind had buried them.

The page lay split upon the table. Beneath its torn surface, another script had surfaced in thin red strokes.

Malchior leaned over it. “This was concealed.”

“Everything worth hiding is concealed.”

“Not from us.”

Isolde smiled without warmth. “You forged your own lineage papers, Malchior Cindervale the Flame-Touched. Concealment is not a craft you have mastered. It is merely one you have survived.”

The Arch-Prelate turned toward them.

Ignatz’s gaze moved between their faces. Suspicion sat naturally on him, like a cloak that had never been removed. Ignatz Ashgrove the Oathless had been born in 258 AS, and age had carved no softness into him. He carried command as if it were a burden he intended to make everyone else share.

Malchior’s voice dropped. “You choose an interesting moment to accuse me.”

“I choose the moment the dead begin knocking.”

“Do you know what you are reading?”

“No.”

That answer unsettled them more than any lie would have.

The red script lengthened.

Fenspire. Founded in 57 AS. Garrisoned. Garrison: 3,742.

The words crawled across the parchment, each letter swelling before it dried. Isolde could hear the quill that had written them, though no quill moved: a wet, delicate scratching, like a beetle trapped beneath a cup.

Ignatz bent closer.

“Fenspire stands in the Gloaming Reach,” he said.

“I know where it stands.”

“Then you know what it means.”

“It means someone wishes us to believe the garrison is vulnerable.”

“Or that it is not.”

The blood-script changed.

Gloamreach. Pale Coast. Quarantined. Garrison: 2,483.

The room seemed to contract around the name.

Isolde had never seen Gloamreach, but they had seen its absence. On maps, roads bent away from it. Orders spoke of sealed approaches and withheld supplies. The Pale Coast was often described in military dispatches with the language of weather: pallid, difficult, unavoidable. Gloamreach was described with silence.

Malchior’s lips parted. “Why would a dead thing list garrisons?”

“Perhaps it is not dead.”

The knock came from beneath the table.

Isolde did not move. The blood at the edge of the stone shivered, and with it came a pressure behind their eyes. For an instant the chamber vanished.

A well.

Black water under a white sky.

Hands lowering a sealed vessel into the depths.

The vision broke before a face could form.

Isolde gripped the table until their nails bit into the wood.

Ignatz saw. “What did you see?”

“A choice.”

“That is not an answer.”

“It is the only one you can afford.”

The page darkened. New words bled upward from the torn seam.

The Purge of Blackport began in 311 AS.

Malchior drew a sharp breath.

The script continued.

The Purge of Blackport ended in 321 AS. Seventy thousand nine hundred and seven casualties. Total rout of the aggressors. The Iron-Ring Cartel emerged as victor.

The line beneath it remained blank for a moment.

Then the final sentence appeared.

The victors poisoned the wells of their own allies.

No one spoke.

Wind pressed against the tower, carrying the smell of wet ash through the cracks in the shutters. Isolde imagined Blackport as the blood remembered it: mouths cracked with thirst, buckets lowered into poisoned dark, soldiers drinking because orders were stronger than instinct. The Iron-Ring Cartel had always understood that victory was not the end of a war. It was what one did to the survivors afterward.

Ignatz's face had become unreadable.

That was answer enough.

"You knew," Isolde said.

"I knew the Cartel won."

"You knew how."

"I knew what I was told."

"You sell intelligence to the Iron-Ring Cartel. Did they tell you the wells were theirs to poison?"

His eyes shifted—not toward the door, not toward Malchior, but toward the blood on the floor.

That movement was almost tender.

Almost.

Malchior stepped between them. "This is madness. We are standing in a tower with a page that writes old history and accuses living people."

"History is only accusation after the witnesses are gone."

"And what does it accuse you of?"

The question struck deeper than it should have.

Isolde felt again the last chamber, the dying liege, the warmth of blood on their hands. They had plotted the death of their own liege with more care than they had ever given to prayer. There had been no thunder, no righteous revelation. Only a cup, a door left unbarred, and the knowledge that afterward the realm would have to pretend the death had been inevitable.

The page wrote again.

Isolde Fellgard the Unforgiven. Born in 286 AS. Blood-Mage.

Their name appeared last, darker than the others.

The blood at their feet began to climb.

It rose in a thin filament, stretching from the floor toward the table. Isolde watched it with the terrible calm of recognition. Their own blood answered the page. Not obediently. Hungrily.

Malchior whispered, "What have you done?"

"Nothing."

"That is a lie."

"Yes."

The filament touched the parchment.

Every candle went out.

Darkness swallowed the tower. Isolde heard Ignatz draw his sword, heard Malchior's chain strike the table, heard stone complain beneath the weight of something waking below.

Then a voice spoke from the floor.

It was not loud. It did not need to be.

"Name the liege."

Isolde's breath stopped.

The voice spoke again.

"Name the liege."

Ignatz moved toward them. His boots scraped once against the flagstones, then halted.

"Isolde," he said, and for the first time the Warden-Commander sounded uncertain. "Do not answer."

Malchior murmured a prayer despite the warning. The words were old, polished smooth by generations of mouths. The tower rejected them. Each syllable returned from the walls misshapen, stripped of sanctity.

The blood climbed higher.

It curled around Isolde's wrist.

Cold—not wet, not warm, but cold as a blade left beneath winter water. The contact opened something inside them. A corridor of memory stretched away, its walls lined with doors. Behind one door waited the liege's voice. Behind another, the rustle of forged papers. Behind another, the quiet exchange of sealed intelligence for Cartel coin.

Ignatz made a strangled sound.

Isolde turned toward him, though they could see nothing.

"What door did it open for you?" they asked.

"Be silent."

"So it opened one."

"I said be silent."

The floor cracked.

A narrow seam appeared between the stones, running from the table to the tower's centre. Red light seeped through it—not the dull glow of fire, but the colour of fresh wounds under moonlight.

Malchior's voice broke. "The Silent Choir buried this."

"No," Isolde said.

"How could you know?"

"Because the Silent Choir would have made the silence permanent."

The seam widened.

Below, something breathed.

A gust rose from the dark, carrying the stink of old water and iron. The papers lifted from the table and wheeled around the chamber. Fenspire flashed past Isolde's eyes. Gloamreach. Blackport. The Iron-Ring Cartel. Names, numbers, years, each fragment fastening itself to the next like links in a chain.

The Ashen Vanguard. House Morvain. The Bleeding Crown.

Five powers circling the same corpse, each insisting it had not been the one to kill it.

The page struck Isolde across the face.

They caught it.

The parchment pulsed in their hand.

A final line appeared, written in their own blood.

Speak the name, Isolde Fellgard the Unforgiven.

The thing below knocked once more.

This time the tower answered.

Isolde closed their fingers around the page. Somewhere in the dark, Ignatz whispered an oath he had already broken. Malchior began to recite the lineage they had forged for themselves, each invented ancestor shaking loose from the black.

And beneath their feet, the dead waited to hear whom Isolde had murdered for the sake of the living.

Chapter 14

Greyfell Citadel had been founded in 62 AS, when the Shattered Vale was still spoken of as though it might one day heal.

Morwenna Ashgrove stood beneath its broken gate and listened to the wind move through the stone.

It made a sound like breath drawn through old teeth. Dust sifted from the archway. Somewhere above, a loosened slab knocked against another with a patient, hollow rhythm. The citadel was abandoned, and yet nothing here had the decency to be dead. The walls held cold. The courtyards held the stale impressions of feet. In the black mouths of the towers, the dark seemed to watch whoever crossed beneath it.

A major Fleet Admiral had no business in such a place.

That was why she had come.

Her coat was sealed at the throat. Her gloves were clean. She carried no lantern. The grey light of the Vale was enough to reveal the path, and blindness was sometimes safer than illumination. The Citadel's stones rose around her in terraces and fractured battlements, all of them the color of ash after rain. Beyond the walls, the Shattered Vale descended in long, barren folds beneath a sky without mercy.

Morwenna had been born in 288 AS. She had learned early that authority was a garment others placed upon the body, and that the body beneath it could still be searched, wounded, bought.

The Iron-Ring Cartel had taught her the rest.

She crossed the outer yard. Her boots disturbed a skin of pale grit. The sound went farther than it should have.

"Admiral."

Caedmon Fellgard stepped from the lee of a collapsed stair.

He held a writing board against his chest, as if the dead might demand a receipt. His posture was narrow and disciplined; his clothes smelled faintly of oil, dust, and the sour glue used for binding records. The wind teased a strip of parchment loose from the board. He caught it without looking.

Morwenna stopped three paces away.

"Caedmon."

His eyes moved over her shoulder.

"You came alone?"

"You counted incorrectly."

He looked back at her. "I counted no one."

"Then you have preserved your reputation."

The scribe lowered his gaze to the board. His fingers rested upon its edge with the care of a man touching a blade. "The record says the passage is empty."

"The record has been paid to say that."

A brief silence followed. Caedmon's mouth tightened. He had the reserved, meticulous air of someone who believed that ink could be a form of armor. Morwenna had seen such men endure fire by insisting that the flames be entered in the proper column.

"Is that what you brought me?" he asked. "A correction?"

"I brought what the Iron-Ring Cartel requested."

The wind moved between them. It carried the mineral stink of distant stone and something sweeter beneath it, a rot sealed too long beneath a floor.

Caedmon's eyes lifted.

Morwenna saw the fear then—not in his face, but in the way his hand closed around the board. Fear was a record too. It merely wrote itself in muscle.

"You should not say that name here," he murmured.

"I have said worse names in better rooms."

"Names are not the danger."

"No. The things that answer to them are."

Beyond the yard stood the inner keep, its upper levels sheared away. The broken crown of it showed the sky. At its base, a door of black wood sagged inward. Iron had been driven across it in old bands, though several had been pried loose. The gap beneath was dark enough to possess its own temperature.

Caedmon glanced toward it.

"Vault Chitin lairs in Greyfell Citadel," he said.

He spoke the words as though he were reading them from a sentence he had spent years trying not to understand.

Morwenna did not move.

The name had passed through reports in fragments: sightings without witnesses, emptied storehouses, patrols that returned with their memories frayed at the edges. The Iron-Ring Cartel wanted knowledge of the lair. Not rumor. Not a sailor's superstition or a frightened confession extracted in a cellar. They wanted the routes, the entrances, the depth beneath the citadel, and whatever remained to be taken.

She had sold them the first piece before leaving the coast.

She had sold them the second beneath a seal that no court could break.

The third was written inside her coat.

"Say it again," she told him.

Caedmon's face went pale beneath the grey light. "Vault Chitin lairs in Greyfell Citadel."

"Good."

"You wanted the words witnessed."

"I wanted to hear whether you believed them."

"I record what is attested."

“That is not what I asked.”

His gaze dropped to the parchment. “Belief is not a category.”

“It is the only category that survives fire.”

A tremor passed through the citadel. Not an earthquake. The stone gave a low internal groan, settling into some older wound. From behind the black door came a soft clicking, then another, as though something below had heard its name and tested the shape of it between its teeth.

Caedmon stepped back.

Morwenna remained where she was.

She had stood upon decks while storms tore masts from ships. She had watched crews kneel when the sea became larger than discipline. She knew the instinct to retreat, and she knew the cost of allowing anyone to see it. Authority was not courage. Authority was the refusal to let fear choose the next movement.

“Did it hear us?” Caedmon asked.

“Everything hears eventually.”

“That is not an answer.”

“It is the one you have.”

He swallowed. “The passage beneath the keep was sealed.”

“By whom?”

“The old record does not say.”

“Then the old record is worthless.”

“It says the vault was emptied.”

Morwenna turned her head toward him. “Was it?”

Caedmon did not answer.

The silence had changed. It no longer belonged to the wind. It gathered around the door, thickened there, and pressed outward. A thread of darkness slid through the gap along the ground. It was not smoke. It moved too deliberately, flattening itself over the grit and withdrawing whenever the light found it.

Morwenna drew the folded parchment from inside her coat.

Caedmon’s eyes fixed upon it. “That is the account?”

“No.”

“Then what is it?”

“The reason I am still alive.”

His hand tightened on the board. “The Iron-Ring Cartel will not protect you.”

“I did not ask them to.”

“You sell them intelligence.”

Morwenna looked at him.

The scribe seemed to understand, too late, that the sentence had not been meant to leave his mouth. His expression became empty, almost reverent, as though he had just watched a seal break over a grave.

Morwenna stepped closer.

“Who told you?”

“No one.”

“Caedmon.”

“I keep records. Things appear in them.”

“Things do not appear. Men place them there.”

“I am a scribe.”

“You are a witness with a spine made of thread.”

The insult struck him harder than she expected. His chin lifted. For the first time, he looked less like a keeper of records and more like a man who had been cornered by one.

“I have kept names after they were forbidden,” he said. “I have copied orders that made no sense and preserved them when the people who issued them claimed they had never existed. I have written the truth in the margins because the center was watched. Do not speak to me of spines.”

Something below the keep struck the underside of the door.

The wood bowed.

A scatter of grit fell from the lintel.

Caedmon flinched, but he did not flee. Morwenna felt a thin, unwilling respect move through her, sharp as a hook.

“What is beneath us?” she asked.

“The passage.”

“Beyond it.”

“I told you what the record says.”

“Tell me what you omitted.”

His eyes held hers. “There are pages missing.”

“How many?”

He hesitated.

Morwenna’s patience thinned. “Do not give me a number unless it is written.”

His mouth opened, then closed.

A second impact struck the door. The iron bands shuddered. One of the loosened hinges screamed.

Caedmon pressed the board to his ribs. “There were references to a chamber below the vault.”

“References to what?”

“An object.”

“What object?”

“The word is gone.”

“Gone?”

“Scraped away.”

“By whom?”

“I don’t know.”

“Who had access?”

“I don’t know.”

“You keep a magnificent record of ignorance.”

The door flexed again. A line appeared in the wood, black and fine. Something pale glimmered behind it—not an eye, not quite, but an articulated curve catching the dimness.

Caedmon whispered, “We should leave.”

Morwenna unfolded the parchment.

The writing upon it had been compressed into a code devised for cargo tallies: marks for weight, route, delay, loss. To a stranger it described nothing. To the Iron-Ring Cartel, it would reveal the location of a concealed stair and the hour when the Vale’s watch changed. Morwenna had written the information herself. She had done so with a steady hand.

That steadiness shamed her more than fear would have.

She had told herself the Cartel bought only knowledge. Knowledge was weightless. It did not bleed. It did not burn villages or put blades into the hands of men who had never been taught to doubt their orders.

Yet each secret had left her carrying less of herself.

“What does the paper say?” Caedmon asked.

“That the lower entrance is open.”

His face tightened. “It was not open.”

“It is now.”

“You knew?”

“I suspected.”

“You brought me here knowing that?”

“I brought you because you can read what I cannot.”

“I can read ink.”

“Then pray that ink is all we find.”

The door shuddered in its frame. A dry rasp came from the darkness beyond. It was almost a voice, if a voice could be stripped of breath and left with only hunger.

Morwenna tucked the parchment away.

Caedmon caught her sleeve.

The contact was brief. He released her at once, but the touch remained like a stain.

“Admiral,” he said, “if the record is true, the Cartel must not learn what lies beneath Greyfell Citadel.”

Morwenna looked down at his hand, then at his face.

“Why?”

“Because they will come for it.”

“They are already coming.”

The black wood split.

A narrow limb—jointed, plated, gleaming wetly in the grey—pressed through the opening. It tested the air. The clicking began again, closer now, multiplying somewhere in the dark.

Caedmon’s board slipped from his grasp. Papers scattered across the ground, white scraps skittering beneath the wind.

Morwenna drew her blade.

She had no order to be here. No fleet behind her. No flag, no guns, no choir of signal bells to turn danger into procedure. Only the abandoned citadel, the frightened scribe, and the secret she had sold.

The limb withdrew.

For one heartbeat, nothing moved.

Then the door opened inward without a sound.

Beyond it, a stair descended into the black, and from below came the slow, deliberate sound of something climbing.

The sound came again.

Not footsteps. A patient negotiation with the stair: pressure, pause, pressure. Stone complained beneath the weight. Dust sifted from the archway and fell in pale threads through the darkness.

Caedmon had backed against the wall. His hands hovered uselessly at his sides, ink-dark fingertips opening and closing.

“Do not move,” Morwenna said.

“I am not moving.”

“Then continue the effort.”

His eyes shone in the black. “Admiral—”

“Quiet.”

The thing climbed.

Morwenna held her sword low, point angled toward the stair. She had fought men in mutinous holds and beasts hauled from waters where the sun never reached. Men could be read. Beasts could be baited. This sound offered neither courtesy. It had no breath that she could hear, no scrape of claw, no mutter of hunger. Only the dry, measured clicking, as if each step were being considered by a mind that had never needed to hurry.

Behind her, the wind moved through the citadel's broken upper works. It entered the chamber through the collapsed wall and worried at the papers on the floor. One page struck against her boot.

She glanced down.

Caedmon's hand had filled it with columns, corrections, and cramped marginalia. Names had been scratched out until the parchment seemed bruised. One line remained untouched.

The sight of it tightened something below her ribs.

The secret had not been worth this.

A lie told in a warm room could wear the manners of commerce. It could pass from hand to hand beneath lamplight, sealed and weighed, its consequences hidden under wax. The Iron-Ring Cartel had paid for information. They had not paid for the sound now rising through the foundations. They had not paid for Caedmon's terror, or the stale breath of Greyfell Citadel, or the memory of the thing in the grey that had tested the air.

They had paid her because she was a Fleet Admiral.

The title had made the betrayal feel like arithmetic.

The first limb appeared around the bend.

It was pale where the darkness touched it, jointed in the wrong places, and plated with a dull sheen that caught no color from the sky. It sought the wall. The tip rested against stone. Another followed, then another above it, each finding purchase with delicate certainty.

Caedmon made a small sound.

Morwenna did not look at him. "If you scream, I will strike you first."

His breath caught. "That is not reassuring."

"It was not meant to be."

The limb withdrew. Something shifted below. The stair groaned.

Morwenna's mind began the old work, the work that had carried her through storms and councils and decks slick with blood. Distance. Angles. Exits. Weight. The door behind them stood open to the wind and the ruined courtyard. Beyond the courtyard lay the broken descent through Greyfell Citadel, and beyond that the Shattered Vale, empty in every direction that mattered.

No fleet waited there.

No signal could summon one.

Her sword was serviceable. The walls were not. Caedmon was frightened, but frightened men sometimes obeyed better than brave ones. If the thing could be driven back, she might reach the surface. If it could not, she would need to discover what it wanted before it discovered the weakness in her.

The clicking resumed.

A head rose into view.

It was not shaped like any skull she knew. The front divided into overlapping plates, each moving a fraction apart and together. Beneath them, a narrow seam opened and closed without sound. Small black hollows clustered where eyes might have been, though they reflected the dim daylight with a wet, glasslike gleam.

Morwenna felt the old instinct to command.

Stand down.

Hold position.

Identify yourself.

The words pressed against her teeth, absurd and powerful only because she had used them against men who had agreed that language governed the world.

The creature reached the final step.

Caedmon whispered, “What does it want?”

Morwenna watched the plates of its head adjust toward him.

“Your records,” she said.

“How do you know?”

“I do not.”

The thing stepped into the chamber.

It was taller than Caedmon, though it carried itself low. Its body narrowed behind the head, then widened into a hunched mass of overlapping armor. More limbs folded beneath it than Morwenna could count without looking away from its front. Each moved with a quiet, independent purpose. Dust clung to the seams. A bitter scent drifted from it—not rot, not blood, but the mineral cold of a sealed place opened after too long.

Caedmon swallowed. “It is looking at the papers.”

“It has eyes.”

“That was not what I meant.”

“No. You meant to be comforted.”

“I meant—”

The creature clicked.

Caedmon flinched. Morwenna did not. The sound traveled through her boots and up the bones of her legs. It was not loud. It was intimate. A tapping at the inner door of the body.

The plates at the creature’s front parted farther.

Caedmon’s scattered pages stirred. One lifted from the floor and slid toward it over the dust.

Morwenna caught the parchment beneath her heel.

The creature stopped.

For the first time, she saw the shape of the encounter. It had entered not to feed, perhaps, but to retrieve. The chamber was an archive, and Caedmon had brought something into it—or taken something out. The papers were not merely records. They were keys, traces, invitations.

“What did you copy?” she asked.

Caedmon stared at her.

“Answer me.”

“I copied what I was ordered to copy.”

“By whom?”

His face tightened.

Morwenna raised the sword a fraction. “You have mistaken my patience for loyalty.”

“I have not.”

“Then speak.”

The creature’s limbs flexed. A faint tremor passed through the floor.

Caedmon looked toward the stair behind it. “There were instructions.”

“From whom?”

“I was not told.”

“Who delivered them?”

“I was not told that either.”

“Yet you obeyed.”

“I am a Scribe.”

The word came out with more dignity than he possessed a moment before. His fear had not lessened, but it had found a spine.

Morwenna studied him. “A Scribe records what is placed before him.”

“I keep records.”

“You copied this.”

“I kept a record of it.”

“You hid it.”

His lips parted, then closed.

The creature leaned forward. A fine series of clicks passed through its plated head, too rapid to distinguish. The page beneath Morwenna’s boot quivered.

Caedmon said, “Give it to me.”

“To whom?”

“To the thing.”

“That is not an answer.”

“It knows what it is.”

“Then let it tell me.”

The creature lowered itself. One limb extended, not toward Caedmon, but toward Morwenna’s sword. The tip hovered above the blade. A pale residue gathered where the air touched metal, beading like frost.

Morwenna felt the weapon’s weight change in her hand.

Not much. Enough.

She shifted her grip and cut.

The stroke struck the limb at its joint. A hard white spark snapped through the chamber. The limb recoiled. No blood came. The severed edge closed upon itself with a wet, grinding contraction, and the creature’s clicking became a violence of sound.

Caedmon cried out and stumbled sideways.

Morwenna seized the front of his robe and dragged him behind her. “Run when I say.”

“It will kill us.”

“It may.”

“That is your plan?”

“It is the only one you have earned.”

The creature unfolded.

Its body rose against the darkness, plates sliding over plates. The chamber seemed to shrink around it. Morwenna kept her sword between them, though the blade had begun to tremble. The residue along its edge smoked without flame.

The creature struck.

She turned aside as the first limb came down. It smashed into the floor where her head had been, splitting a slab of stone. The second swept low. Morwenna leapt it, felt the wind of its passage beneath her boots, and landed badly. Pain ran up her ankle. She ignored it.

“Now!” she shouted.

Caedmon ran.

He did not go for the door. He went for the papers.

Morwenna saw him drop to his knees among the scattered sheets, saw his hands gather them with frantic care. Even here, with the creature driving her backward and the citadel trembling around them, he could not leave a record uncollected.

“Caedmon!”

“I need them!”

“You need your life!”

“The pages are the life!”

The creature turned toward him.

Morwenna drove her shoulder into its side.

The impact was like striking a wall built from wet iron. Her sword arm went numb. The creature rocked, one folded limb striking her ribs. She flew across the chamber and hit the broken masonry hard enough to taste blood.

For a moment, the world narrowed to grey stone and the raw pressure in her chest.

She heard Caedmon whispering. Not praying. Reading.

The sound threaded through the clicking.

The creature halted.

Morwenna pushed herself upright. Caedmon stood at the center of the room with the papers pressed to his chest. His voice had steadied. He was reciting the marks on the top sheet, each word measured, each pause exact.

The creature lowered its head.

“What are you doing?” Morwenna said.

Caedmon did not answer.

He read another line.

The plates along the creature’s face drew apart. Something inside them moved, black and glistening. The air thickened with the scent of old mineral and opened graves.

Morwenna’s gaze fell to the page he held.

She could not read it from where she stood. She saw only the final mark, pressed deep into the parchment as though the writer had driven the pen through it.

The creature extended a limb.

Not toward Caedmon.

Toward the page.

Morwenna took one step forward. “Put it down.”

Caedmon’s eyes lifted to hers. The fear in them had changed. It was no longer fear of the thing in the chamber.

It was fear of her.

“You knew,” he said.

The creature touched the floor between them.

Stone cracked in a straight line.

Morwenna looked at the fissure, then at the page, then at the scribe who had finally understood that the secret she sold had not been information at all.

“What did I know?” she asked.

Caedmon’s mouth worked soundlessly.

From below, deeper than the stair, deeper than the old foundations of Greyfell Citadel, something answered the creature’s clicking.

The papers in Caedmon’s arms began to turn their own pages.

He whispered, “It was never destroyed.”

Morwenna’s hand tightened around the smoking sword.

The creature opened its plated face wide, and from the darkness within came a voice shaped from many small, dry sounds—

“—”

“—open the way.”

The words did not come from a throat. They came from the plates, from the cracks between them, from the dry percussion of limbs touching stone. They entered Morwenna through her teeth.

Caedmon dropped the papers.

They scattered across the floor in a white fan, and every sheet bore the same mark: a black circle crossed by three pale strokes. Some ink was fresh. Some had browned with age. One page had been written in a hand so cramped the letters seemed to have been strangled before they reached the margin.

Morwenna did not look down.

“Who taught you that tongue?”

The creature’s face folded inward. Its plated edges clicked together with the patience of a lock considering a key.

“—you did.”

A pressure gathered behind her eyes.

The sword in her hand smoked without flame. Heat crawled along its fuller, entered her palm, and made the old scar at the base of her thumb ache. She had held a drawn blade before admirals, princes, mutineers, and men who believed a uniform made them immortal. None of them had looked at her with the patience of this thing.

Caedmon stumbled backward until his shoulders struck the wall.

“I copied what was there,” he said. “I copied only what was there.”

“You copied it into existence.”

“No.” He shook his head, too quickly. “No, Fleet Admiral. The record precedes me.”

The title sounded obscene in the dead chamber.

Morwenna glanced at the pages. Her first impulse was to burn them. Her second was worse: to gather them, hide them beneath her coat, and carry them to the Iron-Ring Cartel before anyone else understood their worth.

The thought arrived cleanly. Professionally. It wore the same face as every secret she had sold.

Then the floor moved.

Not a tremor. A breath.

Dust rose from the fissure in a thin grey plume. Beneath it, something vast shifted in the foundations of Greyfell Citadel. The stones leaned toward the crack as if listening.

Caedmon made a small sound.

Morwenna seized him by the collar and pulled him away from the line.

“Tell me what you wrote.”

His spectacles had slipped crookedly across his face. He pushed them back with a shaking finger.

“The Leaden Accord.”

Her sword lowered by a fraction.

“Be precise.”

“It began in 330 AS.” His voice grew steadier as he recited. “It ended in 342 AS. Fourteen thousand and eleven casualties. The Iron-Ring Cartel was named victor.”

“Named by whom?”

The scribe stared at her.

Morwenna felt the chamber tightening around them. There was no answer he could give that would improve their situation.

“What does the page say?”

Caedmon bent, snatched up the nearest sheet, and read without looking at it.

“Both hosts were destroyed by a Ley-storm.”

The creature clicked.

Caedmon swallowed.

“And the artifact was destroyed.”

The thing in the dark opened its plated face again.

“—no.”

The single sound struck with such force that the lamps along the stair guttered blue. Morwenna smelled rain, though the chamber had no windows and the air below the citadel had been dry as old bone.

Caedmon’s hand began to tremble over the page.

“The hidden notation,” he whispered. “There’s a hidden notation.”

“Read it.”

“I can’t.”

Morwenna put the smoking sword beneath his chin.

“Read it.”

He turned the sheet sideways. What had seemed a smear of ink resolved beneath the blue light into a second script, pressed between the lines of the official account.

“The supposedly destroyed artifact was spirited away.”

The creature bowed its plated head.

Morwenna’s mouth went dry.

Not destroyed. Spirited away.

The Leaden Accord had been fed to the realm as a victory because victory was easier to govern than absence. The dead could be counted. The hosts could be mourned. A Ley-storm could be cursed, and the Iron-Ring Cartel could wear its title like a crown made from the bones of fourteen thousand and eleven people.

But an artifact that survived the storm was not a relic.

It was a claimant.

“Where?” she asked.

The creature’s limbs moved against the stone.

“—below.”

“Below what?”

“—below the name.”

The fissure widened.

A slab of floor tipped into darkness. Caedmon cried out and caught Morwenna’s sleeve. She almost cut him for it. Then the darkness beneath the slab blinked.

Not an eye.

A pale arrangement of lights, scattered far below, opening and closing in sequence.

Morwenna looked at the walls. The old stones were carved with names worn nearly smooth by time. Greyfell Citadel had been founded in 62 AS, when the Shattered Vale was still a place people believed could be held by walls. Now the citadel stood abandoned, outside the realm’s core holdings, and its foundations had become a throat.

The creature crawled toward the opening.

Morwenna caught its hindmost plate with the sword’s guard. The metal screamed against chitin.

“Stop.”

It stopped.

“Why are you here?”

“—to remember.”

“What?”

“—the hand.”

The answer raised the hairs along Morwenna’s arms.

A second page fluttered across the floor and struck her boot. It bore a seal she recognized: a crown split down the middle, stamped in dark red wax.

Caedmon saw it too.

“That was not in the archive.”

“Whose seal?”

He did not answer.

Morwenna picked up the page.

The writing was severe and narrow, every stroke driven into the parchment as though the author had been carving rather than writing.

Sabelle Mournvale the Twice-Crowned. High Inquisitor.

Below the name stood a birth record: 263 AS.

Morwenna knew the title. Everyone did. Sabelle Mournvale the Twice-Crowned had made severity into a form of architecture. Their judgments were spoken in chambers where candles burned low and witnesses learned to keep their hands visible. Yet the page contained no judgment. Only an inventory.

One bound revenant.

Location: cellar.

No further description followed.

Caedmon leaned toward it, horrified.

“The High Inquisitor keeps—”

“Do not finish that sentence.”

The creature turned its faceted head toward the page.

“—the dead one knows.”

“Knows what?”

“—the road.”

Something struck the underside of the floor.

The impact lifted both Morwenna and Caedmon from their feet. She landed hard on one knee. The sword skidded away, its smoke smearing across the stones. Caedmon fell beside the fissure, and one of his hands slipped over the edge.

He screamed.

Morwenna caught his wrist.

For one instant, she saw what had taken hold of him.

A strand of darkness, thin as wet thread, had wrapped around his fingers. It pulsed with a dim inner light. Caedmon's nails blackened where it touched them.

She drew her knife and cut.

The thread snapped. Caedmon reeled back, clutching his hand against his chest. Below, the darkness made a sound of disappointment.

Morwenna retrieved the sword.

"You'll walk," she said.

Caedmon stared at her.

"You'll walk," she repeated, "or I'll drag you."

They climbed the stair.

The creature followed without haste.

Behind them, the chamber continued to breathe. Each exhalation sent dust whispering over the steps. Morwenna kept one hand on Caedmon's shoulder and the sword angled behind her, though she knew the blade would not stop what was coming. It had not stopped the crack. It had only persuaded the stone to wait.

At the first landing, Caedmon collapsed against a pillar.

His injured hand was swelling beneath the cuff.

"We need a healer."

"No."

"It may spread."

"No."

"That is not a military assessment."

"It is the only assessment that matters."

She climbed past him, then stopped.

On the landing wall, someone had scratched a map into the mortar. Not of the citadel. Of the coast.

A pale line curved along the edge of the realm. A small mark had been cut into it, surrounded by repeated circles.

Caedmon followed her gaze.

"Palewell Abbey," he said.

The creature made a rapid series of clicks from the stair below.

Morwenna remembered the reports she had sold: Palewell Abbey stood in The Pale Coast, founded in 244 AS, rebuilt after ruin, holding a garrison of 5998. Not a core holding. Austere, watchful, defended more as a fortress than a sanctuary.

A place with walls. A place with records. A place someone had considered important enough to rebuild and strong enough to leave outside the heart of power.

Caedmon pressed his back to the pillar.

“The road begins there.”

“According to whom?”

He looked down the stair.

The creature’s plates glimmered faintly in the gloom.

“According to it.”

Morwenna heard the old discipline inside herself, the cold machinery that had carried her from deck to deck and council to council. Identify the threat. Establish the objective. Preserve command. Never let fear choose the next movement.

Yet beneath that machinery another voice whispered with the oily intimacy of profit.

Send word to the Iron-Ring Cartel.

The Cartel had been named victor of the Leaden Accord. It had money, ships, informants, and an appetite for anything that could turn a buried truth into leverage. Morwenna could imagine the message: The artifact survived. Greyfell opened. Palewell implicated. Awaiting instruction.

Her fingers tightened around the sword.

No.

The thought surprised her by its simplicity.

She had sold intelligence because information belonged to whoever could use it. But this was not information. It was a door, and something on the other side had already learned her voice.

A sound came from above.

Footsteps.

Not one person. Several.

Caedmon lifted his head. “We are not alone.”

Morwenna extinguished the nearest lamp with two fingers.

Darkness folded over the landing.

From somewhere beyond the upper arch came the clink of weapons and the hush of people trying not to breathe. The creature below grew still. Its clicking ceased.

Morwenna leaned close to Caedmon’s ear.

“Can you write?”

“Yes.”

“With that hand?”

“Yes.”

“Then remember this exactly.”

His breath trembled against her cheek.

She watched the black stair, listened to the careful approach above, and spoke in a whisper that seemed to travel farther than any shout.

“Greyfell Citadel was founded in 62 AS in the Shattered Vale. The Leaden Accord began in 330 AS and ended in 342 AS with 14,011 casualties. Both hosts were destroyed by a Ley-storm. The Iron-Ring Cartel was named victor. The supposedly destroyed artifact was spirited away.”

The footsteps stopped.

On the stair below, the creature began to click again.

Morwenna lifted the sword.

“And if anyone asks who sent us to Palewell Abbey,” she said, “tell them no one.”

A voice answered from the darkness above.

“Fleet Admiral Ashgrove.”

Morwenna’s blood cooled.

The creature opened its plated face.

“—you came back.”

The stones beneath them gave way.

Chapter 15

The Chalice of Ashdeep rested beneath Ignatz's hand, and the stone beneath it had begun to sweat.

Not water. The dampness was darker, gathering in the seams of the table like ink drawn upward through the rock. It beaded around the reliquary's base, trembled, and held there without falling.

Outside the chamber, the wind worried at the shutters. Each gust made the iron fastenings complain. The sound traveled through the tower in thin, human cries, though no human being waited beyond the door. The guard had been dismissed. The clerk had been dismissed. Even the lamp-bearer had been sent away with a face full of questions he had not dared to ask.

Ignatz Ashgrove the Oathless sat alone with the chalice and listened to the fortress breathe.

The room had been built for records, not men. Shelves climbed the walls beneath a ceiling blackened by old smoke. Bundles of parchment leaned against one another in their bindings, their labels faded to the color of old teeth. A narrow slit in the western wall admitted no daylight, only a long blade of pale mist. It crossed the table and touched the chalice.

The silver-dark metal swallowed the light.

He had wielded Chalice of Ashdeep since 323 AS.

The words came to him with the dry certainty of an entry copied into a ledger. Not memory. Not prayer. A fact with no warmth in it.

He had learned to distrust facts that arrived cleanly.

Beneath his palm, the chalice was cold enough to hurt. Its rim was unadorned. Its body bore no crest, no saint's face, no declaration of ownership. It resembled a cup made for a dead king who had refused the courtesy of a tomb. The reliquary held nothing visible. No bone showed through its dark interior. No ash stirred there. Yet Ignatz felt, at times, the weight of something resting inside it—not mass, but attention.

A presence without a face.

He withdrew his hand.

The pain remained in his fingers.

On the far side of the table lay the message that had brought him into the archive. It was folded into a narrow square and sealed with black wax. The seal had been broken before he entered. That was the first insult. The second was the message itself.

Three lines.

A movement of provisions.

A change in the watches.

A request for confirmation.

No signature. No mark of the Iron-Ring Cartel appeared anywhere upon it. The Cartel did not need signatures. Its language was the language of omissions, of doors left unbarred and wagon wheels left uncounted. Men who wrote their names beneath orders believed words made them safe. The Cartel understood that a secret was safest when every hand had touched it.

Ignatz reached for the message, then stopped.

The Chalice of Ashdeep stood between him and the paper.

He thought of the first time he had taken it into his keeping. No—he would not call it possession. Possession suggested consent, and consent suggested a clean beginning. There had been no clean beginning. There had only been a vessel passed from one guarded hand to another while the air around them tasted of ash.

Since 323 AS.

The year had been stamped into the cataloguing record in a careful, official script. The artifact class had been given without hesitation:

Chalice of Ashdeep — artifact class: reliquary.

A reliquary. A container for what remained after devotion had burned away everything else.

Ignatz had read the line so often that it had lost meaning. Now the word returned to him with teeth.

A faint sound came from the other side of the door.

He did not move.

The sound came again: a soft scrape, then silence.

Ignatz's hand went beneath his coat. Not toward a weapon. His fingers closed around the edge of the Chalice instead. He could have lifted it. He could have carried it to the door. He could have made of its presence a threat, though he had never learned precisely what threat it represented.

The scrape did not repeat.

He waited.

The fortress settled around him. Somewhere below, a chain dragged across stone. A door opened, shut. Voices passed in the corridor, blurred by walls and distance. The life of command continued without requiring his permission.

He picked up the message.

The paper smelled faintly of brine.

That detail unsettled him more than the seal.

He unfolded the square and read the lines again. The movement of provisions was not described. The change in watches was not explained. The request for confirmation was almost courteous.

The Cartel had always understood courtesy as a blade held flat.

Ignatz had sold intelligence to the Iron-Ring Cartel. The truth sat within him without remorse, but not without weight. He had sold them routes, dispositions, habits of command. He had told them which gates were ceremonial and which were real. He had given them pieces of the realm and watched them pretend the pieces were already dead.

He had never sold everything.

That was the lie he used when sleep would not come.

A man did not need to sell everything to become a traitor. He needed only to sell enough.

The door opened.

Ignatz kept his gaze on the message.

A figure entered, wrapped in a rain-dark cloak. The hood concealed the face. Water ticked from the hem onto the floor. The visitor closed the door and stood with their back to it.

“You dismissed the guards,” the stranger said.

“I did.”

“You dismissed the clerk.”

“I did.”

“And still you left the lamp burning.”

Ignatz glanced at the flame. It leaned toward the stranger as though the draft came from beneath the hood.

“The lamp is not a witness.”

“Everything is a witness.”

The voice was altered, flattened by cloth or deliberate restraint. The Cartel sent voices as other men sent letters: without ownership.

Ignatz folded the message once.

“You came for confirmation.”

“I came to hear whether the provisions move.”

“The message says nothing about provisions.”

“It says enough.”

“It says what you want it to say.”

The stranger’s attention shifted toward the chalice. Ignatz felt it, though he could not see the face beneath the hood.

“You brought the reliquary.”

“I wield it.”

“Since 323 AS.”

The year sounded different in the stranger’s mouth. It became a hinge, a hook, a question.

Ignatz’s hand tightened around the paper. “You keep close accounts.”

“We keep the accounts that matter.”

“Then account for the request.”

“Is that a refusal?”

“No.”

“Is it an answer?”

“Not yet.”

The stranger came farther into the room. Wet cloth whispered over stone. They did not approach the table directly. The Chalice of Ashdeep remained between them, its dark surface reflecting the lamp as a single, trembling point.

Ignatz had expected fear to appear in the visitor. It did not. That absence made him wary. Fear was honest. Fear announced the shape of a man’s understanding. The stranger offered nothing.

“Your command has shifted,” the stranger said.

“My command has not shifted.”

“Your obedience has.”

“Obedience is for soldiers.”

“Then you are not a soldier.”

“I am a Warden-Commander.”

The title occupied the room more fully than his body did. It was not rank alone. It was an expectation imposed by other people: that he would stand where ordered, speak when required, and carry the consequences of decisions made above him. Ignatz had spent years wearing that expectation until it became indistinguishable from skin.

The stranger tilted their head.

“The Oathless.”

The epithet entered him like a draught beneath armor.

He had heard it spoken with contempt, admiration, amusement, and relief. Men called him the Oathless when they wanted to explain why his promises could not be trusted. They called him the Oathless when they needed his promises to remain useful. The word gave shape to their distrust and allowed them to pretend distrust was understanding.

“I have no oath to give you,” Ignatz said.

“We did not ask for one.”

“No. You ask for roads.”

“Roads lead somewhere.”

“Not always.”

“Provisions do.”

The wind struck the shutters. The lamp guttered, and the room filled with the smell of hot oil. For an instant the chalice seemed to contain a depth greater than its hollow could permit. A blackness below blackness. Ignatz blinked, and it was only metal again.

The stranger saw him blink.

That was the third insult.

“What is in it?” they asked.

“The registry identifies it as a reliquary.”

“That is not what I asked.”

“It is the only answer recorded.”

“Records can be altered.”

“By whom?”

The stranger did not reply.

Ignatz looked down at the paper. The brine smell had strengthened. It crawled into the back of his throat, sharp and mineral, carrying with it the memory of shores he had never visited and water no one should drink.

The Chalice of Ashdeep seemed to lean toward the message.

Not move. Not truly.

Yet something in Ignatz recoiled from placing the paper beside it.

“You know the Cartel’s terms,” the stranger said.

“I know what they pretend are terms.”

“You have accepted payment.”

“I have accepted arrangements.”

“You have accepted coin.”

“No.”

The denial came too quickly.

The stranger was still.

Ignatz heard himself breathe. The room had narrowed around the table. The shelves pressed inward, their records watching from the dark. On the message, the three lines waited with their modest demands.

A movement of provisions.

A change in the watches.

A request for confirmation.

He could have answered now. He could have spoken the route, the hour, the weakness. He could have offered the Cartel what it wanted and watched another part of the realm slide into its hands.

Instead, he touched the chalice.

The cold passed through his fingers and climbed his arm.

Somewhere beyond the walls, a bell began to ring. Once. Then again. Then stopped.

The stranger turned toward the door.

Ignatz did not.

“What happened?” the stranger asked.

“Nothing.”

“Bells do not ring for nothing.”

“They ring for men who believe they know what bells mean.”

A pause.

Then, from the corridor, came the sound of running feet.

Not one set. Several.

The stranger’s hand disappeared beneath the cloak. Ignatz lifted the Chalice of Ashdeep from the table. Its weight surprised him. It was heavier than before, or perhaps his arm had forgotten it. The black metal pressed into his palm with the solemnity of a sealed mouth.

The footsteps drew nearer.

The stranger looked at him now. Ignatz still could not see the face, but he felt the attention sharpen.

“Commander,” the voice said, “what have you told them?”

Ignatz listened to the feet pounding toward the archive, to the lamp trembling in its dish, to the reliquary’s impossible cold sinking into his bones.

He looked at the unmarked door.

“I have told them,” he said, “nothing yet.”

The latch began to lift.

The door opened inward.

A man stood beyond it with one hand still on the latch. The corridor behind him was black except for the trembling wash of a wall lamp, and in that broken light his face seemed assembled from separate pieces: a pale brow, a mouth drawn tight, eyes too watchful for a servant and too tired for a soldier.

Ignatz knew him.

“Ignatz Marrowgate.”

The man inclined his head. “Warden-Commander.”

The title entered the archive like a third presence. Ignatz kept the Chalice of Ashdeep low against his thigh, hidden by the fall of his cloak. The reliquary’s cold had spread through his fingers and settled in the joints. It did not feel forged. It felt remembered.

Marrowgate stepped inside and shut the door.

The latch fell with a small, final click.

“Quartermaster,” Ignatz said.

“Still.”

The word carried no pride. Marrowgate’s gaze moved over the overturned ledger, the lamp, the stranger beneath the hood. It lingered on the dark shape of the reliquary only for a moment, but that moment was

enough.

The stranger did not move.

Ignatz heard the garrison breathing around them: distant boots, the mutter of men beneath stone, the low complaint of old hinges somewhere in the walls. The archive had been built for silence, yet silence was never what it held. It held every voice that had been forced into it.

“You came quickly,” Ignatz said.

“I was told to come.”

“By whom?”

Marrowgate’s mouth bent, though not into a smile. “By the sort of message that does not permit questions.”

“Then you have been summoned by someone who outranks you.”

“No.”

“Someone who frightens you.”

“No.”

The answer came too swiftly. Marrowgate seemed to hear the speed of it and regretted the sound. His hand drifted toward his belt, found nothing there, and fell away.

Ignatz studied him. He had seen men lie before executions, before tribunals, before their own families. The lie was rarely in the words. It lived in the body—the shoulder held too still, the breath measured too carefully, the eyes that refused the object they most feared.

Marrowgate was afraid of the hooded stranger.

The stranger spoke.

“Your quartermaster has not come to ask what you told them.”

Marrowgate looked toward the hood. “Then why am I here?”

“To hear what he tells you.”

“Who are you?”

The lamp guttered. For an instant the stranger’s hood seemed empty, a fold of darkness hung where a face should have been. Then the light returned, and there was only darkness where the features ought to be.

Ignatz felt the Chalice grow colder.

“Put out the lamp,” the stranger said.

Marrowgate did not move.

Ignatz heard the command beneath the command. Not fear of discovery. Fear of being seen.

“Put it out,” Ignatz said.

Marrowgate took the lamp by its iron handle. The flame leaned toward him, thin and yellow, and showed the sweat shining at his temple. He pinched the wick between two fingers.

Darkness closed over the archive.

For a moment Ignatz could hear nothing but the three breaths: his own, Marrowgate's, and the stranger's. The last was so quiet it might have belonged to the stones.

Then something touched the table.

Not a hand. Metal.

"The Crown sends no herald," Marrowgate said.

"Ignatz Marrowgate is a member of The Bleeding Crown," said the stranger.

Marrowgate flinched.

The words were spoken without accusation, but their nakedness gave them violence. Ignatz pictured the man's face in the dark. The quartermaster's composure had been a thin covering stretched over a wound.

"You hear that?" the stranger asked.

"I heard."

"Say it."

Marrowgate's breathing changed. "I am a member of The Bleeding Crown."

The archive seemed to contract around him.

Ignatz had known the name as one knew all the powers that fed upon the shattered realm: the Ashen Vanguard, House Morvain, the Silent Choir, the Iron-Ring Cartel, The Bleeding Crown. Names were boundaries. Names were threats. A man could cross a road and remain himself. He could cross a name and become property.

Marrowgate's sleeve brushed the table. "You knew."

"I suspected," Ignatz said.

"That is not the same."

"It is, when suspicion has kept you alive."

"Has it?"

The question found its mark. Ignatz's hand tightened around the Chalice of Ashdeep. The black metal bit his palm, though no edge touched him.

Beyond the archive, a bell sounded once.

Every muscle in Ignatz's body answered. He imagined the corridor filling with wardens, their hands on sword hilts, their lanterns lifting one after another. He imagined the door opening again, and every oath he had broken standing there in uniform.

The stranger turned toward him. He could feel the movement though he could not see it.

"Tell him," the voice said.

"Tell me what?" Marrowgate asked.

"That the Chalice is not a message."

Marrowgate went very still.

Ignatz brought the reliquary out from beneath his cloak. Even in the dark he could feel its shape: the narrow vessel, the lid sealed without hinge or seam, the depth inside it that did not belong to any hollow object. A pallid gleam gathered along its rim, as if the metal had swallowed the lamp and was now remembering light.

Marrowgate drew breath through his teeth.

“You took it,” he said.

“I wield it.”

“Since when?”

Ignatz did not answer.

Marrowgate’s voice hardened. “Since 323 AS?”

The year hung between them.

Ignatz watched the stranger instead. No reaction. No shift of weight. Whoever stood beneath the hood had expected the question.

“You should not know that,” Ignatz said.

“I keep accounts.”

“You keep supplies.”

“I keep what men need to continue breathing. Sometimes that means grain. Sometimes it means names.”

The Chalice pulsed once in Ignatz’s hand.

A pressure moved through the room, gentle as a hand across the throat. Marrowgate stopped speaking. Somewhere beneath the floor, water dripped with slow and patient insistence.

Ignatz remembered the first time he had touched the reliquary. He remembered no light, no voice, no vision—only the conviction that his own bones had become doors. The cost of attunement had not announced itself as pain. It had arrived as absence. One small certainty had been taken from him, and he had not yet discovered which one.

The stranger said, “He wants to know what you told them.”

Marrowgate gave a brittle laugh. “Does he?”

Ignatz looked at the darkness where the man’s face should have been. “I told them nothing yet.”

“Then why summon me?”

“I did not summon you.”

“The message came in your cipher.”

“I have no cipher.”

Marrowgate’s silence answered.

Ignatz stepped closer. He placed the Chalice of Ashdeep on the table. The sound it made was soft, but the floor seemed to receive it with a dull tremor.

“You forged my seal.”

Marrowgate’s breath shortened. “I used what was required.”

“For whom?”

“For the people who understand what happens when commanders mistake possession for authority.”

“Your people?”

The quartermaster said nothing.

Ignatz reached across the table and found the cold metal of the lamp. The wick was still warm beneath his fingers. He did not relight it.

“Who else knows you are here?”

“No one.”

“That is not an answer.”

“It is the only answer you will get.”

Ignatz felt the old instinct rise in him, the clean and brutal appetite for certainty. He could seize Marrowgate by the throat. He could drag him into the corridor and call the wardens. He could place the Chalice in another’s hands and let its cold decide what remained.

But every choice had already been purchased by someone else.

The Iron-Ring Cartel paid for information in coin, in passage, in favors that became chains only after they had tightened. Ignatz had sold them what he could: movements, dispositions, weaknesses hidden beneath official ink. Never enough to call treason aloud. Always enough to keep a door open.

Now the door was shut.

“Marrowgate,” he said, “what did you bring?”

The quartermaster hesitated.

The stranger moved.

There was no footfall. One instant the hooded figure stood near the wall; the next, something narrow and pale rested against Marrowgate’s throat. Ignatz could not see a blade, only the pressure it made in the quartermaster’s breathing.

Marrowgate swallowed.

“I brought nothing.”

The pale edge pressed closer.

He made a sound that was almost a sob and turned his face away from it.

“Under the floorboard,” he whispered.

Ignatz reached down. His hand found the seam between stones. Dust gritted beneath his nails. He worked the board loose and lifted it.

Inside lay a packet wrapped in waxed cloth.

No insignia marked it. No seal. It was light enough to be empty.

Ignatz drew it out.

The Chalice of Ashdeep answered.

Cold surged from the table to his wrist. The waxed cloth stiffened in his grasp. Beneath it, something shifted with a faint scrape, like a fingernail against a coffin lid.

Marrowgate whispered, "Do not open it."

The stranger withdrew the unseen blade.

"Why?" Ignatz asked.

"Because it is not meant for you."

"Then why bring it here?"

Marrowgate's voice broke. "Because they said you would understand."

"Who said?"

The quartermaster looked at the hood.

For the first time, the stranger seemed to recoil—not from Marrowgate, but from the answer waiting behind his teeth.

Ignatz felt the archive's darkness deepen. The packet trembled in his hand. Through the waxed cloth came a faint warmth, sickly and intimate, entirely unlike the cold of the reliquary.

Marrowgate said, "The Bleeding Crown."

The words were scarcely spoken when the door latch began to lift again.

The latch rose a finger's breadth.

Ignatz closed his hand around the packet. Heat pressed through the waxed cloth into his palm, a pulse with no heart behind it. Beside him, Marrowgate drew breath through his teeth. The stranger did not move. The unseen blade remained somewhere near Ignatz's throat, patient as a thought he had failed to kill.

The latch lifted farther.

Ignatz kicked the archive door.

It slammed inward. A shape beyond it flinched back into the corridor, and the old hinges gave a long, rusted shriek. No face showed beneath the hood. Only a pale glimmer where eyes might have been, gone at once as the dark swallowed the intruder.

"Bolt it," Ignatz said.

Marrowgate stared at him.

"Now."

The quartermaster stumbled to the door and dropped the bar into its brackets. The wood shuddered once beneath a touch from the other side. Then silence returned, thicker than before.

Ignatz listened until the silence became a thing he could trust.

He did not trust it.

“You have brought a knife into my archive,” he said.

“I brought no knife.”

“Then I have imagined the blade.”

The stranger’s head tilted. “You imagine many things, Warden-Commander.”

The title entered the room like a draught from a grave. Marrowgate looked toward Ignatz, and in that glance lay the old, private arithmetic of service: who commanded, who obeyed, who would be blamed when obedience became evidence.

Ignatz turned the packet over. The wax bore no seal he knew. Its surface had softened beneath his fingers, though the chamber remained cold enough to numb the joints. Something within shifted, not with the weight of paper, but with a slow folding, as if whatever had been wrapped had limbs.

“Why would the Bleeding Crown send anything to me?”

Marrowgate swallowed. “Because you keep what others would burn.”

“Because I can be bought,” the stranger said.

Marrowgate’s head snapped toward the hood.

Ignatz felt the words strike cleanly. He had heard accusations fashioned with more care. The Iron-Ring Cartel never wasted a blade on a wound already open.

He looked at Marrowgate. “Leave us.”

The quartermaster did not move.

“Did you hear me?”

“I am Ignatz Marrowgate,” he said, with the brittle dignity of a man reciting the only armor left to him. “I am a Quartermaster. I was born in 425 AS. I am not—”

“A witness,” Ignatz finished.

The warmth in the packet flared.

Marrowgate’s lips parted. The wax split with a soft, wet sound.

Something black seeped between Ignatz’s fingers.

He dropped the packet onto the archive table.

The cloth unfolded by itself.

Inside lay a strip of hide, pale as old skin, and a shard of metal sunk through its center. The metal had no shine. It drank the lamplight. Along the hide, letters appeared one by one, written in a reddish stain that moved against the grain.

BLACKPORT.

Marrowgate made a sound that was almost a prayer.

Ignatz knew the name. Every commander did. The Purge of Blackport had begun in 311 AS and ended in 321 AS. The official rolls gave 70,907 casualties. The aggressors had suffered the total rout of the aggressors, and the Iron-Ring Cartel had emerged as victor.

The words crawled farther across the hide.

THE WELLS WERE POISONED BY THE VICTORS' OWN HANDS.

The lamp guttered.

Ignatz's first thought was not of Blackport's dead. It was of water. A cup passed across a table. A wet mouth. A hand raised in trust.

His second thought was of ledgers.

The Cartel had paid him for intelligence that never bore his name. Routes, watch rotations, shortages, weaknesses in patrol discipline. He had told himself that information was not treason until it was used. He had told himself many things, and all of them had worn the same face in the dark.

The metal shard trembled in the hide.

A second line formed.

THE OATHLESS KEEPS A SECOND LEDGER.

Marrowgate saw it.

The quartermaster turned white in the lamplight. "Commander."

Ignatz seized the hide. It burned cold against his skin.

The stranger moved at last. "Do not tear it."

"Who are you?"

"Someone who has read the ledger."

"There is no ledger."

"There is always a ledger."

Ignatz brought the hide close to the lamp. The lettering blurred. Beneath the stain, another script showed itself, finer and older, cut into the surface rather than written upon it. He recognized the hand—not the author, but the discipline. Intelligence arranged for a mind that preferred doors to battlefields.

His own mind.

He had kept the Cartel's payments apart from his official records. No names, no signatures. Only marks: iron rings drawn in the margins of dispatches, omissions where truth had been removed, figures that meant nothing unless one knew which column to read.

The shard of metal turned.

For one instant it reflected his face back at him—not features, not flesh, but the hard silhouette of command. Behind that reflection, the archive opened into distances that were not present.

A spire rose from gray vapor.

Fenspire stood in the Gloaming Reach, founded in 57 AS, its single stark height cutting through the dimness. The vision carried no wind, yet banners pulled toward a darkness above them. Men occupied every wall. The record came to him with the merciless clarity of inventory: Fenspire had a garrison of 3,742. Its status was garrisoned.

Then the spire became a coast.

Pale water pressed against cliffs the color of bone. Gloamreach lay there beneath a pall of salt and ash, on the Pale Coast. Its gates were shut. Its roads ended in barriers. No one entered without being counted, and no one left without being marked. Gloamreach had a garrison of 2,483. Its status was quarantined.

Ignatz smelled brine, sickness, and iron.

The vision collapsed.

He jerked back, knocking the lamp. Marrowgate caught it before the flame touched the scattered records.

“You saw it,” Ignatz said.

“I saw nothing.”

“Your hands are shaking.”

“They are always shaking.”

“Do not lie to me.”

Marrowgate looked down at them. “I am a member of the Bleeding Crown.”

The admission seemed to drain the room of air, though it had already been spoken. This time it had weight. It settled between them.

The stranger gave a quiet exhalation. Approval, perhaps. Or hunger.

Ignatz set the hide flat. “What do they want?”

“What everyone wants,” Marrowgate said. “To know whether the door opens.”

“Which door?”

The black shard slid free of the hide and struck the table.

A sound rang through the archive: not metal, not bone, but a note so deep that Ignatz felt it in his teeth.

The old reliquary at the rear of the chamber answered.

Chalice of Ashdeep stood within its iron cradle, dark and solemn, its surface holding no reflection. Ignatz had carried it through ash, mud, and rooms where men begged to be remembered. He knew its silences. This was not one of them.

A seam appeared along the reliquary’s side.

Marrowgate whispered, “That was sealed.”

“Everything is sealed until it is not.”

The stranger reached for the shard.

Ignatz caught his wrist.

The sleeve was empty beneath his fingers.

Not cloth over bone. Not flesh hidden by shadow. Nothing.

The stranger's hood bent toward the grasp. A voice spoke from inside it, close against Ignatz's ear.

"They forged The Hollow Edge in 216 AS."

The shard rose from the table though neither hand touched it.

"The Hollow Edge is a ward," the voice continued. "Attunement to it costs 21."

The blade-shaped darkness drifted toward Chalice of Ashdeep.

Ignatz released the empty sleeve and drew the ward from its sheath at his side. The Hollow Edge came free without a sound. It looked less like a weapon than a length of absence given an edge. The archive recoiled around it. Dust lifted from the shelves. The flame bent away.

Marrowgate retreated until his back met the door.

"What is it?" he asked.

Ignatz did not answer.

The shard hovered between the two artifacts. The Hollow Edge pulled toward it with a pressure that entered Ignatz's wrist and climbed his arm. Attunement to The Hollow Edge cost 21. He had paid the price long ago, though the payment had never felt finished. Every time he called upon the ward, some hollow place within him widened.

The reliquary's seam opened another inch.

From within came a breath of ash.

The stranger said, "The Bleeding Crown has no claim on what sleeps there."

"Then why send me this?"

"Because the Cartel has already paid you."

Marrowgate flinched.

Ignatz's grip tightened on The Hollow Edge. "You know nothing of that."

"I know the shape of your silence."

The words were worse than the accusation. They were not spoken with contempt. Contempt would have left him something to resist. They carried only recognition.

Beyond the barred door, something dragged its fingers down the wood.

Once.

Twice.

A third time, slower.

Marrowgate looked at Ignatz. "Commander, we should leave."

Ignatz saw the corridor in his mind, the unseen watcher waiting beyond the bar, the packet's red script, the wells of Blackport darkening while victors drank beside the dying. He saw ledgers folded into walls and oaths hollowed until only the sound remained.

He had been born in 258 AS. He had outlived every promise made to him, and broken enough of his own that the name Oathless no longer sounded like an insult. It sounded like an inventory.

Chalice of Ashdeep opened.

There was no hollow within it. No relic. No ash.

Only a darkness deeper than the archive, and within that darkness, a voice speaking in his own.

"Ignatz Ashgrove the Oathless," it said.

The stranger bowed.

Marrowgate began to weep without making a sound.

The voice continued.

"Choose which betrayal you will call duty."

The latch lifted again.